

TUESDAY, AUGUST 18, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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GS-II
BY DR. SATVIK BHAN
Starting from
23rd
August, 2026
9540886666
B-20, 2nd Floor, ORN, New Delhi

Happening today

● **KERALA'S VIZHINJAM** International Seaport will begin full-scale export-import operations, a major milestone in maritime and economic development.

● **INDIA-THAILAND** Joint Military Exercise begins in Thailand, with focus on operations in jungle and semi-urban terrain.

EXPRESS special

March to July, Govt sent one blocking order to social media firms every minute

Over half sent to Instagram which was key protest platform; Oct 2024-25, daily takedown average was six, shows Sahyog

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, August 17

● Blocking orders

From March–July 2026

Instagram	-1,00,000
Facebook	-80,000
YouTube	-15,000
TOTAL	-1,95,000

SOURCE: INTERNAL GOVT DATA. NOTE: EACH BLOCKING ORDER MAY COVER MULTIPLE PAGES OF CONTENT OR ACCOUNTS

Jantar Mantar, which began in early June and was called on

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

BRINGS TOGETHER ORGANISATIONAL EXPERIENCE, ENERGY, GRASSROOTS CONNECT: PM

BJP rejig: Goyal treasurer, Smriti, Ram Madhav back

KEY INCLUSIONS AND EXCLUSIONS

IN	 RAM MADHAV, 61: National vice president. An author, RSS ideologue, he was BJP national general secretary from 2014 to 2020 and played crucial role in formation of BJP-PDP government in J&K	 BHARTI PAWAR, 47: One of the six women national vice-presidents appointed. She's a former Union Minister and a tribal leader from Maharashtra
	 SMRITI IRANI, 50: National general secretary. She's a former Lok Sabha MP & Union Minister	 MANPREET SINGH BADAL, 64: National vice president. Seen as one of BJP's leading faces for the coming Assembly elections in Punjab
		VISHNU DATT SHARMA, 55:

All Cells Coordinator. Former BJP state chief of MP, considered a rival to incumbent CM Mohan Yadav in state unit

SWADESH SINGH, 46: National secretary. An emerging face who has been inducted in the team from the Yuva Morcha; considered close to party chief Nitin Nabin

HEMANG JOSHI, 35: Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha president. A young face from Gujarat, he is considered to enjoy confidence of party's top brass

OUT	 AMIT MALVIYA He was chief of the BJP's National IT Department, co-in-charge for West Bengal and member of the National Executive
	 TEJASVI SURYA, 36: He was chief of the BJYM. A second-time Lok Sabha MP from Bangalore South, his exit is being interpreted as the party hitting the refresh button on its youth wing



Protesters celebrate in Ranchi, Monday; they said the agitation would continue until their demand for a CBI probe was fulfilled.

Amid protests, Soren cancels key exam, scraps all tests held by outsourced agency

Rahul writes to CM, urges him to meet protesters

Shubham Tigga & Manoj CG Ranchi, New Delhi, August 17

JHARKHAND CHIEF Minister Hemant Soren on Monday said the state Cabinet has decided to cancel the result for the JSSC-CGL examination, and all exams conducted by testing agency TDPL, in a bid to end a deadlock that has embroiled his government for weeks now. He also ordered a probe into examinations conducted by the state government since 2014.

Soren said ongoing investigations had revealed "shocking" facts and suggested a larger network involving com-

panies linked to the examinations. Earlier in the day, alliance partner Congress had urged Soren to engage with protesting students.

The protesters, however, said they would continue their agitation as long as their demand for a CBI probe into all exams in question remains unfulfilled.

The Soren government's latest decision was, meanwhile, met with resistance from another quarter: those who had qualified for the now-cancelled exam. A group of candidates who had secured government jobs gathered outside Project Bhavan, arguing that they should not be made to suffer for alleged irregularities for which they were not responsible. The administration deployed security personnel as the candidates

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Party bid to hit Refresh in the wake of protests, run-up to key state polls

Vikas Pathak & Liz Mathew New Delhi, August 17

THE BJP'S organisational overhaul signals the return of leaders who had been sidelined, replaces the social media in-charge, and brings in a new youth wing president — all changes that are being viewed within the party as a much-needed refresh after the recent CJP protests and be-

fore crucial state elections. As expected, the party has inducted several leaders from UP and Punjab ahead of polls in the two states.

Among the key changes, the inclusion of Smriti Irani as general secretary is being seen by party insiders as not just a rehabilitation but also a move to add teeth to the party's campaign ahead of the

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Election Commission once had a Dimag! Excel phrase.



NATION

PAGE 9

TWISHA DEATH: AIMS DELHI FINDS 'NO INJURY SUGGESTIVE OF ASSAULT'



Ayush stuns top seed

Ayush Shetty after defeating top seed and defending champion Shi Yuqi of China 21-14, 13-21, 21-19 in the first round of the Badminton World Championships in New Delhi, Monday. **REPORT, PAGE 20**

A third of names could be deleted in Delhi's draft SIR roll of electors

Devansh Mittal New Delhi, August 17

EVERY THIRD name could be struck off in the draft electoral roll for Delhi that will be published next week, official data suggest.

At 8 pm on Monday, the last day of the 'enumeration' phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in

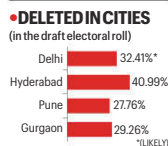
Delhi, enumeration forms of only 97.47 lakh electors had been collected and uploaded to the official portal, data from the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) showed.

This number is only about 67% of the 1.45 crore names on the electoral rolls when the SIR exercise began in Delhi. The remaining 47.62 lakh electors will be marked as "uncollectible" —

a category that includes electors who were absent, who may have moved or died, duplicate entries, or "Other" reasons.

During the enumeration phase, Booth-level Officers (BLOs) went from door to door, distributing enumeration forms, helping electors fill them in, and then uploading the details on the official portal

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



THE CITY **PAGE 4**
BEHIND DELETIONS: DUPLICATION, RELOCATION

● **MEN IDENTIFIED AS HEALTH SCHEME BENEFICIARIES WERE RETIRED GOVT EMPLOYEES**

I-Day tableau to showcase knee surgery success in Punjab on a shaky footing

Kanchan Vasdev & Man Aman Singh Chhina Chandigarh, August 17

THE PUNJAB government is claiming it was operating on, so to speak, a knee-to-knee basis. As per the Opposition, that claim has no legs.

On Saturday, a tableau by the state Health Department at the Independence Day parade in Ferozepur, attended by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, featured five men dancing the bhangra and ident-

ified by the announcer as "beneficiaries who had undergone knee-replacement surgeries under the Mukhmantri Sehat Bima Yojana".

Only, the five are retired Health Department employees, who were dancing on sturdy knees very much their own.

As the facts trickled out, Ferozepur Chief Surgeon Dr Meenakshi Dhin-gra said they did nothing wrong. The participants, she said, were "part of a symbolic

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



Five people, identified by the announcer as 'beneficiaries' of the scheme, dance at the I-Day parade in Ferozepur. EXPRESS

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'No teachers, poor food': After boys, 200 girls block busy road in Lucknow

New Delhi

Govt plans high-rises for bureaucrats near Def Col, Mayur Vihar

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 17

DELHI'S GOVERNMENT housing colonies may soon get a major makeover, with the government planning to redevelop those under the Public Works Department (PWD) pool as high-rise buildings.

PWD Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said the government will demolish the existing flats and construct multi-storied flats as per the Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) policy.

Gulabi Bagh in North Delhi, Kalyanwas in Mayur Vihar and Bahapur near Defence Colony are likely to be the first colonies taken up under the plan.

It will be on the lines of the Centre's General Pool Residential Accommodation (GPRA) and will be self-financed.

The plan

At Gulabi Bagh and Kalyanwas, commercial projects will be developed alongside residential spaces. Singh said that under the TOD policy, around 10% of the total area should be utilised for commercial purposes.

"So, 10% of flats at Gulabi Bagh and Kalyanwas are planned for commercial use to help recover the redevelopment costs. We also have plans to use the entire permissible FAR (Floor Area Ratio) at these two locations and build high-rise buildings. We will keep flats for officials and staff, as per the requirement, and the remaining will be sold," he added.

Revenue generated from these projects will also be used to finance the development of the new Delhi Secretariat complex at ITO, Singh further said.

Unlike Gulabi Bagh and Kalyanwas, the Bahapur project will be purely residential. The existing flats are in poor condition and require immediate redevelopment, Singh said.

"In Bahapur, 160 Type IV and Type VI flats, with bedrooms, halls and kitchens, will be constructed. The tender for this project will be floated by next week. As there is an immediate requirement here,



Parvash Sahib Singh

these will be for residential purposes," Singh said.

This project is expected to cost around Rs 400 crore and will soon be placed before the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) for approval.

What will be built

■ Kalyanwas, Mayur Vihar: The government has 32 acres of land here. Around 70 lakh sq ft of space is planned, including commercial development.

■ Gulabi Bagh: Around 2.25 crore sq ft of space is planned.

■ Bahapur: Around four lakh sq ft of space is planned.

Singh said the projects will be developed on a self-financing model, with the government recovering its construction costs through the sale of flats and commercial space. "These projects will be developed on a self-financing model by selling flats and commercial space to private players. The government's construction cost will be recovered from what we sell. There will be a certain percentage that will remain with the government," he said.

Revenue generated from these projects will also be used to finance the development of the new Delhi Secretariat complex at ITO, Singh further said.

Unlike Gulabi Bagh and Kalyanwas, the Bahapur project will be purely residential. The existing flats are in poor condition and require immediate redevelopment, Singh said.

How government plans to sell the flats

Officials said the minister has asked the General Administration Department (GAD) to submit its requirement for flats

to the PWD.

Once the colonies are redeveloped, the government will advertise flats for sale. The Central government, Central Public Works Department and public sector undertakings (PSUs) will also be able to buy them, Singh said.

"Otherwise, whoever wants to buy it from the market can do so. The market price will be fixed," Singh said.

"For the portion that we want to give to private players in the open market, we will hold an auction and give it to whoever bids the highest," Singh added.

Officials said consultants will be appointed for Gulabi Bagh and Mayur Vihar to prepare the Detailed Project Report, budget estimate, and other aspects of the self-financing model. "Here, three categories of flats — Type II, Type III and Type IV — will be developed, which will take about three to four years," they said.

7 more sites identified

Besides these locations, seven more sites have been identified for redevelopment under the model to optimise land use. These include Probyn Road, Timarpur, Sindhora Khurd, Sindhora Kalan and Vikas Bhawan.

■ Gulabi Bagh, Sindhora Kalan and Sindhora Khurd colonies are located in North Delhi and comprise around 1,200 Type I, II and III government quarters.

■ Probyn Road and Timarpur, near Civil Lines, have 16 Type V residential quarters and 90 Type III quarters.

■ Kalyanwas has 70 Type II government flats.

"As these are big-ticket projects and cannot be constructed solely through public funds, the government has decided to rope in private players. It will give contracts to private companies to construct houses and office complexes and recover the cost by allowing construction of private offices and retail spaces, and possibly even by selling left-over land parcels to private developers," officials said.

DELHI SIR DRAFT ROLLS

Duplication, relocation: Why 1/3rd of electors may get deleted

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 17

DUPLICATE ENTRIES in other states, relocation, and lack of awareness are among the factors that the booth level officers (BLOs) have attributed to the expected deletion of 32.82% of names of electors in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of draft rolls in Delhi.

On Monday, the SIR enumeration phase — in which BLOs conduct door-to-door visits to distribute enumeration forms, electors fill out their details and BLOs upload the details on the EC portal — ended in the city. When the exercise started in June, the city had 1.45 crore names on its electoral rolls. Enumeration forms of around

67.18% of the electorate, or 97.47 lakh electors, have been collected and uploaded onto the portal, as per the officials.

Forms of around 47.62 lakh electors are set to be marked uncollectible — a category that includes people who are absent, have shifted, have died, have duplicate entries, or fall under 'Other' reasons.

"Most of my deletions will be of labourers who had Voter ID here as well as in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Some have even completed the SIR of these states because they want at least one address proof for their villages," said a BLO in East Delhi, who did not want to be named. The BLO was assigned an urban village. He said he had

to mark them absent after a discussion with their neighbours. "Others had found cheaper rental accommodations in nearby villages, or found work at another construction site, so they shifted," he added.

Out of around 1,500 electors assigned to him, he said he had only been able to collect rolls and digitise enumeration forms of around 800. He also estimates that out of the 700 forms he had submitted, around 200 will be sent notices due to a mismatch in names or due to missing documents.

BLO Amit Kumar, 31, who was assigned upscale Kailash Colony, said that he was able to digitise 60% of his enumer-

ation forms. Out of the 40% that he marked uncollectible, he estimates that roughly 30% are marked shifted. "Many people in my area have shifted abroad. Others have shifted to Noida, Gurgaon or some other areas," he said.

Roughly one-fourth of the enumeration forms he has submitted are set to get notices, he pointed out, due to no linkage between found or name changes or mismatch in spellings. "It was difficult to get many to participate at all. They were just not interested at all. I went to their houses 6-7 times when we are only supposed to go just twice. When I told them that their name can be struck off the electoral list, some even said they have no problem," Kumar said.

Another BLO in West Delhi agreed with Kumar, saying that many people were not aware of the ongoing exercise and therefore, were reluctant to participate. "They just did not care enough. Even many educated people did not fill their forms and turn them to us," the BLO said.

Officials in the Chief Electoral Officer's office previously told The Indian Express that they expected around 30% to 40% of names across Delhi to be deleted from the electoral rolls. "Delhi has a large population of migrant labourers, government employees and private-sector professionals, all of whom move frequently and often do not update their addresses," an official had said.

WORKERS SAY WON'T CALL OFF STRIKE UNTIL DEMANDS ARE MET

'We want justice': Protests enter second day after sanitation worker is stabbed to death; 1 arrested

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, August 17

"WE WANT JUSTICE," said a teary-eyed Sumita, 37, as she sat cross-legged on a road in a street near the Emergency Block at the Lal Bahadur Shastri (LBS) Hospital on Monday. Her brother, Anil Kumar, a 27-year-old Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) contractual worker, was stabbed to death in East Delhi's Kalyanpur in the early hours of Sunday morning.

Along with her father Ram Asare, Sumita, her family members, and hundreds of sanitation workers, and Kalyanpur ML A Kuldeep Kumar gathered at the protest site Monday, demanding Rs 1 crore in compensation for the family, a government job for a relative and strict punishment for the accused as their protest entered the second day. Senior district police officers and paramilitary personnel were deployed at the hospital in view of the demonstration.

Recalling the last time she met Anil, Sumita said, "I saw him two days ago. He came to my house... and we had a meal together... he mentioned that his salary was about to get credited. He was happy. But he is gone now. Who will take care



The protest on Monday; (right) victim Anil's father, TASHI TORGYAL

of the family? That is why we are demanding a government job for his elder brother."

The MCD Sanitation Workers Union has also gone on a strike — they said it won't be called off until all demands are met.

According to the police, Anil, who worked as a helper, was standing near a garbage van on Sunday when the attacker approached and assaulted him with a knife. The incident was captured on a CCTV camera.

Hours after the murder, Anil's family began a sit-in protest outside the mortuary at Lok Nayak (LBS) Hospital, refusing to accept his body after the post-mortem as they demanded the arrest of the accused.



Police arrested the suspect, identified as Nihal alias "Kulla", 52, from the Kalyanpur area on Monday afternoon. During questioning, Nihal allegedly told investigators that he had intended to target Anil and the garbage van driver, Gulshan, as he suspected an illicit relationship between Gulshan and his wife. "Nihal revealed that he tracked the vehicle early on Sunday. In a fit of rage, he attacked Anil, who often accompanied Gulshan. Officers are trying to recover the knife allegedly used in the crime," a police officer said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (East) Rajeev Kumar said an FIR was registered after the incident and multiple teams were deployed to trace the suspect. "The accused repeatedly evaded arrest but was taken into custody on Monday," he said, adding that police were examining CCTV footage and questioning witnesses to reconstruct the sequence of events.

Garbage collection services remain shut

The MCD Safai Karamchari Union has said it will keep the small garbage collection vehicles, called auto-tippers, off the roads until their demands are met. "One of our brothers was murdered. This is not just a one-off case. Our demand is that our workers be given protection. Some schemes should be developed so that no such fatal attacks can happen in the future. No one should be able to exploit them. Secondly, our demand is that a government job be given to a member of this family and its 1 crore compensation be provided," Vijay Untwal, chairperson of the union, said.

He added, "If this administration doesn't listen to us, we will go on a strike and stop work in all of Delhi."

AAP MLA Kuldeep Kumar,

who has been participating in the protests, claimed that no one from the government has been in touch with the family. "The family and sanitation workers have been sitting here since 7 am on Sunday. No representative from the government has come to meet them. This is clear discrimination. If a sanitation worker is not safe while working in the streets and neighbourhoods today, how will he clean?" he said.

Surendra Kumar Gautam, Anil's cousin, warned that their protest would also go on if the family's demands were not met and said another demonstration was planned for Tuesday.

Several protesting sanitation workers alleged poor working conditions. "We pick up garbage while people are still sleeping... Now, we are afraid if we'll get to see our family after our shift," said Deepak, 40.

Vikas, a garbage van driver, said, "The government recently ordered that everyone's salary should be increased. Our salary has not increased. The agency for which we are working says that if we speak up, they will fire us from the job."

The daily-wage workers claim they don't get any day-off. They don't get money for days that they don't show up.

Delhi Master Plan 2047 sharpens focus on 'Right to Walk'

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 17

ON AVERAGE, a Delhiite walks just 1.6 km a day. As far as cycling goes, the daily average comes down to 3.6 km, according to the Delhi Master Plan 2047. In its 20-year vision for the Capital, the plan emphasises on promoting "Right to Walk", which emerged as a critical talking point following a recent Supreme Court ruling in this regard. The plan renews the focus of authorities on a citywide network of safe, shaded and universally accessible pathways, along with pedestrian-only zones and improved links with public transport.

trips, pedestrians take up 35% of the share while 7% are cycle-rickshaw trips. Public transport trips — such as Delhi Metro and buses — constitute 24% of the total trips on average.

However, the plan has also highlighted that the growth of regional centres and the relative ease of accessibility has led to an increase in the average road and public transport trip length from 6 km in 2007 to 10.9 km in 2018. At 16.7 km, the plan has highlighted Metro's role in long-distance commutes, while two-wheelers, cars and buses are best utilised for medium distances of 8-14 km, as per the data.

14 proposals

To encourage people to walk, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has prepared 14 proposals — these at the implementation stage with the road-owning agencies concerned, according to officials. "These will be integrated with

plans for traffic management, Multi-Modal Integration (MMI) and others... Walk Plans for other priority areas are being prepared in consultation with stakeholders," said an official, adding that the authority has initially identified 24 priority areas for the preparation of Walk Plans. For road infrastructure overhaul, the plan proposes barrier-free non-motorised transport infrastructure such as footpaths and cycle tracks. Pedestrian zones and cycle crossings are to be provided wherever possible, while pedestrian crossings — pedestrian-operated, light-controlled road crossings — near schools and markets are proposed to improve safety.

"Traffic-calming measures like Multi-Utility Zones (MUZs) to accommodate street furniture, that is seating, garbage bins, signage, public conveniences such as restrooms, childcare rooms and drinking water,

street vendors and kiosks at regular intervals, service lines such as gas pipelines, optical fibre, among others, provision for parking and Public Cycle Sharing (PBS) systems, while ensuring that walk walking space is available for pedestrians," said the official.

In areas with high pedestrian footfall, including commercial areas, heritage precincts and areas identified for 24x7 economic activity, agencies can identify pedestrian-only zones, the plan has underlined.

The plan also proposes continuous active-travel networks connecting cultural hubs and other active-travel corridors along roads with a right of way of more than 30 metres, subject to feasibility. Officials said that new developments under landpooling, transit-oriented development and regeneration schemes will also be treated as Active Travel Areas.

"Cycling along highways,

greenways along natural drains and the Yamuna are also proposed as part of the network. Transit stations will be designed with cycle parking and pick-up and drop-off facilities for public and private vehicles, taxis and intermediate public transport," said officials.

It also talks about removal of encroachments, illegal parking and unauthorised structures (including religious structures) from footpaths and Non-Motorised Transport lanes, which shall be taken up on priority.

For developing land-pooling areas, the plan separately proposes an incremental public transport network comprising new bus routes, bus rapid transit system (BRTS) and high-speed rail routes. Metro systems may be introduced along specific corridors, while Urban Extension Roads are proposed to function as mass-transit corridors connecting these areas with the rest of Delhi.

Two including minor killed as fire breaks out at West Delhi building

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 17

TWO PERSONS, including a minor, were killed after a suspected blast in an e-rickshaw battery triggered a fire at a building in West Delhi's Raghubir Nagar in the early hours of Monday, police said.

Police said that the victims were identified as Md Sufed (17) and Md Sahmad (38), who hailed from Bhagalpur in Bihar.

Sufed lived with his father, Md Naseeb, and maternal uncle Sahmad — all e-rickshaw drivers, police said.

The victims were charging the portable batteries of their vehicles on the premises of the building when the incident happened, officers said.

Sahmad's brother Md Rehman said he came to know about the incident around 6 pm Monday. "It appears that the



Deceased Md Sahmad

batteries were being charged here. We do not have any other details yet. People told us that a large number of batteries were being charged here and that there was a blast, after which they died. This is negligence," he said.

"Our father also sleeps in this building. However, he had slept at another house in the area yesterday. It is a miracle... he too, like my brother and my nephew, could have been a vic-

Police say the victims were charging the portable batteries of their e-rickshaws on the building premises

tim," Rehman said. Police said that officers reached the spot after receiving a PCR call regarding the incident. They found that the victims had sustained injuries. They were rushed to Gurgaon Singh Hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

A team from the Delhi Fire Services also reached the spot, after which the blaze was brought under control.

Police said that the exact cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained, adding that further inquiry is underway.

• BUNDU HALEEM WAS STARTED BY NAIMUDDIN'S GRANDFATHER. FOR THREE GENERATIONS, THAT'S THE ONLY DISH THE FAMILY HAS SOLD

A stall near Jama Masjid selling haleem and blessings for more than 70 years

Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, August 17

BACK IN 1953, Naimuddin's grandfather started a small food business in a lane close to Jama Masjid. There was only one dish on the menu — haleem. But the lack of variety was no handicap — customers loved the robust, deeply satisfying flavours of his slow-cooked mutton-and-lentils stew.

More than 70 years on, the little shop in a lane close to Karim's hotel retains its reputation. Naimuddin continues to sell the only dish that his grandfather ever cooked. On most days, he runs out by 4.30 pm. "Our work is *dada ilahi* (an-

cestral)," Naimuddin told The Indian Express. "Dada aisa sold a portion for *chadar joda* (25 paisa)." Naimuddin sells haleem for Rs 50 a plate. But he turns away no one — those who can't afford a full plate can have a small portion for even Rs 10.

His haleem is not merely something that he sells for profit, Naimuddin said — it is a blessing from his grandfather and father. His shop bears his name, Naim Bhai Haleem Wale, but also that of his father — "Bundu Haleem".

At the stall, Naimuddin stands behind a large pot of haleem simmering gently on a coal *chulha*. A second pot sits to his left, ready to feed the first

once it runs low. He makes 25-30 kg of haleem six days a week, Naimuddin said. "I don't open on *Tumra* (Fridays) and *ding Ramza* (Fridays). I begin well before 4 am, the haleem is ready by 11 am, and is over by 4.30 pm. "Some days, the pot runs empty by 3 pm," he said.

The recipe and ingredients haven't changed since the time his grandfather made the dish, Naimuddin said — pounded wheat, broken wheat, turmeric, chili, salt, garam masala, lentils, and meat, typically cut of mutton from the neck, cheek and tongue. "It is extremely time-consuming and difficult to make this, that's the reason not many take up the task," he



Naimuddin's sells his haleem for Rs 50 a plate, but if you can't afford that, he will give you a smaller portion for less. REVA THAKKAR

said. Traditionally, haleem is served with flatbread, but Naimuddin has no time to make anything other than the dish. "People are welcome to get

their own roti, bread or rice to eat with it," he said.

Haleem traces its origins to harees, a dish that travelled to the Deccan with the Hadhrami

Arab soldiers who served the Nizams of Hyderabad. The dish evolved over time, as generations of Indian chefs added lentils, ghee, and spices to it.

In Delhi, you can get haleem at shops in Old Delhi, Nizamuddin Basti, and the Hyderabad pockets in Zakir Nagar and Jangpura. Bundu Haleem, Naimuddin's stall on Matia Mahal Road, is among the capital's oldest continuously-running haleem places.

After finishing Class 12 in 1994, Naimuddin, now 51, got married, and briefly trained

with the Delhi Police, and taught at a Civil Defence Centre. "I wanted a government job, but life had different plans. My father's health began to fail, and seeing his distress, I joined him," he said, adding, "I don't want to pass the stall down to my daughters. They are successful in their lives — one practises law, the other works at a car showroom, and two are in school."

To hear that Bundu Haleem may not survive its owner would break many hearts. On the rainy Tuesday that The Indian Express went to the stall,

Yasmeen had come all the way from Jahangirpuri with her husband and their one-year-old child to enjoy the dish. "We have been coming for the last five years," she said.

Mohammed Arif, a welder, has been coming every day for the past six years. "Mera roz ka dinna ka khana hai," he has the haleem with some rotis that he picks up from a restaurant.

For Abdul Kayyum, who has been parking his autorickshaw at the Jama Masjid stand for 37 years, "Naim bhai" has become a close friend. Gulfam (36), Yasmeen's husband, said the first time he ate the stall's little bowl with his father: "The taste is still the same."



Engaging Gen Z

UNDERLINING The new-found significance of the youth following protests in Delhi, BJP national president Nitin Nabin is scheduled to hold a three-hour interaction with Gen Z representatives during his trip to Vizag on Tuesday. Of the seven separate events which he is scheduled to attend during his stay, Nabin's three-hour-long engagement with the youth is second only to his meeting with the state executive, which is scheduled for four-and-a-half hours. Nabin will also interact with district-level leaders and other office-bearers for an hour and with elected representatives such as MPs, MLAs and MLCS for two hours.

Film Fan

THE NEWLY appointed Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha president and Vadodara MP Hemang Joshi has a somewhat little-known interest — organising film festivals. He organised a film festival on 'Operation Sindoor' on October 25, 2025, and then a short film festival on 'Har ghar deshi ghar swadeshi' in December 2025. He is learnt to have organised many other thematic short-film festivals with youth organisations and foundations.

Date Awaited

FOURTEEN MONTHS after the first annual general meeting of the newly reconstituted Prime Ministers' Museum & Library Society was held in June last year, the administration is yet to fix a day for this year's meeting. The 47th annual general meeting in 2025 was chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and also attended by Union ministers Nirmala Sitharaman, Dharmendra Pradhan, Ashwini Vaishnaw and Jagendra Singh Shekhawat.

Kishor takes oath as Bankipur MLA, calls it 'big responsibility'

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 17

JAN SURAJ Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor on Monday took oath as Bankipur MLA at Bihar Assembly, calling it "a matter of great honour". Kishor took the oath in the presence of Speaker Prem Kumar.

"It is a matter of great honour to be part of a House that was represented by Sri Krishna Singh, Anugrah Narayan Singh, Kedar Pandey, Karpoori Thakur, Lalu Prasad, Nitish Kumar, Ram Vilas Paswan, and Sushil Kumar Modi. Being a member of the Bihar Assembly also brings a big responsibility. I will try to live up to people's expectations," he told reporters in Patna.

Kishor defeated BJP Neeraj Kumar Sinha to win July 30 Bankipur bypoll, ending the ruling party's three-decade-long hold on the constituency. The bypoll was necessitated by BJP national president Nitin Nabin vacating the seat after being nominated to Rajya Sabha.

After taking the oath, Kishor headed off to address public meetings in his constituency. He has been meeting residents across every ward under Bankipur to reiterate his election promises, having already covered 14 of the 24 wards.

The pledge that has garnered the most attention is his promise of 10,000 jobs for the people of his constituency.

2.08 crore Maharashtra voters may be left out of SIR draft rolls

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, August 17

FORMS FOR at least 2.08 crore of Maharashtra's 9.79 crore voters — more than one in five — could not be collected during the door-to-door enumeration exercise under SIR of electoral rolls, which ended at 5 pm Monday. The figure is from the 10 am bulletin on the final day, and is likely to change. Nearly half of these are from Thane, Mumbai and Pune.

Names for which forms remained uncollected will not feature in the draft electoral roll to be published on August 24. "This is not permanent deletion from the electoral roll. The August 24 list is a draft, and is likely to change. Nearly half of these are from Thane, Mumbai and Pune.

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'Must conduct NRC before Census': Manipur students protest, announce two-day strike

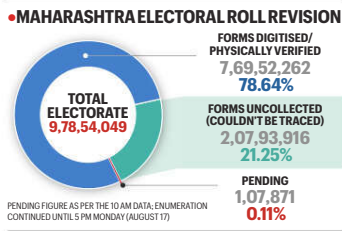
Leivon Jimmy
Imphal, August 17

THE 'CAMPAIGN for Just and Fair Delimitation (JFD) Student Wing' has announced a two-day general strike in Manipur from midnight on August 17, demanding implementation of NRC before the commencement of the Census exercise in the state.

The house-listing phase of Census 2027 is scheduled to begin with self-enumeration from August 17. The main house-listing operation is scheduled from September 1 to 30 this year.

The JFD, a conglomerate of civil bodies, is demanding a halt on any form of Census-related exercise until illegal immigrants are identified, using 1951 as the base cut-off year.

The strike comes amid growing protests in Imphal and across valley districts against preparations for Census. Students, market bodies and civil



PENDING FIGURE AS PER THE 10 AM DATA. ENUMERATION CONTINUED UNTIL 5 PM MONDAY (AUGUST 17)

ber 23 to seek inclusion or correction. Eligible persons can apply for inclusion as voters during this period," said an official. During the SIR, BLOs visited households with pre-filled forms and collected them for verification and digitisation. A form recorded as uncollected does not by itself mean the voter is dead, has shifted, is a

duplicate or is ineligible. The voter may have moved, may not have been at the address when the BLO called, or may not have been traced there.

The data shows 2,07,93,916 forms, or 21.25% of the state's electorate, in the uncollected category. Across Maharashtra, 7,69,52,262 forms, or 78.64%, had been digitised as of the

10 am bulletin.

The problem is concentrated in the largest urban districts. Forms for 94.47 lakh voters in Thane, Mumbai City, Mumbai Suburban and Pune account for 45.4% of all uncollected forms, although the four districts hold only about 27.5% of the state's electorate.

Thane has the highest share, with forms for 28.88 lakh of its 74.51 lakh voters, or 38.77%, uncollected. Mumbai City has 9.60 lakh, or 37.57%, Mumbai Suburban 26.99 lakh, or 34.48%, and Pune 28.99 lakh, or 31.92%.

The numbers are also high in Nagpur, Palghar and Raigad. Nagpur has 14.06 lakh uncollected forms, or 30.32%, Palghar 6.87 lakh, or 28.88%, and Raigad 5.91 lakh, or 23.43%. Together, these seven districts account for about 1.21 crore, or 58.3%, of all uncollected forms, while holding about 37% of the electorate.

Rural districts show the opposite pattern. In Hingoli, forms

for 8.82% of voters remain uncollected. The figure is 9.10% in Buldhana, 9.93% in Ratnagiri and 10.62% in Latur. In Thane, forms for nearly four in 10 voters could not be collected. In Hingoli, it was fewer than one in 10.

Officials have previously cited migration and changes of address among the reasons for the high urban numbers of uncollected forms. In Mumbai, Thane and Pune, frequent movement between residences can make it difficult for BLOs to find electors at addresses recorded in the roll, officials said. The uncollected figure has risen from 1.80 crore on August 12 to 2.08 crore on Monday, an increase of about 27.3 lakh in five days.

The 10 am bulletin showed around 1.08 lakh electors outside digitised and uncollected categories, with their final status yet to be reflected. On that basis, 2.08 crore is the minimum number of electors likely to be left out of the August 24 draft.

Over 73 lakh names dropped in Telangana SIR draft rolls

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 17

AROUND 73.39 lakh voters in Telangana have been deleted under Special Intensive Revision (SIR) as draft rolls were released Monday.

Meanwhile, 92 lakh voters will be sent notices. Chief Electoral Officer C Sudarshan Reddy said on Monday.

Reddy said the Election Commission has collected 78.30% of enumeration forms from a total of 3.38 crore voters.

Apart from 73.39 lakh voters who were deleted from the draft rolls, about 60 lakh had anomalies in the electoral rolls, and another 32 lakh electors remain unmapped — meaning that they couldn't be linked to the 2002 voters' list.

This means that as many as 92 lakh electors will now get notices.

Of the state's 3.38 crore voters, 9.22 crore (2.78%) have died, 57.46,803 (16.99%) were found to have shifted permanently or were absent, and 6,70,203 electors (1.98%) were found to have been enrolled in multiple places in the electoral roll.

According to the Telangana Chief Electoral Officer, BLOs did not get back the rest of the enumeration forms because "the electors became electors in other states and UTs, were not found in existence, or did not submit the form till August 10, were not willing to register as elector for some reason or the other".

Electors who were unable to submit their enumeration forms can now file Form 6 for inclusion during the claims and objections period. The period for filing claims and objections is between August 17 and September 16. The notice phase and disposal of claims and objections will be held between August 17 and October 15.

BJP's new social media head: Will ensure right info reaches Gen Z

THE BJP on Monday appointed **Deepak Mhaskey** as the party's new national social media convener, replacing Amit Malviya.

In an interview with **Jayprakash S Naidu**, Mhaskey speaks about his role and his plans for the party, among other issues. Excerpts:

What would be your main focus as BJP's national social media convener?

My focus will be to tackle the fake narrative spread by the Opposition, which uses AI in reels to twist facts and mislead people. We have been creating positive content and taking it to people. I will try and add momentum to this.

You replace Amit Malviya, who held the post for over a decade. What would you like to do differently?

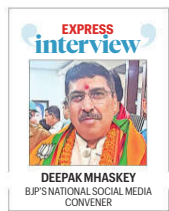
I have worked under him and served as the coordinator for Chhattisgarh. I have learnt a lot from him. I spoke to him today and sought his guidance on how to take his work forward. I hope to take this battle forward and give our work new dimensions.

Malviya was very active on social media. How will your approach be?

Every person has their own style. He had his own approach. I will follow things I have learnt from him but my will also see my way of functioning.

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests seem to have dented the party and similar agitations may happen closer to elections. How do you plan to handle them?

Giving responses to protests is a normal part of political discourse.



DEEPAK MHASKEY
BJP'S NATIONAL SOCIAL MEDIA CONVENOR

course. We will deal with issues as and when they arise. As I said earlier, we will make efforts to prevent the spread of fake information and narratives.

Do you have any Gen Z-specific strategy?

We have a meeting on August 22, where we will get instructions. We will plan our strategy accordingly, will ensure the right information reaches Gen Z.

Every state has its own way to communicate. We need to make use of different social media platforms. We will plan campaigns accordingly.

Will state party units have the power to post content or will information flow be controlled centrally under your leadership?

Both the centre as well as state units have their own roles. We will work in tandem.

Do you think state units should have more power?

In BJP, it is not about power. We work in coordination and our roles are decided by the party leadership.

Do you see any weaknesses in the BJP's social media cell?

There are no weaknesses.

Will try to know the mind of youth and mobilise their energy, says new BJYM chief

Aditi Raja & Jatin Anand
Vadodra, New Delhi, August 17

BJP'S FIRST-TIME MP from Vadodra, Hemang Joshi, who was appointed the national president of Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) on Monday, plans to take the party's youth outreach beyond conventional political messaging, focusing on the concerns of Gen Z, social media narratives, and direct engagement ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* after his appointment, Joshi said: "We have to keep the youth away from negative narratives and take them closer to the path of Viksit Bharat envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi."

He said the need is to understand the "game of narratives in the era of social media" and "how we set up a narrative". In 2024, when he was 33, Joshi replaced two-time MP Ranjanbhai Bhatt from Vadodra, a constituency that Prime Minister Narendra Modi won in 2014.

A former vice-chairman of the Vadodra Municipal Corporation's school board, Joshi is a physiotherapist and also has a Master's degree in human resource management. He is believed to be close to BJP's national leaders as well as the RSS.

Joshi said his priority would be to "break barriers that seem to exist between national leaders and ground karyakartas". "I will try to know the mind of the youth. For this, we need to interact with them by breaking protocols, if needed. I aim to mobilise youth energy... to change the scenario rather than just focusing on the negativity," he added. He said connecting with the young people when they have concerns and relaying the "feedback from the



Vadodra MP Hemang Joshi

Hemang Joshi said his priority would be to 'break barriers that seem to exist between national leaders and ground karyakartas'

ground to the leadership in a timely manner" is imperative. Joshi, who is a known Rahul Gandhi baiter on social media as well as in Parliament, said: "I've recall Rahul Gandhi's younger days... he worked as a karyakarta now when he is older, he dresses in T-shirts to woo the youngsters... Our outreach, however, will be genuine to address the concerns of the youth."

Joshi, who was appointed Gujarat president of the BJYM in December last year, said he would resign from the state post and "work as a karyakarta in the state" once the decision on his successor is taken.

Joshi also has a distinguished image in terms of international exposure. He represented India at the inaugural BRICS Cultural Forum in 2024 in Russia and the 2nd BRICS Traditional Values Forum in Brazil in 2025.

As a member of an all-party parliamentary delegation, he visited various countries for diplomatic outreach in the aftermath of Operation Sindoor in May 2025.

Ahead of 2027 Assembly poll battle in Uttarakhand, why BJP has set its sights on 23 seats it lost in 2022

Dhama to oversee preparations in Khatima, a seat he lost in 2022

Lalmuni Verma
Lucknow, August 17

THE BJP has tasked senior leaders with overseeing organisational work in the 23 constituencies it lost in the 2022 Uttarakhand elections, as part of a micro-management strategy aimed at strengthening the party ahead of the 2027 polls.

Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, who lost his traditional Khatima seat in the 2022 elections, has been assigned the constituency. He will oversee the party's programmes there, assess the political situation and work towards creating a favourable atmosphere for the BJP ahead of the next Assembly elections.

The move comes amid concerns within the BJP over anti-

incumbency, particularly among Gen Z voters. The Congress had won 19 of the 23 seats the BJP lost in 2022, while the BSP and Independents won two seats each.

These leaders will visit their assigned constituencies, assess the political situation, draw up strategies with local party leaders and create an atmosphere conducive to the BJP's victory in 2027, a senior BJP leader said.

The BJP won 47 of Uttarakhand's 70 seats in 2022 to retain power. Although Dhami lost Khatima, he was later elected from Champawat in a bypoll, allowing him to continue as CM.

"Khatima, Dhami's hometown, is also a constituency he frequently visits. He is familiar

with the people and can comfortably devote time to meeting them and addressing the issues of the public as well as BJP workers," the leader said.

BJP's central leadership will take a final call closer to the 2027 elections on whether Dhami contests from Khatima or Champawat. However, party insiders believe he should contest from Champawat, where he won after losing Khatima.

BJP state chief and Rajya Sabha MP Mahendra Bhatt has been assigned Piran Kaliyar, a Muslim-dominated seat in Haridwar district the party has never won. Congress's Furkan Ahmed has held the seat since 2012.

Another difficult constituency, Manglaur, has been assigned to RS MP and BJP na-

Shivkumar and submitted a petition noting that about half the names of Bengaluru voters would be removed from the draft rolls. "In nearly 3,000 booths in Karnataka, deletion rates exceed 60%," the organisations' petition stated.

The delegation was led by actor Prakash Raj, who had recently flagged that he was marked as shifted during the enumeration phase and alleged it was a ploy to delete voters. The group urged government to seek a three-month extension of SIR and urged it to approach the Supreme Court if necessary.

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'Black money compromises democracy': SC orders speedy probes, trials

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 17

OBSERVING THAT black money in the electoral process compromises democracy, rule of law and the process itself, the Supreme Court on Monday strongly batted for timely probes and conclusion of criminal cases relating to recovery of ill-gotten money during the elections in the country.

Issuing a slew of directions, a bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N K Singh said, "Black money in the electoral process is the issue with which we are herein concerned, is one such aspect that compromises democracy, rule of law and the electoral process itself," the bench said.

The order was passed by the bench on a plea filed by Karnataka government related to the 2014 Lok Sabha polls, where large scale of black money was seized during elections in Bellary district.

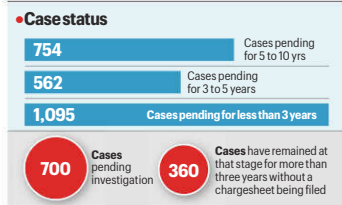
Over 4,000 cases pending against MPs, MLAs: Amicus curiae to SC

Vineet Bhatta
New Delhi, August 17

A TOTAL of 4,192 cases against sitting and former MPs and MLAs are pending trial across the country with 519 cases pending for more than a decade, according to a report submitted before the Supreme Court by Senior Advocate Vijay Hansaria, appointed amicus curiae in a PIL seeking expeditious disposal of criminal cases against MPs and MLAs.

Another 700 cases are pending investigation while 360 have remained at that stage for more than three years without a chargesheet being filed.

The figures form part of Hansaria's 22nd Amicus report. It notes that the 4,192 figure is based on information received from High Courts and their websites; the Allahabad High Court did not submit a report and its figure of 1,171 cases is from its website as of February 2024. The High Court websites, in total, show 4,442 pending cases.



The report states that Chief Ministers of 14 of 28 states have criminal cases against them pending trials. Telangana CMA Revanth Reddy faces the highest number of cases at 89, followed by West Bengal CM Suvedu Adhikari (29), Karnataka CM D K Shivakumar, Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu (both 19) and Kerala CM V D Satheesan (18).

Of the 4,192 cases, 754 have been pending for 5 to 10 years, 562 for 3 to 5 years, and 1,095 for less than 3 years, it states. Among the states/High Courts with the highest reported pendency are Uttar Pradesh (171), Kerala (543), Bihar (373), Maharashtra (364) and Odisha (330). The cut-off dates for these figures vary. The report says the number of cases pending trial has fluctuated but remained above 4,000 since 2018 — rising from 4,075 in December 2018 to 5,140 in November 2022 before settling at 4,192 in July 2026.

In 2017, the Supreme Court ordered the setting up of 12 special courts in 10 states, UTs for speedy trials in criminal cases involving legislators. In December 2018, it directed that one designated Sessions Court and one designated Magisterial Court be identified in every district to try cases on priority.

In November 2023, the SC directed the Chief Justices of all HCs to register suo motu cases to monitor the early disposal of such cases and empowered special benches to issue directions for expeditious trials.

The matter was referred to a three-judge Bench in February 2025 after the previous amicus report highlighted the absence of effective monitoring by most HCs. It has been listed for hearing before the three-judge Bench on August 18.

Hansaria said that despite top court's directions, the pendency had remained at roughly

the same level and attributed the delay to designated courts being burdened with regular judicial work, repeated adjournments, non-appearance of accused persons, delays in securing witnesses and inadequate monitoring by High Courts.

The amicus recommended that designated courts exclusively conduct trials involving lawmakers until their backlog is cleared; that cases pending for more than 3 years be heard day-to-day; and that courts issue NBWs where an accused lawmaker fails to appear on two consecutive dates. The report also proposes a nodal prosecution officer for securing witnesses and requiring real-time uploading of case data and order sheets on HC websites.

He has also sought that trials be completed within one year of framing of charges, monthly monitoring by HCs of cases pending for more than 3 years and "micro-monitoring" of individual delayed cases.

BRIEFLY



Firefighters douse the blaze that broke out in the basement of Ayakar Bhavan, the Income Tax office in Mumbai. GANESH SHIRSEKAR

MAHARASHTRA

1,500 evacuated, 29 rescued from fire at Ayakar Bhavan in Mumbai

A FIRE broke out in the basement of Ayakar Bhavan in Churchgate that serves as the headquarters of the Income Tax department in Mumbai on Monday, leading to a major evacuation of around 1,500 people from the seven-storey building. "Nearly 1,500 people were present and all were evacuated quickly... 29 people were left stranded for some time because of the smoke..." a senior Mumbai Fire Brigade official said. According to officials, the fire broke out at 1.57 pm in the basement storage cabins near Churchgate station. EMS

Prayagraj: Three Kanwariyas die in road accident

THREE KANWARIYAS died in Prayagraj, after their speeding motorcycle collided with an auto-rickshaw, police said on Monday. DCP (Ganga Nagar) Kuldeep Gunawat said Shiv Prakash, a Tharwar resident, died on the spot while Ashok Kumar from Phaphamau, and Lallu were rushed to SRN Hospital, where they died during treatment. According to police, the motorcycle's high speed and slippery road conditions following rain caused the accident, causing the two-wheeler to skid and hit the auto-rickshaw. CM Yogi Adityanath took cognisance of the accident and expressed condolences to the bereaved families. PTI

Man, toddler die in roof collapse due to rain in UP

A 25-YEAR-OLD man and his three-year-old nephew died after being buried under the debris of a collapsed house roof in Shahjahanpur district of Uttar Pradesh, amidst relentless rainfall since Sunday night, police said. A woman was also critically injured in the incident, which occurred on Monday morning. Circle Officer (Po-wayan) Pravin Malik said in Mudiya Kurniyat village, a 'kutchi' house was built next to the one whose roof collapsed. The height of the 'kutchi' house exceeded that of the pucca house. Due to the rain, the 'kutchi' house fell on the pucca house's roof as it had no iron beam to support it. PTI

Navy to lease two new MQ-9B Sea Guardian unmanned aircraft from US firm

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 17

THE MINISTRY of Defence on Monday inked a US \$1.943 crore contract with American firm General Atomics Aeronautical to lease two MQ-9B Sea Guardian High-Altitude Long-Endurance (HALE) Remotely Piloted Aircraft Systems (RPAS) for the Indian Navy for 30 months.

In a statement, the Defence ministry said the contract was signed in the presence of A Anbarasu, Additional Secretary and Director General (Acquisition), Department of Defence. It said the MQ-9B Sea Guardian HALE RPAS, equipped with advanced systems, state-of-the-art sensors and sophisticated payloads, will significantly enhance the Indian Navy's Maritime Domain Awareness capabilities.

"The systems will provide persistent intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance coverage over vast areas of the maritime domain, strengthening India's ability to monitor and respond to developments across the Indian Ocean Region," it added.

In December last year, the Ministry of Defence approved the leasing of HALE RPAS for the Navy. Currently, the Navy operates two MQ-9As on lease, which were procured in 2020 in the backdrop of tensions between India and China for a period of one year, and their

lease period was subsequently extended.

With the addition of two new high-altitude long-endurance systems, the Navy's inventory will increase to four units. This expansion will provide a greater operational coverage for the Navy in both the eastern and western regions. Until now, the limited number of just two HALE RPAS restricted simultaneous coverage of both fronts.

It is learnt that while the lease of the existing RPAS will expire after a certain period, the leases of the two new RPAS will continue until deliveries of the 31 MQ-9B HALE RPAS begin. It is further learnt that the new RPAS will have almost the same configuration as the 31 MQ-9Bs which are being procured, as against the existing HALE RPAS.

In 2024, India and the United States inked a deal of around \$3.5 billion or over Rs 28,000 crore to procure 31 MQ-9B HALE RPAS for the Indian armed forces. Apart from ISR roles, they can also carry out precision strikes on strategic targets in mountains and the maritime domain during long-endurance missions.

A global MRO facility will be set up in India under contract with General Atomics to assemble some of the MQ-9Bs in India to support India's long-term goals to boost indigenous defence capabilities. A certain percentage of the components for the drones will be sourced indigenously.



Nepal honours Army Chief

Nepal President Ram Chandra Paudel (right) confers the honorary rank of General of the Nepali Army upon Indian Army Chief General Dhiraj Sethi in Kathmandu on Monday. PTI

Over 80 FIRs, 253 arrests made in pan-India crackdown on Shahzad Bhatti Network: MHA

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 17

SECURITY AGENCIES have busted an alleged terror syndicate linked to the Pakistan-based Shahzad Bhatti Network (SBN), detaining 253 people across 14 states ahead of Independence Day, officials said on Monday.

Officials claimed the recoveries point to direct cross-border links. The recoveries allegedly include IEDs, grenades bearing Pakistan Ordnance Factory markings, pistols, live cartridges and CCTV cameras said

to have been used for espionage.

"The operation carried out on August 12 with state police forces was aimed at preventing alleged SBN-linked disruptions and subversive attacks around Independence Day. The action was coordinated through a real-time intelligence-sharing system and led to fresh FIRs in Delhi and Karnataka," a MHA spokesperson said.

According to officials, the crackdown led to 62 detentions in Uttar Pradesh, 52 in Haryana, 51 in Delhi, 44 in Punjab, 15 in Rajasthan, eight in Maharashtra,

five in Uttarakhand, three each in Karnataka, Gujarat and Bihar, and two each in Telangana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, and Kerala.

"More than 80 FIRs and over 200 arrests have been recorded against SBN members and alleged associates under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Arms Act, Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, and the Explosive Substances Act," the spokesperson said.

The Shahzad Bhatti Network is alleged to be a Pakistan-

JD(S) leader held for assaulting traffic police

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 17

THE CITY police have arrested Janata Dal (Secular) state General Secretary Manjunath alias Gottigere Manja for allegedly assaulting a traffic police constable on Sunday.

Traffic police constable Arun M Badagowda was at work in Hulimavu area, when he gestured for Manja's car to stop. This, the police said, enraged Manja, who caught hold of Arun's collar and kicked him.

Based on a complaint filed by Arun, the Hulimavu police registered a case and arrested Manja on Sunday night. He was produced before the court later. Manja was granted bail by a local court on the grounds of his health condition on Monday.

Kharge targets BJP, RSS: 'Which of your leaders fought for Independence?'

Pavneet Singh Chadda
Panaji, August 17

AMID THE controversy over the rendition of *Vande Mataram* at an Independence Day event, Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday hit out at the BJP and the RSS, calling them "anti-India" and questioned their role in India's freedom struggle.

Addressing the Congress convention of both-level agents and workers in South Goa's Verna, Kharge said it was the Congress which fought for the freedom of the country. "Which BJP/RSS leader fought for Independence? And you teach us patriotism? [They say] we are anti-India. You are anti-India... you are anti-religion," he said.

"You are anti-religion because when a person like me goes to Uttarakhand and gives a speech before lakhs of people... you do a 'purification' through a 'havan' two days later. Is it not a shame on this country? Your religion teaches this? Your Gurus... they teach this? Where is your (M S) Golwalkar Guruf? Where are the teachers... who taught you? Have they taught only this? *Puapli loh toh aap hain, apka pehle shuddhikaran hua chahiye* [You are the sinners, you must be 'purified' first]," he said.

A political row had erupted on Sunday after Union Home Minister Amit Shah accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of attempting to stop the full rendition of *Vande Mataram* at the party headquarters on Independence Day and said the party should apologise to the nation. The Congress denied the charge and defended its leader, stressing that the full rendition of *Vande Mataram* was a tradition.

Kharge said Congress leaders like Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru had devoted their lives to the freedom struggle. He said the BJP and RSS did not fight for independence and instead wrote



AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge addresses a public meeting in Goa on Monday. ANI

letters to the British, pledging their support. "They were slaves of the British. What does history say? You... from the BJP or whoever from the RSS... wrote letters to the British, saying we are in your support. What did we [Congress] say? 'Do or die'. This was Mahatma Gandhi's voice. Your voice was... *maaf mangna* [to apologise]. *Ye maaf sarkaarain hein* [these are apology governments]," he said.

Referring to Goa Congress leaders, who switched over to the BJP in the recent past, Kharge said, "Our people won with a big majority in Goa the previous time, but some people defected... Today, out of 12 ministers [in the Cabinet], 10 are from the Congress. Do not vote for these gaddars [traitors]."

Slamming the BJP for "stealing MLAs" and "engineering" defections, Kharge said the BJP government in Goa is a "govt of thieves." He said, "The Congress should have formed the government here. But they [BJP] formed the government 'tod-fod ke' [through defections]. So, what should I call it? And these people will teach us morality?"

After January launch vehicle debacle, GISAT-1A take-off in September to end ISRO's seven-month operational hiatus

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, August 17

AFTER A SEVEN-MONTH hiatus, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) is set to resume its launch services, with the first of the observation satellite GISAT-1A set to be launched in the first week of September.

This is one of two satellites — the other being NVS-03 — that has remained parked at Sriharikota spaceport for months as launches were put on hold following a series of setbacks said officials in the space agency.

Indeed, three of the six missions that ISRO undertook in 2025 and 2026 saw the satellites not reaching the intended orbits due to anomalies in the launch vehicle or spacecraft engine.

GISAT-1A or Geo Imaging Satellite — also referred to as EOS-05 under the new nomenclature — is a replacement satellite for the 2021-launched GISAT-1 (or EOS-03), which missed the orbit after the final propulsive segment of the rocket failed to ignite.

The new satellite, GISAT-1A, which boasts a 10-year mission life, is designed to image large areas of interest at frequent intervals for the purposes of monitoring natural disasters or keeping a track of agriculture or forestry.

Meanwhile, NVS-03 — fuelled and ready at Sriharikota — is likely to be launched in November, officials said.

The space agency undertook just one launch this year. On January 12, ISRO's workhorse launch vehicle, Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV), was set to place an Earth observation satellite in orbit as part of the ISRO PSLV-C62/EOS-N1 mission.

However, the mission failed reportedly due to an "anomaly" in the third stage of the rocket. The findings of the Failure Analysis Committee, which probed the incident has not been made public yet.

In 2025, ISRO undertook five launches. This included one mission wherein PSLV-C61 was set to put in orbit the Earth observation satellite EOS-9.



The launch of PSLV-C62/EOS-N1 had failed in January reportedly due to an "anomaly." ANI

Again, the mission failed because of yet another "anomaly" in the third stage.

The space agency has maintained that the two anomalies were unrelated. However, no failure analysis report has been made public for this mission either. Then, there were two launches via the Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV).

The first was the GSLV-F16-enabled launch of a NISAR satellite developed in collaboration with NASA, which was successful. However, the second launch — of NVS-02 using GSLV-F15 — missed delivering the satellite to its destination after the orbit-raising manoeuvres failed.

Though the GSLV-F15 functioned normally, the findings of

the analysis report have not been made public.

There were also two Launch Vehicle Mark-3 (LV-M3)-enabled launches — of communication satellites Bluebird-2 and CMS-03.

These launch numbers fare poorly against the 15-mission target set by the space agency in 2025-26 and 27 in FY 2026-27 as per the recent ISRO annual report. The space agency counts the launch vehicle and satellite as separate missions. But even then, the numbers fall short.

ISRO had planned to place in orbit in 2025-26 at least four Earth observation satellites, one communication satellite, one technology demonstrator, and three (launches and spacecraft missions) under Gaganyaan programme. It had also planned for at least two PSLV, GSLV and LV-M3 missions each.

For 2026-27, the space agency had set an ambitious target of at least five flights of its newly developed SSLV. This would be in addition to four PSLV, three GSLV, and one LV-M3 missions. Under Gagan-

nyaan programme, it had planned at least four missions (both spacecraft and launch vehicle).

After losing NSV-02, the launch of the next satellite in the series is extremely important considering India's navigation constellation can no longer provide navigation data independently.

"...Presently, the NavIC constellation has three satellites for providing PNT (Positioning, Navigation, Timing) services — IRNSS-1B, IRNSS-1I and NVS-01. To provide basic positioning service, a minimum of four operational satellites are required in orbit. Hence, the NavIC constellation cannot provide standalone positioning service, however timing service is functional," Union Minister of State for Space, Dr Jitendra Singh, said in a Parliament reply.

Singh further stated that the armed forces continue to use NavIC signals alongside data from the US's GPS, the EU's Galileo, and Russia's GLONASS as part of a multi-constellation navigation setup.

Vande Mataram 'disruption': Advocate files complaint against Sonia and Rahul

Alok Singh
New Delhi, August 17

A SUPREME COURT advocate has filed a complaint against Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi over an alleged incident involving the disruption of the national song during an I-day function.

The complaint, filed by advocate Subh Sharma, alleged that during the rendition of 'Vande Mataram' Sonia Gandhi made gestures that appeared to indicate an objection to the song being continued.

DCP (Central) Rohit Rajbir Monday said they are inquiring into the complaint regarding the alleged incident at the All India Congress Committee (AICC) headquarters on August 15. The complaint was received at the I P Estate Police Station on Sunday evening.

Sharma has sought an investigation into the matter and the registration of an FIR against the two Congress leaders.

The complaint further alleged that in another video, Rahul Gandhi can be seen speaking the words, "We are not singing Vande Mataram."

The statement, when viewed in the context of the ongoing rendition of the National Song and the conduct attributed to Sonia Gandhi, raises concerns regarding the alleged intention and conduct of both leaders towards 'Vande Mataram' and its dignity, the complaint said.

8 killed in West Bengal hotel fire as locked emergency exit traps guests

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, August 17

EIGHT PEOPLE, including five tourists from Meghalaya, were killed after a massive fire broke out at a four-storey hotel in Tarapith in West Bengal's Birbhum district early Monday morning. Three of the deceased were from Alipurduar in West Bengal.

Police detained one person for alleged lapses in the maintenance of the hotel's fire-fighting system, officials said.

Although the hotel had a rear exit and an emergency staircase, the grilles to the emergency exit were locked, they said, adding that the locks had to be broken to rescue those trapped inside.

The personnel further said the door leading to the terrace was also locked, hampering rescue operations.

Police said 28 people have been rescued from the hotel and admitted to various hospitals. The cause of the blaze has not been determined yet, although police suspect a short circuit. The owner of the hotel has been detained.

According to local residents, the fire started around 4.30 am in the recreation area of Hotel Bideshim, rapidly engulfing the entire ground floor before thick smoke spread to the upper levels. They said the fire spread quickly due to false ceilings and fibre panelling of the interiors.



A forensic team visits the site in Tarapith, Birbhum district, on Monday.

The hotel, located a stone's throw from the Tarapith Temple, was packed with tourists due to the holy month of Shrawan.

Fire officials said the victims were likely sleeping when the blaze started. A detailed post-mortem examination will be conducted to determine the exact cause of the fire and resultant deaths. The injured guests, some suffering from burn injuries, were rushed to the Ramprabhat Government Medical College and Hospital.

Minister of State for Fire and Emergency Services, Koushik

Chowdhury, said, "According to the information I have, a hotel caught fire early this morning. I am in touch with the Chief Minister (Suvendu Adhikari), who is receiving regular updates. A detailed investigation will be conducted, and we will take stern action."

Speaking to the media, Superintendent of Police Vidyut Raj Bhundesh said the police and fire brigade rescued 11 people. "We are continuing our investigation... We will take stern action. We observed that some fire safety measures, including handheld fire extin-

guishers, were in place," he said, adding that a forensic team has been called to investigate the matter.

Samarjit Paul, one of the guests, said, "We were on the ground floor when we suddenly heard a commotion... As we opened the door, the heat of the flames hit us. We quickly closed the door, switched off all the lights and fans, rushed to the balcony, and hopped out."

Another guest staying on the first floor said, "We woke up to people shouting and screaming and saw a lot of smoke. We could hardly see anything. My

husband and I quickly grabbed our children and headed to the balcony. My husband climbed down the parapet (holding on to a tree), I handed over the children to him, and then I climbed down. It was very scary."

Fire brigade officers on the scene said that a short circuit is preliminarily suspected as the cause, though a full investigation will be conducted.

The hotel has been sealed. Outside, several guests who escaped were seen searching for missing relatives.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a social media post that he was "angushed to hear about the loss of lives due to a fire tragedy in Birbhum".

He has announced compensation of Rs 2 lakh to the families of those killed in the fire and Rs 50,000 for those injured.

In the wake of the fire tragedy and ahead of the Kaushiki Amavasya festival, which draws thousands of pilgrims to Tarapith, the West Bengal government has formed a multi-departmental Special Audit Committee to inspect all local commercial accommodations.

The committee will audit fire safety compliance, electrical installations, and the availability of emergency exits across all hotels, lodges, and hostels.

Sub-divisional officer (SDO) of Ramprabhat will be the committee's chairperson.



An ambulance arrives at a hospital following a stampede in Bihar's Lakhisarai on Monday.

Bihar: 7 killed, 25 injured as panic over electric pole triggers stampede at temple

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 17

BY THE time the stampede occurred at 6:40 am, Mammala Devi and her daughter had already been standing in the long queue at the Ashok Dham temple for over an hour, awaiting their turn. A regular at the temple, Mammala visited on the first and second Mondays of the ongoing Hindu month of Sawan.

"A large number of devotees got down after the train stopped and began entering the queue, increasing the pressure. It was then that the stampede broke out," she said.

A 44-year-old resident of Barahiya, some 12 km away, Mammala fainted and was killed in the crush, while Pallavi sustained minor injuries. Mammala was one of seven people killed in a stampede near Ashok Dham Halt in Bihar's Lakhisarai district on Monday morning, where a large number of devotees had gathered on the third Monday of Sawan. All seven deceased were women, officials said.

Twenty-five people were injured in the stampede, which officials said was triggered by a rumour that an electricity pole had fallen and live current was spreading near the railway halt, about a kilometre from the temple.

Although an electricity pole had fallen, officials said it was in a field and was carrying a covered cable, not an exposed wire. "Preliminary investigation has found that an electric pole had fallen in a field. People approaching from behind began shouting that an electricity pole had fallen. Around 100 metres ahead, women were standing in a queue. The announcement triggered panic, and as some people tried to move into the field to get away, they fell and were trampled," Lakhisarai SDPO Shivam Kumar told The Indian Express. "Others following behind continued to move over them, resulting in the casualties."

Although the train doesn't usually halt there, the stoppage in the month of Sawan is meant

especially for the temple's devotees.

"The temple gates opened at 2.55 am, and while the initial crowds were manageable, it grew. When the rumour spread, it created additional pressure within seconds," the official said.

According to officials, the spread of the rumour led to barricades being broken. Besides Mammala Devi, the other deceased women have been identified as Rinku Devi, 50, of Safaisarai in Munger; Hemlata Devi, 55, Lalita Devi, 50, and Savita Devi, 35, all of Prataprur in Haisi; Saroj Devi, 65, of Bakawan in Patna; and Savitri Devi, 48, of Chamania in Lakhisarai.

Three women are critically injured and have been moved to Patna Medical College and Hospital.

Relatives questioned crowd-management arrangements at the temple. There was a huge crowd because it was the third Monday of Sawan, and the administration should have made arrangements accordingly and increased its deployment, Mammala's relative said.

The district administration said Rs 4 lakh in ex-gratia compensation had been paid to the families of each deceased person, and arrangements had been made for the treatment of the injured.

A three-member inquiry committee has been set up to investigate the incident, officials said.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and former CM Nitish Kumar expressed grief over the incident through social media posts. In his post on X, Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary described the incident at Ashok Dham as "extremely sad and heart-rending" and said he was deeply distressed by reports of devotees being killed in the accident.

Meanwhile, Leader of the Opposition in the Bihar Assembly and national working president of the RJD Tejashwi Yadav blamed the incident on inadequate security arrangements and crowd management, saying it reflected the "administrative mismanagement" of the NDA government.

WEST BENGAL ANNAPURNA YOJANA 10L out of 17L rejected applicants for cash transfer scheme have Aadhaar issues: Govt

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, August 17

AFTER VERIFICATION, names of around 17 lakh applicants for the Annapurna Yojana were rejected over Aadhaar-related issues ahead of the disbursement of the third tranche of funds for the direct cash transfer scheme for women, the government said on Monday.

The information was shared at a press meet by Minister of State for Health Sumana Sarkar, Minister of State for Information and Cultural Affairs Purnima Chakraborty and Secretary of the Women and Child Development Department, Mounima Godara at Nabanna.

The government will be disbursing the third instalment between August 17 and 20 to the bank accounts of 1.62 crore beneficiaries out of 1.62 crore applicants and Rs 4,350 crore has been allocated for this purpose.

According to sources at Nabanna, the primary reason for the rejection of names was the non-linking of bank accounts with Aadhaar. Out of the 17 lakh rejected cases, around 10 lakh

were due to this Aadhaar-related issues. Additionally, several applications were turned down because the applicant or a family member holds a government job, or because records showed they pay income tax.

The sources added that verification of documents is underway for those who applied between July 11 and July 31, and the process will go on till September 30.

To resolve the Aadhaar and bank account linking issues easily, Nabanna has issued special instructions to Block Development Officers (BDOs) to coordinate with bank authorities and organise special camps.

Rejected applicants can re-apply by accessing the 'Social Register' option on the government portal, where the renewal window will open on August 20. Anyone with grievances or objections regarding the rejection can also lodge a complaint directly through the same portal. Those wishing to submit fresh applications will need to wait till September 30, sources said.

SC tells HC to defer Rahul assets case, asks CBI and ED not to submit report

Ananthkrishnan G
New Delhi, August 17

THE SUPREME COURT on Monday asked the Allahabad High Court to defer proceedings in a plea seeking a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and Enforcement Directorate (ED) into allegations of disproportionate assets against Rahul Gandhi.

A three-judge bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant also asked the CBI and ED not to submit any report to the HC in the interim.

"Police or any other agency, if they have any prima facie evidence, they can register a case, they can proceed against anyone. They don't need permission from accused. But if the court wants to issue a direction, they are expected to follow the principles of natural justice," the CJ said.

The bench, also comprising Justices Jyotsna Bagechi and V Mohana, was hearing Gandhi's appeal challenging the HC order.

The proceedings before the Allahabad HC originated on a complaint filed by a Karnataka resident, S Vignesh Shishir.

"It is expected that if the complaint of the petitioner has been received, the allegations of the complaints may be verified as per law. It is needless to say that the CBI or ED may take appropriate steps which are permissible under the law," the HC had said in May.

Appearing for Gandhi, Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal said that what happened was "well-known to law... and a witch-hunt through a process not recognised by law".

Questioning Shishir's locus standi and bona fides, Sibal said

he had not disclosed his credentials. He submitted that Shishir is an RSS worker who files petitions against Gandhi repeatedly.

Appearing for the CBI, Senior Advocate S V Raju said the agency "has done nothing except for verifying the complaint", adding that "if correct, (these are) serious allegations". He said only on the facts, facts may be right, facts may be wrong, but if the facts are right, it's a gross case of disproportionate assets," Raju said.

Have you done it (looking into the allegations) suo motu," Justice Bagechi asked Raju. As Raju answered in the negative, Justice Bagechi said, "then let us examine the correctness of this order."

Raju said the agency would not oppose Sibal's submissions as if it was a frivolous complaint. "If it's so serious, why has your agency kept quiet? Do you require impetus from the court? Your agencies have statutory powers," Justice Bagechi observed.

Sibal also questioned how the proceedings before the HC, which happened in-chamber, appeared in the media. "These are sealed cover procedures, how do newspaper reports happen?"

Shishir, who appeared online, responding to a query from the bench said, he had not received a copy of the paper book (case documents) to oppose Gandhi's plea, and urged the court to supply him the documents and fix a date for hearing the case.

The court issued notices to the respondents and directed that the documents be supplied to Shishir so that he can also be heard on the next date of hearing.

You've got mail: Drugs now being circulated in Goa through courier

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, August 17

EARLIER THIS year, Goa Police intercepted a consignment of hashish being smuggled into the state.

More than the act of smuggling, though, it was the mode through which the contraband was being transported into the state that left the police worried. The hashish packages were found concealed in the bottom of a steam iron, which was posted in a package being delivered at the hands of an unsuspecting driver.

Concerned at the possibility of many more such cases, the Goa Police have decided to take the assistance of courier and postal service operators besides delivery partners to curb drug trafficking in the coastal state.

The initiative is part of a broader three-year roadmap as part of 'Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyan'.

Senior police officers recently held an awareness meeting with at least 75 representatives from courier and postal service providers across Goa.

During the meeting, the anti-narcotics cell informed the operators about an emerging technique among traffickers to conceal consignments, especially to smuggle cannabis and hashish, in small courier parcels and through the postal services network.

'Dead-drop method'

The police noticed that by increasingly traffickers have been using a "dead-drops" delivery method to smuggle narcotics. After the buyer transfers money to the seller, they are sent coordinates of a particular location to retrieve the drugs from a rider. The drugs are often ferried by unsuspecting courier delivery partners, who are under the im-

Police officers meet representatives of postal service providers for assistance

• Anti-narco action



* DATA UNTIL AUGUST 12, 2026; SOURCE: GOA POLICE



Goa Police has now created a WhatsApp group for coordination with courier service operators.

DEAD-DROP DELIVERY: After sending money to the seller, the buyer gets coordinates for the location where a courier delivery partner would hand over the parcel. The rider believes the contents are legitimate.

pression that they are handing over a legitimate parcel.

The aim of the awareness meeting was to sensitise the courier and postal service operators about common concealment methods used by traffickers and to look for "suspicious consignments", especially the ones with pseudonymic bookings, incomplete sender or receiver details, unusual packaging, and high-value parcels with inconsistent descriptions.

"Courier and postal service providers are key stakeholders to prevent the misuse of their services by drug traffickers. We flagged the importance of proactive vigilance, strict adherence to KYC norms, verification of consignor and consignee details of parcels, and timely reporting of suspicious consignments to law enforcement agencies," said a senior police official, requesting anonymity.

Advantage anonymity

"This 'drop-dead' method has become quite popular due to the relative anonymity it allows the traffickers. The courier service operators, in a way, end up unknowingly facilitating the transportation of narcotics," the police officer added.

According to an analysis by anti-narcotics cell, which was shared at a zonal coordination meeting earlier this month, the most commonly seized drugs in Goa include ganja, chas, LSD, MDMA/ecstasy and cocaine.

Though cocaine is smuggled internationally and makes its way to Goa through other states like Delhi and Karnataka, cannabis (ganja) is trafficked here from Jharkhand and Odisha, according to police analysis. Chas is trafficked to Goa from Himachal Pradesh and Nepal while LSD largely makes its way into Goa from Kerala. Methamphetamine is sourced from Kerala and Bengaluru and ecstasy/MDMA is trafficked to Goa from Kerala, Maharashtra and Delhi.

As a result, an assessment in 2023 found that cocaine is sourced from South American countries and makes its way to Goa via the

sea route, primarily through shipping containers. LSD paper is brought in flights, concealed in luggage, and through mail. Chas (charas) is trafficked to Goa from Himachal and other north Indian states besides Nepal through rail route and via bus.

According to the police presentation, offenders use discreet methods for procurement, storage and distribution of drugs. "Social media platforms, courier services, rented premises, tourist gatherings, and nightlife events are sometimes misused for drug circulation. Coastal belts, tourist areas, nightlife zones, and party locations remain vulnerable to drug-related activities," the report stated.

Rise in cases

In 2023, Goa police arrested 166 people, including 21 foreign nationals, and registered 140 cases for smuggling narcotics. The number of arrests increased to 192 in 2024 and 213 in 2025. Cases lodged also went up to 162 and 163 in 2024 and 2025, respectively. Until August 12, 2026, 135 people have been arrested and at least 122 cases registered.

Police said the road map to end drug-trafficking involves four pillars: Enforcement, intelligence and operations; precursors and synthetic drugs control; demand and harm reduction; and capacity building and coordination. "We have created a WhatsApp group for coordination with courier service operators and some delivery partners. If they spot any suspicious parcel, especially near schools and clubs in the coastal belt, we have asked them to report to police. The idea is also to identify new patterns and get to the source. A challenge we face is there is no regulatory framework overseeing private courier services," the police officer said.

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At 85, ex-UP cop who refused to give up on promotion finally gets his due

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, August 17

FOR 25 years, a former police sub-inspector refused to let a promotion denied to him at the end of his career become a forgotten grievance.

Ram Autar Singh Yadav pursued the case through the police, the State Public Services Tribunal and finally the Allahabad High Court, travelling more than 450 km from his hometown in Etawah to appear in person in court.

The 85-year-old has now finally won the case, earning the promotion to the post of inspector.

Stating that the petitioner was treated "unfairly", the High Court has directed the Uttar Pradesh government and the Director General of Police (DGP) to give Yadav the benefits of the rank of an inspector with effect from 1980.

A division bench of Justices Arindam Sinha and Satya Veer Singh, in its judgment delivered and uploaded on August 4 and 10, respectively, directed to release the petitioner's promotional salary and benefits from March 16, 1980, till the date of his retirement. It said corresponding retirement benefits must also be given to him within four weeks.



Ram Autar Singh Yadav

In 1999, Yadav retired from service as a Station Officer (SO). He had filed a representation before top officials, including the DGP, during his service period

after his batchmates got a promotion and he was rejected.

In his April 2010 order, the DGP rejected Yadav's claim, citing adverse remarks in his confidential reports and a previous censure. This order noted that Yadav had been punished five times and adverse remarks were mentioned seven times.

According to Yadav's petition, he petitioned the State Public Services Tribunal in Lucknow. His claim was dismissed in November 2012. His revision petition, too, was dismissed the next year.

He then challenged the Tribunal's decision in the HC. But his writ petition was dis-

missed for non-prosecution in February 2015.

Yadav made an application for restoration, which was also dismissed for want of prosecution by a co-ordinate bench in December 2025.

The present application was filed for recall of the December order. The petitioner submitted before the court that the adverse remarks, as cited by the DGP in its 2010 order, were never communicated to him.

After hearing the submissions, the High Court bench stated in its order, "The Tribunal appears to have lost sight that a fact can be proved, while the negative cannot. It was up

FIR filed after Dalits allege they were forced off chairs at Rajasthan school I-Day function

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 17

THE RAJASTHAN Police have lodged an FIR after some Dalits were allegedly asked to vacate their chairs during an Independence Day function at a school in Bhiwara.

The FIR was lodged following a complaint by Rameshwar Lal Baiwra, 37, and Gopali Baiwra, 37, who alleged that some Dalits were allegedly asked to vacate their chairs during an Independence Day function at a school in Bhiwara.

The FIR was lodged following a complaint by Rameshwar Lal Baiwra, 37, and Gopali Baiwra, 37, who alleged that some Dalits were allegedly asked to vacate their chairs during an Independence Day function at a school in Bhiwara.

"We were sitting on the chairs placed there during the programme when some people approached us and discriminated against us because of our caste," the Baiwras alleged. They said they were abused "using caste-based slurs by the people, who, in a highly insulting tone, said: 'You Baiwras, sit down

below [on the floor]. If you sit on the chairs, where will we sit? What right do you have to sit in front of us?"

They allege they were intimidated and forced to vacate the chairs, claiming there were threats to shut down the Anganwadi where two women from their group worked. They allege the incident happened in front of schoolchildren, teachers and villagers, "causing us mental trauma and deeply hurting our self-respect and social standing".

Talking to *The Indian Express*, Rameshwar Lal said: "The entire case is that we sat on chairs. Every year, all of us sit on the ground. But this time, there were chairs and the teacher invited us to sit on them which led to some people objecting to us, saying that we can't sit with them." Bagor police station SHO Bachhraj Choudhary said the investigation is ongoing.

17 death sentences in seven cases, 100 days: Why a Muzaffarnagar trial court stands out

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, August 17

BETWEEN APRIL 6 and July 17 – barely 100 days – Judge Ravi Kumar Diwakar, Additional District and Sessions Judge presiding over Fast Track Court No. 3 in Muzaffarnagar, sentenced 17 people to death across seven separate murder trials, out of 22 accused.

For a sense of how unusual that number is, take the entire Uttar Pradesh. In all of 2025, across the state, trial courts handed down 28 death sentences in 20 cases, as per the Death Penalty in India: Annual Statistics Report 2025, by the Square Circle Clinic at NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad.

The two states that ranked after UP in the award of death sentences by trial courts in 2025, Karnataka (15) and West Bengal (14), in fact, saw fewer capital terms in comparison to Justice Diwakar's court alone.

All death sentences by a Sessions Court have to be confirmed by a High Court. The Square Circle Clinic's decade-long data shows High Courts have confirmed barely 1 in 10 of the death sentences they have

examined since 2016 (106 of 1,085). The Supreme Court has not confirmed a single death sentence since 2023.

One essential requirement for confirming the death sentence is adherence to norms as laid out by the Supreme Court in Manoj & Ors v State of Madhya Pradesh case of 2022, which include examining the mitigating circumstances and reports on the accused's conduct.

Judge Diwakar's orders awarding the death sentence do not have a record of the same. Apart from deaths to 17 of the five other accused in the seven cases, two did not stand trial, another died during trial, another passed away during investigation, and one was found not for murder but for making evidence disappear.

The requirement, and the gap

In Manoj & Ors v State of Madhya Pradesh, a three-judge Supreme Court Bench comprising Justices U U Lalit, S Ravindra Bhat and Bela M Trivedi held that before a trial court hands down a death sentence, it must have on record several reports, to be prepared by the state

in a time-bound manner. These include reports on the accused's psychiatric and psychological condition, jail conduct, behaviour and work done in custody.

The purpose, the Bench said, was to test whether reform of the convict was truly foreclosed, since death is to be given only in "the rarest of rare" cases.

In the 17 death sentences given by the Fast Track Court No. 3, there is no record of the state producing such material, or the court calling for it. The *Indian Express* reached out to several prosecutors concerned, and off the record, they said they did not submit any such reports as the court did not seek the same.

In at least two cases, the judge noted the accused's "bhav-bhangima" (facial expressions and demeanour in the courtroom) as a key factor. "The court observed the facial expressions and demeanour of the convicted person, and at no point did the court feel that he felt any remorse for the crime he had committed," the sentencing orders in the May 30 and July 2 orders state.

The 2022 Manoj ruling also placed the burden of assembling material on mitigating

circumstances on the State: the trial court has to "elicit" it, and the State has to produce a structured account of the accused's socio-economic background and early life.

Across all the seven cases, the defence counsel argued that the convicts concerned were poor, labourers, or fathers of young children. But the court found other factors as weighing over this in its sentencing orders.

Advocate Rajeev Sharma, District Government Counsel, Muzaffarnagar, did not respond to attempts by *The Indian Express* to reach him via phone calls and text messages.

Under Sections 407 to 412 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, no death sentence passed by a Sessions Court can be carried out until the High Court confirms it. So, all 17 death sentences awarded by the Muzaffarnagar trial court will go to the Allahabad High Court for confirmation, alongside any appeals the convicts file independently.

In a landmark ruling in 2025, in the Vasanta Sampat Dupare v Union of India case, a Supreme Court Bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sanjay Karol and Sandeep

Mehta held that even a death sentence the Supreme Court has itself affirmed as final could be reopened under Article 32 of the Constitution if the Manoj safeguards were not followed.

The seven cases, the 17 death sentences

■ April 6: Three given the death sentence by the Muzaffarnagar Fast-Track Court No. 3 for kidnapping and murdering a young advocate and a close friend of one of the convicts. The court saw it as an attack on the Bar and the rule of law itself.

■ April 28: A father and three sons convicted for beating a man to death with bricks over a Rs 70,000 debt. The court likened it to mob lynching, and held that "the facial expressions and behaviour" of the four showed no repentance through the trial.

■ May 30: One given capital punishment for the "diabolical" double murder of a woman he was in a relationship with and her six-year-old son. His crime was seen as aggravated, as he was already in jail for his wife's dowry death.

■ June 20: Two held guilty of killing a man and burning the body. The court held it to be a

calculated, "no body, no case" attempt, influenced by films, to destroy evidence. It spoke about "total lack of remorse" shown by the accused in the courtroom.

■ July 2: One sentenced for fatally stabbing a Home Guard and trying to kill another after they stepped in to stop him from assaulting his own mother. The crime was seen by the court as "a challenge not only to the police force but also directly to the authority of the state government". The court also added that the crime demonstrates criminals are capable of "directly challenging the sovereignty of the State".

■ July 6: Two convicted of killing a rival panchayat election candidate, and using their influence to make the murder weapon disappear from police custody. The judge said that "democracy is based on the ballot, not the bullet".

■ July 17: Four were sentenced for organising a "gang-style" robbery-murder on a highway. The court cited their criminal antecedents and Muzaffarnagar's reputation as a "Crime Capital", and talked about "the message" the sentence sends.

Bihar Police to SC: Constable who fired from AK-47 rifle was 'trapped'

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 17

THE BIHAR Police has told the Supreme Court that a constable working in the District Intelligence Unit (DIU) "had fired... 4 rounds from his AK-47 in the air" after he "got trapped in the crowd" of protesters that had hit the streets in Siwan on July 25, following the bandh call by various parties as the 'Jantar Mantar' protests in the state turned violent, but no one was injured.

In a counter-affidavit filed in the top court, ADGP (Law and Order) K Shuhita Anupam said that "in Siwan, on 25.07.2026, protestors of AISA and RYA (student and youth wing of



Protesters clashed with police at several places in Bihar on July 25. FILE

CPI (ML)) gathered at Gandhi Maidan and began marching towards JP Chowk. At around 12:30 pm, protestors started pelting stones on the police force. The hooligans from Mairwa Road and Gopalganj

Road joined the stone pelters. In the stone pelting, 20 police personnel including Superintendent of Police Siwan, 2 Sub-Divisional Police Officers, 2 Inspectors, 2 Sub-Inspectors, 13 Constables got injured. In the

violence, two police vehicles and a large number of traffic trollies were damaged. Water cannon and tear gas shells were used to control the law and order situation. For the incidents, 6 FIRs were registered against 82 persons, out of which 17 persons were arrested".

The affidavit filed on August 11 stated that "as the deployed force was inadequate, all the officers and personnel working in different sections and lines were called to supplement the police force. Near JP Chowk, Constable... working in the District Intelligence Unit (DIU), got trapped in the crowd and fired 4 rounds from his AK-47 in the air. No one was injured".

It further said that in Hathi

Chowk, about 1.5-2 km from JP Chowk, another assistant sub-inspector fired 2 rounds from his 9mm pistol to disperse the mob. Two fired cartridges of .315 bore and 1 fired cartridge of 7.65 mm were recovered from the place of incident.

"Three protestors suffered minor firearms injuries" and they "were given best possible treatment in Sadar Hospital, Siwan, and were immediately shifted to Medanta Hospital in Patna for better treatment. All the injured persons were released after their injuries healed," the affidavit read. The State Police said that "the injuries to protestors were neither caused by AK-47, nor the persons were located at the place where the constable fired from AK-47. Ballistic examination is being carried out to ascertain the type of weapon, distance of fire, angle of fire etc".

It added that the constable who fired the AK-47 "has been put under suspension for undesired conduct and departmental proceedings... has been initiated against him". The State pointed out that "as AK-47 is a platoon-level weapon, it is to be used in special operations, not in law and order situations". A detailed instruction regarding "use of AK 47 has been issued by the Director General of Police" on August 1 and added that "similar orders have been issued at earlier occasions as well".

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LTD.
2nd Floor, APCRDA Office, Rayapada, Thuluru Mandal, (A.P.)
E-TENDER NOTICE
E-tenders are invited for: TN-31(RVU2627/SL0801104) Implementation of Computerized Maintenance Management System (CMMS) for Chhabra Thermal (CTPP-0&M) and Chhabra Supercritical (CSCP) Thermal Power Project, Chhabra and TN-32(2026-27) (RVU2627/SL0801116) Procurement of 01 No. 2x600 HP Twin Power Stack Diesel Hydraulic Shunting Locomotive for Kota Super Thermal Power Station (KSTPS) Kota for CHP Railway Works. Tender details are available on <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> (for e-tender), www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/rvunl&www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in.
Raj.Samwad/C/26/10027 RVUN/PR-4459 Superintending Engineer (TD-8)

AMARAVATI GROWTH AND INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGIL)
2nd Floor, APCRDA Office, Rayapada, Thuluru Mandal, (A.P.)
E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
NIT No. 14/MID/CE/ELE/AGIL/2026, Dated: 17.08.2026
Name of Work: Providing MEP like high side Electrical, HVAC, Fire Protection System, Lifts, Fire Alarm & Public Address System and Plumbing works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & H&O Offices (GAD Tower) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh".
NIT No. 15/MID/CE/ELE/AGIL/2026, Dated: 17.08.2026
Name of Work: Providing MEP like high side Electrical, HVAC, Fire Protection System, Lifts, Fire Alarm & Public Address System and Plumbing works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & H&O Offices (Tower 3 & 4) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh".
NIT No. 16/MID/CE/ELE/AGIL/2026, Dated: 17.08.2026
Name of Work: Providing MEP like high side Electrical, HVAC, Fire Protection System, Lifts, Fire Alarm & Public Address System and Plumbing works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & H&O Offices (Towers 1 & 2) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh".
The bids can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 19-08-2026. For further details, please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and www.agil.org.
Sd/- Managing Director, AGIL, Amaravati

CORPORATE BRIEFS

EDUCATION



ASIAN BUSINESS SCHOOL - ORIENTATION

The institute successfully concluded a three-day PGDM Orientation Programme from July 29-31, 2026. The programme featured Ms. Ghazal Alagh, Founder of Mamaearth, and industry leaders Ayush Gupta, Director HR, GAIL, and Sayajit Mittal, Founder of Aretto. Day two featured an HR Conclave, team-building activities and chief guest Mr. Vivek Srivastava, Managing Director, PwC. The programme concluded with Campus Connect and a Talent Hunt judged by actress and model Akasha Vats. Dr. Sandeep Marwah graced the event, held under the leadership of Dr. Lalit Vir Srivastava, Dr. Saurabh Sharma and Dr. Gurdeep Singh Raina.



CHRIST (DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITY) - EVENT

Dr. R. Joseph C.C., Vice Chancellor of CHRIST (Deemed to be University), was conferred the honorary rank of Colonel of the National Cadet Corps (NCC) at a piping ceremony held at the University's Central Campus. Ar Commodore Kamal Chadda, Deputy Director General, NCC Directorate Karnataka & Goa, highlighted CHRIST's 57-year NCC legacy and eight consecutive Best Institution Awards. Nearly 200 CHRIST cadets have been commissioned into the Armed Forces, with 47 joining between 2019 and 2026. Dr. R. Joseph is the third CHRIST Vice Chancellor to receive the honorary rank.



AMITY INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL - EVENT

Amity International School, Noida, won the GT Winner's Trophy at the 16th GT Awards, organised by The Global Times at Amity University, Noida. The GT Making a Newspaper Contest 2025-26 featured young journalists from 12 Amity International and Amity Global Schools, showcasing creativity, storytelling and journalistic skills. Mayur Vihar and Sector-46, Gurugram, were joint first runners-up, while Sector-43, Gurugram, secured second runners-up. Saket received the Jury Special Mention Award. Chief Guest Shikta Deo of NDTV urged students to remain curious, fearless and honest. The event also recognised editorial, design, alumni and mentoring excellence.



AJAY KUMAR GARG ENGINEERING COLLEGE (AKGEC) - EVENT

The Department of Computer Science & Engineering at AKGEC, in collaboration with C-DAC Noida, inaugurated a six-day offline bootcamp on Cloud Computing Technology under the FutureSkills PRIME Project. The programme, held from recently, was inaugurated with a traditional Lamp Lighting Ceremony and Saraswati Vandana. Amita Dev, Advisor, AKGEC, graced the occasion as Chief Guest, while Anu Chaudhary, Head, CSE Department, welcomed participants and emphasized the importance of industry-oriented skills. C-DAC experts Shubham Tripathi, Cyber Security Engineer, and Yasir Ahmar Khan, Cyber Security Trainer and Security Consultant, are conducting interactive sessions and hands-on training. Participants are gaining practical exposure to cloud infrastructure, virtualization, deployment models, cloud security, DevOps, containerization and cybersecurity. The initiative aims to bridge the academia-industry gap and equip students with future-ready technical skills.



AMITY UNIVERSITY - EVENT

The University witnessed enthusiastic participation from students and faculty in the virtual launch of the Drug-Free Youth for a Developed India campaign, organised by the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, Government of India. PM Narendra Modi addressed youth nationwide, stressing that a developed India by 2047 requires healthy, mentally strong and drug-free citizens. S. K. Srivastava, Chairman, Anti-Narcotics and Disaster Management Committee, reaffirmed Amity's commitment to a drug-free campus and awareness of addiction. Students viewed films about drug abuse's impact on individuals and families. Faculty and students pledged support for the campaign and a healthier India.



GNIOT GROUP OF INSTITUTIONS - EVENT

It hosted the Namaskar Uttar Pradesh State Creators Awards-2026, organized by Namaskar Foundation, celebrating the state's creative talent, innovators, social reformers and change-makers. UP Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak graced the occasion as Chief Guest, while ISRO Scientist Abhishek Singh was the Guest of Honour. Distinguished achievers from education, culture, technology, entrepreneurship, healthcare, agriculture and social service were felicitated for their contributions. Rajesh Gupta, Chairman, GNIOT, highlighted the role of education and innovation in nation-building. The event reinforced the Foundation's commitment to recognizing talent and inspiring youth.

MOMENTOUS EVENT SEES DIPLOMATS FROM INDIA, IRAN, RUSSIA, CHINA; PAKISTAN STAYS AWAY

At Afghan embassy, Taliban diplomats mark 5th anniversary of 'victory day'

Shubhrajit Roy
New Delhi, August 17

IT WAS a humid evening and the lush green lawns of the Afghan embassy in Delhi's diplomatic enclave Chanakya-puri were lit up with paper lanterns and fairy lights. A white and parrot green themed shamiana housed at least 20 round tables, with giant coconuts and fans to keep the guests cool.

This was no ordinary evening at Chanakya-puri, which witnesses diplomatic receptions round the year. This one was different, and a first in India's diplomatic history.

Five years after the Taliban took control of Afghanistan, its embassy in Delhi marked the 5th anniversary of 'victory day' for the first time on Monday — which was attended by Indian government officials and about two dozen foreign diplomats.

Taliban took over the Afghan embassy in November last year, after their Foreign Minister Amir Khairat Murtagi visited India and met External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar. Both sides decided to upgrade the ties, with the Taliban sending its diplomats to Delhi under a chargé d'affaires — in the absence of official recognition of the Taliban regime by the Indian government.

Chargé d'affaires Mufti Noor Ahmad Noor hosted the two-hour event which was attended by a delegation from the Ministry of External Affairs led



Chargé d'affaires Mufti Noor Ahmad Noor with Joint Secretary (Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran) Anand Prakash at the embassy on Monday. SHUBHAJIT ROY

by Joint Secretary (Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran) Anand Prakash.

As the evening unfolded, diplomats trooped in. Palestinian Ambassador Abdullah M. Abu Shabawh was among the first to arrive, followed by Iranian Ambassador Mohammad Fathali.

While Russia and China sent their diplomats, Pakistan — which has had strained relations with the Taliban in the last couple of years — did not send a representative.

Envoys from Eritrea, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, Niger, Qatar, Oman were seen, and Serbia was the only European country to attend the event.

With no diplomatic recognition from most of the world, the Taliban chargé d'affaires carried pictures with the

guests, but with no flags in the background. There was, however, the Indian flag and the Taliban flag, belonging to the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan, on the dais.

The only place where Afghanistan's old flag still flies is the main flag pole of the embassy, which can be seen from outside.

After a prayer, Noor gave a 21-minute speech in which he addressed several security concerns. "One of the important achievements of the past five years has been the implementation of the sacred Sharia, the strengthening of the country's security and independent decision-making, as well as the consolidation of stability. This security is not only a necessity for Afghans, but also serves the

shared interests of the region and the world. A peaceful, stable and responsible Afghanistan creates new opportunities for regional connectivity, trade, investment and economic cooperation, while also playing a constructive role in preventing shared security threats," he said.

"The Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan believes that Afghanistan's geography should not be a field for negative competition, but rather a bridge for connectivity, cooperation and shared prosperity," the envoy added.

Invoking the historical ties, he said, "For centuries, Afghanistan and India have remained connected through trade, transit, sports, and shared cultural heritage. Throughout our history, the routes linking our two countries served as channels for the exchange of knowledge and art, as well as for the transmission of the values of literature and spirituality. The ancient cities of Afghanistan, such as Kabul, Herat and Kandahar, welcomed Indian traders and caravans, while... Delhi and Lahore benefited from the influence of Afghan scholars, poets and Sufis. In the political sphere as well, the two countries influenced one another in their struggles for freedom and independence from British colonial rule."

Coming to the present, CDA Noor said, "In recent years, relations between Afghanistan and India have witnessed significant progress — guided by mutual respect, political engagement and shared interests. Official diplomatic contacts between the two countries have expanded, embassies and consulates have become more active, and high-level delegations have continued to exchange visits... More recently, Afghanistan's Minister of Foreign Affairs, as well as ministers from other sectoral ministries, have visited India, and the two countries have reached understandings in various areas. These developments represent an important step forward in further strengthening and expanding cooperation between Afghanistan and India."

Only a handful of women were present at the event, including Indian diplomat Sneha Dubey, a few Indian women journalists as well as wives, family members of foreign diplomats in the crowd of about 200 people.

As the evening rolled by over watermelon mocktails, virgin mojitos, Qashali pulses and goseht, the Afghans from the former regime were seen standing near the tent.

While the Taliban-appointed diplomats had dinner with Indian and foreign guests inside the tent, those appointed by the Ashraf Ghani regime looked on from the lawns. A Taliban-appointed diplomat told The Indian Express, "We are all working together, there is no problem between us at all."

SC weighs rules for Ram temple donations amid row over 'theft'

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 17

THE SUPREME COURT on Monday said it might pass orders listing ways to transparently maintain donations at the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya in the wake of alleged embezzlement of funds at the temple.

"There are certain other directions which are required for the purpose of reforms. That we will issue. We are also considering this fact — that how the donation amount should be maintained, what kind of transparency (is needed)," Chief Justice of India Surya Kant remarked orally while hearing petitions seeking probe into the alleged embezzlement.

The CJ said the remark as a counsel urged the three-judge bench, also comprising Justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V. Mohana, to direct the Trust managing the shrine to publish details of the donations received so far.

The court also asked the Special Investigation Team (SIT) constituted by it to investigate the matter and take the probe to a logical conclusion.

CBI FILES CHARGESHEET

Twisha death: AIMS Delhi finds 'no injury suggestive of assault'

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 17

A SECOND post-mortem conducted by an AIMS Delhi medical board has found no injury on model-turned-actor Twisha Sharma's body 'suggestive of assault prior to death'. The Indian Express has learnt. The report allegedly confirms that she died of ante-mortem hanging using the gymnastic belt recovered from her matrimonial home.

The CBI, which is investigating the case, has filed its charge-sheet. The alleged findings as per the report could not be established. The report by AIMS Bhopal stated that the death was "due to ante-mortem hanging by ligature".

"Multiple ante-mortem injuries (simple) in nature, possible by blunt force over other parts of the body have been noted," the first PM report stated. Apart from the ligature injuries, the first post-mortem documented multiple external injuries on the body. These include "Two reddish abrasions" on the front of the neck, bruises on the left arm, including a "bluish contusion", another "bluish contusion" below it, and a further "bluish contusion" lower down on the same arm. It further documented a "reddish contusion" on the front of the left forearm. Another injury described was a "reddish contusion" over the "right ring finger."

Twisha, a former Miss Pune and model-turned-actor from Noida, was found dead at her matrimonial home in Bhopal's Katara Hills on May 12, 2026 — less than six months after her wedding to advocate Samarth Singh. The case was initially registered as a dowry death by the Katara Hills police and later transferred to the CBI amid allegations of investigative lapses and evidence tampering.

Full report on www.indianexpress.com

Three posing as beggars steal diamonds worth Rs 43 lakh, held after 8-hour chase

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, August 17

A HEIST of Rs 43.11-lakh diamonds of 1,437 carats and a subsequent eight-hour chase across districts in Gujarat culminated in the arrests of a woman, her father, and another accomplice, who were carrying 1,885.75 carats of the precious stones — 448.75 carats more than the police had been trying to recover.

A joint statement by the Ahmedabad Rural and Botad police said on Monday that three people posing as beggars entered the office of Ashok Javer Kankotia, a diamond merchant at Neelam Hira Bazar in Botad, stole the diamonds, and fled in less than 15 minutes on Sunday. Kankotia filed a complaint at 7.47 pm. According to the police, CCTV footage showed a woman wearing a saffron sari and leggings secretly entering the back door of the building at 1.09 pm and exiting at 1.23 pm clutching a small bag.

Other CCTV cameras showed her hiring an autorickshaw and being driven off. The autorickshaw's driver told the police where he had dropped off the passenger.

However, another CCTV video from near this hut showed the same woman, two men and a child boarding another autorickshaw. Upon finding and questioning the vehicle's driver, the police learnt that he had dropped them off at the railway station at 4.31 pm. Before the train reached Bavl railway station, the Ahmedabad Rural police coordinated with the RPF to set up a cordon on the platform and exit points of the station.

The police then found the diamonds in a leather purse and in 14 envelopes. The police identified the suspects as Sapna, 31, and her father Bachu Ramu Bhada Sadiya — both residents of Kalavad in Jamnagar — and Botad resident Vina Dheeru Dhevi Jiljila, 30.

They have been booked on charges of house break-in and theft. Further investigation is underway.

Are courts precluded from granting fair compensation for nuclear mishaps: SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 17

THE SUPREME COURT on Monday asked the Centre to respond whether the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Act, 2025, which replaced the Civil Liability for Nuclear Liability Act of 2010, would preclude constitutional courts from determining a "fair and just" monetary compensation in case of a nuclear mishap.

A three-judge bench presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant also sought to know whether there is any conflict of interest in the power under Section 17(4) of the Act to appoint Chairperson and Members of the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board (AERB). The bench, also comprising Justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V. Mohana, issued notice to the Centre and AERB on these two issues.

The court was hearing a plea which said that the government's move to cap the liability of private nuclear operators under the Act in case of a nuclear disaster will encourage the operators to cut corners.

Appearing for the petitioners, Advocate Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi said the Act caps the highest liability of the operator at Rs 3,000 crore and the government's residual liability at Rs 4,500 crore. Referring to nuclear disasters at Chernobyl and Fukushima, Bhushan contended that the real cost would be several times higher.

The CJ said that "only because Parliament imposed a cap, it does not bar the courts".

To the court's remark that the limit may be only to make the project more attractive to foreign investors, Bhushan said it might lead to the operators cutting corners. "If there is a nuclear accident in the country, questions will be raised. And if those accidents are on account of corners cut by the plant operators, in the belief that their liability is capped at Rs 100 crore to Rs 3,000 crore... it is a very serious issue," he said.

Bhushan said the SC decisions had in the past laid down this principle that if somebody operates a hazardous industry, then if there is an accident from that industry, the person who runs it will have absolute and unlimited liability. "That principle has been clearly violated". Also, AERB itself runs some nuclear plants, and it also plays a significant role in regulating them.

"This is a violation of the principles laid down of the independence of the regulatory body by all international conventions".

Responding to a query from the court about nuclear energy, Bhushan said the government had passed the Atomic Energy Act, 2005, which replaced the Civil Liability for Nuclear Liability Act of 2010, which caps the liability of the operator at Rs 3,000 crore and the government's residual liability at Rs 4,500 crore. He submitted that solar power can be built in three months and its per-capita unit cost is one-fifth that of nuclear energy. "It has no hazard whatsoever," he said.

States can't block elephant corridors fearing crop damage: SC

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 17

STATING THAT states cannot block the elephant corridors fearing crop damage, the Supreme Court Monday asked the Centre to conduct a fresh survey of these corridors across the country.

A three-judge bench, presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, said, "We are very clear that there cannot be obstacles in the way of wildlife. Elephant herds have a practice of travelling long distances. No State can say that just because crops are getting destroyed, there have to be obstacles in their path."

The bench, also comprising Justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V. Mohana, was hearing an application which highlighted blockade of the corridors in some states.

"We have been informed that there are mandatory guidelines issued by the Ministry of Environment, Forest, Climate Change and Wildlife to ensure seamless and unobstructed elephant corridors passing through different States. However, owing to certain local factors, the elephant corridors have been impeded, choked, blocked, or obstructed...," the bench said in its order directing a fresh survey.

The top court also asked the Centre to submit a comprehensive survey report detailing the necessary steps and initiatives taken by them to prevent such obstructions.

The court said the matter will be heard after six weeks.

GURU TEG BAHADUR HOSPITAL
(GOVT. OF NCT OF DELHI)
Dilshad Garden, Delhi-110095

F.No.F.50/A&E/GTBH/2026/ date: 14/08/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
SHIFTING OF GTBH EMERGENCY SERVICE TO RAJIV GANDHI SUPER SPECIALITY HOSPITAL

It is hereby informed for the benefit of the general public that the Accident & Emergency (A&E) Services (except Gynecology & Obstetrics and Pediatrics Emergency Services) of Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital (GTBH Hospital) are being shifted to Block No. 4, Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital (RGSSH), Tahirpur, Delhi-110093 w.e.f. 18 August 2026, 9.00 A.M.

However, the Gynecology & Obstetrics and Pediatrics emergency services shall continue to operate from MCH Block, GTBH.

The public is advised to visit **Block No. 4, Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital, Tahirpur, Delhi** (Entry from Gate No. 4) for availing the above-mentioned emergency services with effect from 18th June 2026.

All concerned agencies, healthcare providers, ambulance services, and members of the public are requested to take note of the change and extend necessary cooperation.

DIP/Shubdarth/Classified/0185/26-27

Medical Director

Council of Scientific and Industrial Research
Anusandhan Bhawan, 2, Rafi Marg, New Delhi-110001
Advertisement No. R&A/01/2026
Start Date for online applications: 18th August, 2026 (10.00 AM)
Last Date for submission of online applications: 17th September, 2026 (05.00 PM)

CSIR invites online applications from eligible "Indian Citizens" for filling up 43 posts of **Technician (I) / Group-1 (I)**, in the "Pay Matrix Level-2" (Rs. 19,900-63,200), on direct recruitment basis. The complete details about the vacancies, qualification, experience, age limit and online application form etc. are available on CSIR website i.e. <http://www.csir.res.in>

CBC- 36202/11/0008/2627 Deputy Secretary (R&A)

TATA TATA POWER COMPANY LIMITED
Regd. Office: Bombay House, 24, Horni Mody Street, Mumbai 400 001.
Tel: 91 22 6665 8282, CIN: L28920MH199PC000567
Email: investorrelations@tatapower.com Website: www.tatapower.com

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS
NOTICE is hereby given that the certificate(s) for the undermentioned securities of the Company has / have been lost / misplaced and the holder(s) of the said securities / applicant(s) has / have applied to the Company to issue duplicate certificate(s). Any person who has a claim in respect of the said securities should lodge such claim with the Company at its Registered Office within 15 days from this date, else the Company will proceed to issue duplicate certificate(s) without further intimation.

Sr. no.	Folio No.	Name of Shareholder(s)	Kind of securities and face value	No. of securities	Distinctive Number(s)
1.	HSN0010499	Nand Ram Mishra	Equity Shares of ₹1/- each	5,000	15383031-15383100

For The Tata Power Company Limited Sd/-
Vipul S. Patel
Company Secretary FCS 7021

Place: Mumbai
Dated: August 17, 2026

GUJARAT ENERGY TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED
REGISTERED & CORPORATE OFFICE: SARDAR PATEL VIDYUT BHAVAN, RACECOURSE, VADODARA - 390 007
www.getcogujarat.com

TENDER NOTICE NO. ACE (P&C): TN - 11: 2026-2027

[A] PROCUREMENT: Tender No. (1) E-3T10: Purchase of G.I. Earth-wire & Stay-wire.

[B] CIVIL: ACE (P&C) CONTRACTS/ CIVIL-657, 658, 659, 661, 662, 664, 665, 667, 669, 670, 671:- (1) Construction of C.R. Building, Foundations, Cable Trench etc. at 66 kV Dhunsol S/s under Palanpur Circle, (2) Const. of C.R. Building, Foundations, Cable Trench, etc. at 66 kV Rajpuritalat S/s, and opp. end line-fay foundation at 66 kV Jamanpada S/s under Navsari Circle, (3) Providing Pile foundation for various tower locations proposed for replacement of existing 66 kV lines under Navsari Circle, (4) Const. of C.R. Building, Foundations, Cable Trench, etc. at 66 kV Dediyaan (GIDC) S/s under Mehsana circle, (5) Const. of C.R. Building, Staff Quarter etc. at 66 kV Hamla S/s under Anjar Circle, (6) Const. of First Floor C.R. Building, Foundations, Precast Cable Trench, etc. at 66 kV Sanand-III (GIDC) S/s under S'nagar Circle, (7) Const. of New C.R. building at F.F., Feeder Cable trench etc. at Existing 66 kV Vapi GIDC under Navsari Circle, (8) Const. of C.R. Building (GF) for shifting of existing C.R. with electrification, Yard Cable Trench, R.C.C. Road etc. at 66 kV Panoli 1 S/s under Bharuch Circle, (9) Const. of C'wall, RCC road, Maintenance of Existing C.R. Building, Metal Spreading etc. at 66 kV Thasara S/s under Nadiad Circle, (10) Const. of New C.R. Building (9+2 Span), RCC Road etc. at 66 kV Limbasi S/s under Nadiad Circle, (11) Const. of C.R. Building etc. at 66 kV Gada S/s under Anjar Circle.

[C] LINE: ACE (P&C)/CONTRACTS/E-503/TL/66KV/S&E:- Supply, Erection, testing & commissioning of 66 kV DC Becharji-Vithalapur line on M/C Tower with ACSR Panther Cond. (AP-14 to AP-34) 11.86Rkm under KSY Scheme.

Above tenders are available on website www.getcogujarat.com (for view and download only) & tender.nprocure.com (For view, download and online tender submissions).

Note: Bidders are requested to be in touch with our websites till opening of these tenders.

Date: 18/08/2026 Additional Chief Engineer (Procurement & Contracts)



The Indian EXPRESS

— FOUNDED BY —
RAMNATH GOENKA
— IN 1932 —

60 days on, a disturbing US-Iran stalemate

THE 60-DAY window for the US and Iran to agree on a long-term peace framework expired on Monday. On the ground, however, both sides had shut the window in late June and through July, as they traded strikes. The MoU had begun to unravel, largely over disagreements about how its terms should be interpreted. The framework also failed to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran has effectively blockaded since the Israel-US attack in late February, prompting an American counterblockade. Far from limiting hostilities, the 60-day period saw the war widen, with the Houthis and Saudi Arabia attacking each other as the Yemen-based militant group enforced a partial blockade of the Bab el-Mandeb. Both the US and Iran are now doubling down on economic warfare and both have their reasons to do so. The past 60 months have shown the US that bombing alone will not dislodge the hardline regime in Tehran and the US is running low on munitions. Iran, too, knows that the US has come to stay in the region, and that ballistic missiles fired at US bases or Israel will not change that. The deadlock means that the rest of the world remains hostage to a conflict that neither side appears capable of ending.

Trump's position has oscillated between escalatory rhetoric he has now threatened to bomb Oman if it "gets in the way" of a deal, and a more pragmatic approach. He needs to demonstrate that the pressure campaign is producing results without keeping the country trapped in another foreign war. Iran, meanwhile, must calculate how long it can afford the economic costs without making concessions. Washington has rescinded sanction waivers on Iranian oil in the international market, while threatening to maintain its naval blockade of Iranian ports "indefinitely". Tehran calculates that it can squeeze Trump until the midterms, and sees the stalemate as the new balance of power. It remains to be seen who will blink first, whether either side can gain decisive leverage to negotiate a settlement, or the deadlock becomes the new normal. Should the stalemate persist, India, which has managed the consequences so far, will have to reconsider the threat to its economic, energy and strategic interests. Diplomacy alone will not do the trick. India must reduce its overwhelming dependence on imported oil, build larger strategic petroleum reserves, and aggressively invest in alternative energy sources.

When DU chooses to shrink Delhi's past

THE REMOVAL of an elective paper on the Delhi Sultanate from Delhi University's newly notified postgraduate History syllabus, along with several long-taught papers on gender, religion and political structures in ancient India, does students a disservice. It does so not just by narrowing the choice made available to them but also by undermining their ability to engage critically. In recent years, syllabus changes have travelled steadily from schools to colleges and universities, with chapters and subjects rationalised or removed without sufficiently persuasive explanation. Reform is, of course, both desirable and necessary. But the University's explanation for the omissions — that they are intended to achieve greater balance and regional representation under the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020 — sits uneasily with the NEP's stated aim of fostering considered judgement. Higher education should complicate what students have learnt at school, place events in wider contexts and expose them to competing interpretations and historiographical perspectives. The Delhi Sultanate paper opened a window to the political formations of the 13th and 14th centuries. Its omission renders connections to a rich past more tenuous.

It is difficult to approach History as a series of discrete episodes. It is a continuum, informed, enriched and complicated by what comes before and after. The Delhi Sultanate occupies vital place in medieval history because alongside the story of powerful dynasties, it offers insights into the transformation of Delhi into a political centre — the evolution of state institutions, patronage networks, the movement of people and ideas, and the events, freedoms and unfreedoms that eventually shaped Mughal and colonial histories. This intricate tapestry cannot be reduced to neat silos. If neglected regions, communities and perspectives need greater space, the answer should be to widen the field.

That is also the broader argument of the NEP: To make education more multidisciplinary, flexible and capable of encouraging students to think independently. DU should keep that ambition in sight. At a time when debates over curricular risk turning history into a proxy battlefield for contemporary anxieties, the best defence is not a narrower syllabus but greater intellectual choice. A storied university such as DU should trust its students to navigate the past in all its complexity.

In margins of old books, what AI cannot replace

THE LLMs are hungry and only vast quantities of books can satisfy their appetite. This, according to second-hand booksellers in the UK, is why the sales of pre-owned books are seeing a sudden surge. The news follows the recent revelations about AI firm Anthropic's mysterious "Project Panama", which involves the large-scale buying and scanning of books, mostly second-hand — ironically, because the AI slop flooding the internet has rendered it a low-quality source of information and knowledge.

The fact that books of any kind are being bought in such numbers while the publishing industry is in a slump may seem, on the face of it, like good news. Look closely and it stands revealed as a false consolation. For, AI can only consume books through "destructive" scanning, a process that requires the pieces of books to be ripped off so that the pages can be rapidly scanned and the remains recycled. This digitisation by digestion is an unfortunate fate for books among which, in the words of Virginia Woolf, one might encounter a "complete stranger" who could become "the best friend we have in the world".

Because that has, for long, been the main appeal of second-hand books. Collectors are right about the charms of old, yellowing pages and their distinctive smell, as well as the secretary beauty of marginalia. It is also true that the second-hand book industry was democratising knowledge long before AI. But to browse through books once prized by others and to find among them a new love of one's own has a special allure. At a time when algorithms are determining what is seen and what is ignored, second-hand books hold out the increasingly rare promise of serendipity.

August 15 after Jantar Mantar: The many spaces of freedom — and unfreedom

THIS INDEPENDENCE Day came close on the heels of a students' movement that forced a powerful government to bend and became a liberating moment in its own right. The day after brings an occasion to stand on tip toe, look at what has moved, and what did not change.

Let's begin with freedom's heady freeze-frame. Till the Jantar Mantar moment, a narrative was becoming a stranglehold. It went like this — Congress and the regional parties are in unchecked decline and the BJP, armed with a will to power not diminished by power, enormous resources and control over central agencies, is seizing and filling spaces vacated by opposition parties. After the resignation of a Union minister in response to the protesters' demand at Jantar Mantar, that story is becoming unfrozen. A third force has flashed on the public mind, putting both the main players on notice. Suddenly, the government, too, looks vulnerable, not just the Opposition. Democracy's wet dog shake at Jantar Mantar is loosening democratic spaces.

Even though he did not mention the students' movement by name, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 1-day speech acknowledged it and sought to domesticate it. He profusely invoked "yuva shakti", but asked that it be yoked to the national project. He described the young, the protagonists of Jantar Mantar, as the "labharthi" or passive beneficiaries. This is in line with the earlier recasting by his government of the rights-bearing citizen as the recipient of state largesse and as the performer of duties.

The PM identified the challenge before the nation — the threat posed by the "digital Naxal" (one with a Naxal mindset) well after the "hathiyari Naxal" (armed insur-

gent) had been defeated. In the PM's repertoire of slurs and labels for opponents, dissenters and critics — "ecosystem", "aandolan jeevi", "urban Naxal", among others — "digital Naxal" is perhaps the most unvarnished. It takes no detours, looks for no pretexts, allows no nuances. It reaches inside the mind to criminalise the thought and idea directly.

A few days before the PM's Red Fort speech, a sessions court in Mumbai delivered an uncannily similar-sounding lesson in unfreedom as it refused anticipatory bail to two TBS students accused of raising slogans during a memorial event held in October 2025 (the Bombay High Court has subsequently given one of the two students interim protection from arrest).

The students had gathered to pay tribute to the late Delhi University professor G N Saibaba, who died shortly after his acquittal ended a prolonged incarceration in a UAPA case. The act of focused persons prepared to be not limited to paying him (Saibaba) homage. They even allegedly raised slogans, "the court said. The slogans in question sought the release of Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, former student activists flogged during UAPA, jailed now for about six years, the trial still not in sight. The court also took note of reading material recovered from the students' electronic devices, which, the prosecution said, reflected Maoist ideology. "... though the accused have not committed a criminal offence, their act coupled with the material found... raises doubt about their conduct" — the court seemed to defer, in anticipation, to the PM's coining of "digital Naxal".

In JNU, authorities withdrew permission for an event in which



VANDITA MISHRA

Umar Khalid's book was to be discussed, a PhD dissertation certified by the same university. It cited "non disclosure of full facts" — opaque bureaucracy-speak by a distinguished university once celebrated for the spaces it opened, not shut down, for questioning. And in the Capital's prestigious Sardar Patel Vidyalyaya, an 1-day address on "Why pluralism matters" by JNU professor emerita Zoya Hasan was cancelled at the last minute, because of "security concerns", a thin camouflage for a cave-in to right-wing threat-making.

The Bar Council of India chairman issued a dictat punishing the entire 2026 batch of the NALSAR University of Law, for criticism by some of them of the Chief Justice of India, and their opposition to him attending their convocation as chief guest. He retracted his repressive directive and apologised to students subsequently. But the lingering image is that of yet another institution cracking down on the freedoms of the young and the outspoken, in this case, also tomorrow's Bar and Bench, in order to cosy up to the current political/judicial regime.

The last snapshot is of Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi participating in a sexist joke on stage recently, undermining his own serious critique of Modi's personalisation of foreign policy. In a time when freedom needs to be negotiated step by difficult step, and spaces for opposition and civil society prised open carefully, the LoP's backsliding has larger costs and consequences.

The PM's new label for critics, the sessions court's constricted view, the clampdown by the premier university and school, the Bar's arrested slide and the Congress leader's crude joke — all

The students' success story is up against the congealed realities of a layered polity. Gen Z's success, therefore, lies more in what it can help illuminate, not just in what it has achieved

Tata's leadership change is an opportunity, not a crisis



HETAL DALAL



AMIT TANDON

CHANDRASEKARAN's announcement that he will not be seeking a third term should not cause investors to panic. The transition at the helm of the Tata group has a longer history, but the change has a different dynamic. If used well, it could become an opportunity for the group. While N Chandrasekaran's (Chandra) decision to not seek reappointment was not unexpected, it has caused some disquiet. Shareholders in listed Tata Group companies need not panic. The operating companies are strong businesses, have strong leadership and well-established boards. The immediate impact of this decision is limited at best. For the listed companies that Chandra chairs, a transition will be made once a successor has been appointed. For the listed companies, Chandra has had a successful run; they have grown in size and profitability, and capital has been infused and unlocked by reducing the level of cross-holdings. The group has also started investing in tomorrow's businesses. The concerns are more at the level of Tata Sons — large losses from the aviation and digital businesses, the challenges of the semiconductor foray, its contentious relationship with the RBI with respect to its listing, among others.

A leadership change at the helm of Tata Sons is not entirely a surprise. The media has reported skirmishes among the trustees of the Tata Group and between Chandra and some members of the Tata Sons board. If for nothing else, a successor would have had to be identified soon enough — Chandra is about two years away from reaching the Tata Group's mandatory retirement age for executive directors.

The Tata Group has six months to find a successor. Under Indian law, succession planning is the mandate of the nomination and remuneration committee and of the board. In Tata Sons' case, however, a selection committee must be formed — the process has already been initiated by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust — for the appointment of the chairperson. The selection committee must comprise three members nominated jointly by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust

and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, one from among Tata Sons' board, and one independent outsider; the committee's own chairmen is chosen by the trusts from among their nominees; and quorum requires a majority of the trust nominees.

The appointment of a successor now requires a fresh perspective. The ideal candidate must possess deep relationships across the bureaucracy, ministries, and regulatory bodies, demonstrate proven experience in leading large conglomerates, and exhibit a strong appetite for risk. At the same time, this individual must be capable of navigating an increasingly complex global environment shaped by geopolitical uncertainties and rapid technological advancements.

This must be seen as an opportunity by the group to build further longevity. The Tata Group has a unique holding structure, with philanthropies as the ultimate parent. For the group to truly outlive individuals, it must place its trust in seasoned professionals — both at the executive and board levels of Tata Sons — while safeguarding its core philosophy of responsible citizenship. Defining the mandate, responsibilities, and deliverables of the chairperson of Tata Sons will be central to this effort.

Equally, Tata Sons must also evolve its operating style. Its silence is no longer acceptable in the age of social media. The group's continued lack of response to controversies has allowed the narrative to be controlled by others, slowly denting its image and brand as a reputable, well-governed group known for its contribution to society and the larger societal cause.

Leadership transitions at the Tata Group have historically been fraught with contention, each shaped by its own circumstances. N Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek a third term may be less divisive, yet his successor will inherit a new set of challenges. The most pressing among them will be to reconcile differences, reimagine the group's structure, and chart a path that secures both stability and renewal.

Dalal is president and COO, and Tandon is managing director of Institutional Investor Advisory Services India Limited



SABINE AMEER

FIVE YEARS on, the Taliban govern Afghanistan with a confidence that would have been difficult to imagine in 2021, consolidating power and establishing a functioning, yet highly repressive, state. While the Taliban claim they have brought peace and security, absence of battles and the end of the war have not guaranteed the conditions for justice, inclusion, dignity and cohesion. A country in which half the population is systematically excluded from public life cannot meaningfully be described as at peace.

Afghan women remain the most visible casualties of Taliban rule. As of 2026, an estimated 2.4 million Afghan girls are excluded from secondary education. The Taliban's restrictions have narrowed women's access to employment, healthcare, public spaces, movement and political participation. More than 100 restrictive decrees and measures have been issued since 2021, institutionalising a system of gender-based exclusion. Excluding women from the economy deprives Afghanistan of the human resources it will need to rebuild, and restrictions on female human resources make it harder for aid to reach women and children.

The international community faces a different dilemma: How to engage a regime you do not recognise without normalising the system it has created? Most countries still do not formally recognise the Taliban government, but diplomatic engagement has expanded. China, Iran, Pakistan, India, Turkey and Central Asian states have maintained varying degrees of contact with Kabul, driven by security, trade, migration and regional interests. Russia went further and recognised the regime last year. Western governments continue to maintain channels with the de-facto authorities over humanitarian assistance and counterterrorism.

Regional states cannot ignore the security and migration consequences of isolating Afghanistan. Diplomatic engagement is necessary to negotiate access, protect aid workers and exert whatever influence remains for regional stability. But if governments deepen relations with Kabul while women's exclusion becomes a permanent background condition, the Taliban receive a powerful message: Repression may attract condemnation, but not enough to fundamentally obstruct international engagement. This is why the international community needs to distinguish between engaging Afghanistan and legitimising Taliban rule.

The Taliban survived isolation opened channels for international engagement, and demonstrated that military victory can be converted into political endurance. Yet the country remains economically fragile and dependent on humanitarian support while simultaneously cut off from the human capital it could develop. The lesson of the past five years is neither that the international community should have remained in Afghanistan indefinitely nor that engagement with the Taliban should be rejected outright. But the growing temptation to treat Afghanistan as a settled case, and engaging the Taliban simply because they control the state and because humanitarian aid is vital for its recovery, risks turning pragmatic engagement into de-facto normalisation.

The writer is a contributing researcher with ORF

40 YEARS AGO August 18, 1986



Police firing in Pakistan

SEVERAL HUNDRED demonstrators burned tyres and barricaded streets in the southern part of Karachi with oil drums and vehicles, hurling rocks at the police, who responded with tear gas. One person was killed as the police opened fire on anti-government demonstrators who stormed the streets for the fifth consecutive day. The demonstrators engaged the police in battles marked by gunfire and rock-throwing to protest against five soldiers being killed in Lahore and the arrests of hundreds of opposition leaders.

Sudanese rebels down plane

ABOUT 60 passengers and crew were feared

killed when a Sudan Airways Fokker Friendship was shot down by rebels near the south Sudanese town of Malakal, the official Sudanese News Agency (SUNA) reported. The plane carried 57 passengers and an unknown number of crew, when it was hit during a flight from Malakal airport to Khartoum. East African aviation sources in Nairobi said the crew radioed a final plea for help at 0829 GMT, just after the plane took off.

Soviet Mi-26 for Air Force

THE INDIAN AIR FORCE (IAF) is going in for a military heavy-lift helicopter called Mi-26 from the Soviet Union to augment its helicopter fleet, it is learnt. The Mi-26, which has been code-named "Halo-7" by NATO coun-

tries, is believed to be the heaviest and most powerful helicopter in use in the world.

Housing projects on hold

THE MINISTRY of Urban Development has received a severe jolt by one of its projects in the field of housing finance and urban improvement still pending clearance in the Finance Ministry — more than six months after their submission. The projects were submitted to the Finance Ministry after a long delay in the Ministry of Urban Development, which claimed that the implementation of the projects would bring about a revolution in the field of housing construction in the country.



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• LAW

Notices to actors: What law says on surrogate ads

Abhinav Chakraborty
New Delhi, August 17

MAHARASHTRA'S FOOD and Drug Administration (FDA) issued show-cause notices to Bollywood actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn, and Tiger Shroff last week, alleging that their advertisement for Vimal Elaiichi amounts to surrogate advertising for Vimal Pan Masala.

The notices ask the three actors to explain their role in the ad, which in the FDA's assessment, creates an association with the Vimal Pan Masala brand — a product currently prohibited in the state — and could amount to its indirect promotion.

The latest action reportedly marks the first instance of the regulator examining surrogate advertising even as it ramps up its crackdown on gutkha and pan masala containing tobacco or nicotine.

What the notices say

Maharashtra has prohibited gutkha and pan masala containing tobacco since 2012 under Section 202(A) of the Food Safety and Standards (FSS) Act, 2006. The prohibition is renewed annually, with the current renewal in force since July 13, 2026.

According to the FDA, the Vimal Elaiichi ad's presentation, dialogue, product name, and market context raise a "serious question" over whether it constitutes indirect or surrogate promotion of a prohibited tobacco-related product. The regulator said given all three actors appear as brand endorser, their direct participation is liable to be examined under various provisions of the FSS Act.

PAST SCRUTINY
In 2018, the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) issued show-cause notices to Vimal Elaiichi's promoter, Vishnu Pouch Packaging Pvt Ltd, alleging indirect advertising of tobacco products. The company challenged the notices in court.

In January 2024, the Delhi HC dismissed DGHS appeals, saying that the company had a "fundamental right to carry on business" of "pan masala sales" and "tobacco" as long as it has constitutional sanctity.

The guidelines define "surrogate advertisement" as "an advertisement for goods, product or service, whose advertising is otherwise prohibited or restricted by law, by circumventing such prohibition or restriction and portraying it to be an advertisement for other goods, product or service, the advertising of which is not prohibited or restricted by law".

Penalties for violations are clearly outlined. CCPA can impose a penalty of up to Rs 10 lakh on manufacturers, advertisers, and endorser for any misleading advertisements. For subsequent contraventions, CCPA may impose a penalty of up to Rs 50 lakh. CCPA can prohibit the endorser of a misleading advertisement from making any endorsement for up to 1 year and up to 3 years for subsequent contravention.

The crackdown

The FDA has stepped up enforcement across a range of food-safety concerns, from adulterated milk and food served at restaurants to the sale of junk food in and around schools and the manufacture and sale of banned gutkha and tobacco-containing pan masala. Between May 25 and July 31, the FDA raided 658 establishments where banned products were found, seized stock worth Rs 15.1 crore, registered 519 FIRs, and made 701 arrests. It also seized 78 vehicles carrying banned goods worth Rs 6.6 crore.

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Lucknow 20 अगस्त | सुबह 11:30 बजे 26 Aug | 11:30 AM
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• GLOBAL

Hamas has agreed to disarm, but Netanyahu's ambitions still keep Israel at Hamas

Rishika Singh

New Delhi, August 17

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump's envoy and son-in-law, Jared Kushner, met Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Monday for talks, a day after meeting Hamas chief Khalil al-Hayya.

The consecutive meetings came as the Trump-led Board of Peace attempts to secure peace for Gaza. Netanyahu has rejected the latest peace plan, putting forth one condition for the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) withdrawal from the territory.

"The IDF will not carry out any withdrawal until Hamas is disarmed... we are talking with the Americans about this issue," Netanyahu said. Israel has also resumed its drone strikes on Gaza.

In late July, Trump said the board reached a "historic" 15-point agreement for disarming Hamas. This was read as an unexpected concession from Hamas, which, in turn, said that the IDF must withdraw completely from Gaza first.

Behind Hamas's disarmament

The Board of Peace plan included provisions on returning Palestinian detainees and prisoners, and a temporary International Stabilisation Force for Gaza's security.

While Hamas's disarmament was then seen as unlikely, the shift reflects the limited avenues for breakthrough as the conflict drags on, said Islam Alhalawany, Principal at London-based QELA Advisory and a specialist in West Asian politics.

Since 2023, more than 73,000 Palestinians have been killed in Israel's war in Gaza. "The military situation reached a deadlock. Israel cannot displace Palestinians further, and Hamas cannot deter Israeli incursions or address the humanitarian collapse after three years. Flexibility became rational," Alhalawany told *The Indian Express*.

He also noted the role of mediators Egypt, Turkey and Qatar, who were thanked by Trump as well. "Hamas appears convinced — partly through pressure from Islamic mediators — that demon-

strating compliance will help expose Israel's rogue posture internationally. This is what is called 'Wedge Strategy', and here, it works by enhancing the split between Washington and Tel Aviv. Meanwhile, maintaining the ceasefire would allow a breathing space to the tiny, besieged enclave of Gaza."

Netanyahu's stakes

With two months left for the Israeli legislative elections, Netanyahu faces many political challenges. These will be the first elections held since the October 7, 2023 Hamas attacks, where he was criticised for the security failure.

Polls show that Netanyahu's coalition — often termed the most right-wing government in Israeli history — could fall short of the majority mark. For Netanyahu, this is significant, because he has linked his personal standing with his prime ministerial role and the war on Gaza.

In 2025, he asked the country's president to grant him a pardon from corruption



Displaced Palestinian children carry food portions in central Gaza. AP

charges, stating that the request would help unify the country at a time of momentous change, the AP had reported. Alhalawany said that disarming Hamas was a "natural ask" given his political concerns, but also

shows Netanyahu's broader strategy. "Israel's constituencies around the war are divided into two; one is concerned with Israel's global image and fears over-stretching Tel Aviv's relationship with Washington, while the second is clearly inclined for a more assertive posture at all expense. Netanyahu chose the latter a long time ago, and his maximalist posture on every front shows he's pursuing this strategy for political survival," he said.

This is also reflected in rising attacks against Palestinians. Despite the 2025 ceasefire, UN experts this month "condemned the sharp escalation of attacks against Palestinian civilians". Settler violence — committed by Israelis who live in territories captured by Israel in 1967, primarily the West Bank — has also risen. Far-right Israeli ministers have also called for intensifying attacks on Gaza.

Add to this the sour sentiment among at least some Israelis over the US-Iran deal, which was seen as giving concessions to the Jewish state's main adversary state.

States' revenue loss

Last week, Jarkhand CM Soren, in a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, said mining revenue accounted for approximately 84.9% of the state's own tax revenue in 2024-25. Soren claimed the Mineral Bearing Land Cess, which the state

has been imposing on mining companies, was expected to generate approximately Rs 11,000 crore annually.

"These figures demonstrate that mineral-related revenues are not marginal receipts but a critical component of the state's fiscal capacity," the letter read.

Prabhat Ranjan, Senior Director at Nexdigm, a global consulting and advisory firm, said the amendments would, in effect, serve as a cost-containment and investment-certainty measure for mining companies, but concerns over potential revenue loss for states cannot be brushed aside. "The Centre should use the new framework to establish reasonable and transparent guardrails, while ensuring adequate consultation with mineral-producing states," he said.

The dispute

The Centre's stand is that unchecked state-level levies could raise the cost of key minerals, feeding into inflation and infrastructure costs.

States have raised concerns over loss of revenue as well as over the Bill's implications for India's federal structure.

• SPACE

NASA's Moon Base: What India will gain by joining



AMITABH SINHA

THE RECENT invitation to join NASA's Moon Base programme can be an important turning point in the history of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), one that can potentially put it on an entirely different trajectory.

The invitation itself was not surprising, considering that India has already signed the Artemis Accords, and entered into a strategic partnership with the US on human spaceflight missions. Yet, given the extremely volatile relationship between the two countries in the last couple of years, this initiative to forge a closer partnership on space is a refreshing move.

In scale and ambition, the Moon Base programme can be compared only to the Apollo missions. In terms of its impact on humanity and the future of the planet, it could turn out to be far more consequential.

Setting the Moon

The programme is about creating a permanent research station on the Moon, one that can be inhabited by astronauts, and robots, for prolonged periods of time. The base, to be built in stages over several years, is meant to facilitate research, and allow exploration and exploitation of lunar resources. It will possibly be the most challenging engineering exercise ever undertaken, requiring several trips to the Moon by crewed and robotic missions. It could also be the costliest scientific project ever.

NASA is in no position, and does not want, to execute this entirely on its own. Its budget has been slashed significantly under the Donald Trump administration, while most of its hardware production is now happening in the private sector. So, it is seeking partners — both in the international community as well as in the private industry, to collaborate with.

The 70 countries that have signed on to the Artemis Accords have, in a way, already shown a willingness to join such a collaboration. This includes some major space-faring countries like Japan, India, South Korea, and Israel, besides several European countries.

In just six years, the Artemis Accords



MOON BASE: A THREE-PHASE PROGRAMME
The Moon Base is humanity's first lunar outpost, a place where astronauts will live, work, and explore near the Moon's South Pole.

PHASE ONE (NOW-2029): Focus will be on gaining reliable access to the lunar surface and building a deeper understanding of the environment. Robotic missions will explore the lunar South Pole, demonstrate new technologies, and gather the knowledge needed to guide future development.

PHASE TWO (2029-2032): NASA will begin deploying the first infrastructure needed to support long-term operations on the Moon. Early power systems, cargo transportation, logistics, and communications capabilities will expand humanity's footprint and enable increasingly complex missions.

PHASE THREE (2032 AND BEYOND): NASA will begin assembling a permanent lunar outpost where astronauts can live and work for extended periods. Habitats, power systems, communications, transportation, and other critical capabilities will support an enduring human presence. SOURCE: NASA

has come up as a unique grouping of countries interested in exploration of outer space. Although the Accords are a set of principles and good practices that countries agree to follow in their space activities, they are increasingly being seen as a US-led camp seeking to write its own rules for space exploration and use of extraterrestrial resources, subtly bypassing international multilateral arrangements.

That two major space powers, Russia and China, are not part of the group, gives credence to this argument. India has traditionally been extremely reluctant to join any such group. But it was one of the early signatories to the Accords, joining as the 27th nation in 2023. There is no official confirmation as of now, but it is very likely that ISRO would join the Moon Base programme.

Not adversarial

It makes eminent sense for it to do so.

Artemis Accords

The Accords, introduced by NASA and the US Department of State in 2020, are a set of principles that countries agree to follow in space activities.

The 70 signatories include Japan, India, Israel, and South Korea.

ISRO has its own plans for human spaceflight missions, setting up a space station, and even landing humans on the Moon. Joining Moon Base offers the opportunity for it to gain valuable experience in planning and executing complex missions like these, and leapfrog in technology development. ISRO has demonstrated its capabilities in executing such missions on its own as well, but that would require time and huge amounts of money.

Space exploration is reaching a stage where a 10-year gap in technology development can leave a nation fairly well behind. Besides, it would not make economic sense to reinvent the wheel. ISRO's current plans — an independent human spaceflight programme, a Moon landing programme, and a full-fledged space station — are extremely ambitious. It is, no doubt, extremely important to have these capabilities. But it is difficult to imagine that India would have the scientific and econ-

omic rationale for running these sustainably on its own.

The Bharat Antariksh Station is a case in point. While ISRO must have the technology and capability to build such space infrastructure, it is extremely unlikely that India would have, in about a decade's time, a scientific ecosystem hungry enough to need an entire space station for its own use all year round. It will have to be a shared infrastructure like the International Space Station.

Similarly, maintaining a separate full-fledged programme for lunar exploration might not be economically feasible. The costs are prohibitively high even for the leading economy and richest country of the world. For India, which is chasing multiple parallel goals on the path to prosperity, it might be difficult to allocate resources on the scale required.

The concerns about India joining what appears like a US-led bloc might be overstated. The Artemis Accords are not like a geopolitical or military camp. Space, for now, is not adversarial. If the US lands on the Moon ahead of others, it does not get to control the area or the resources. It does not harm the interests of China or Russia, which are attempting to do the same thing through their own partnership.

The Moon is large enough, and its resources abundant enough, to support the efforts of all the parties, at least in the foreseeable future. So, the current trend of de-globalisation, or go-it-alone approach, in matters of critical technologies like semiconductors, clean energy, and artificial intelligence does not apply in the case of space. There is no domination of supply chains or control over resources.

For India, signing the Artemis Accords, or joining the Moon Base effort, does not prevent it from continuing its long-standing space cooperation with Russia, for example. ISRO, however, needs to ensure that while collaborating with the US, it doesn't lose sight of its own targets and objectives or doesn't get locked into the US technology ecosystem to the extent of overdependence. The Accords do emphasise on development of interoperable systems, but it is not a major restriction for ISRO, which is just beginning to develop these systems.

So, the space cooperation with the US is a major opportunity for ISRO to fast-track its project timelines, and get to the frontiers of technology development. It could result in a lot of spin-off benefits that can bring cascading dividends across sectors.

• POLICY

The Centre-states tussle over the Mines and Minerals Bill

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 17

THE PASSAGE of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Parliament last week has reignited a long-running tussle between the Centre and states over taxation of mineral resources and the revenues they generate.

The amendments seek to restrict states from imposing specified levies on mineral rights and mineral-bearing land, which they had been exploring following the Supreme Court's landmark 2024 ruling upholding their power to tax mineral rights. The Bill has drawn sharp opposition from states. Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren has threatened protests against the amendments, saying they could significantly dent the state's prospective revenue, while Kerala Chief Minister V D Satheesan has raised concerns over their implications for India's federal structure.

The Bill will also extinguish unpaid or uncovered dues arising from such levies imposed before it comes into force, with some estimates putting the value of such

outstanding dues across the mining sector at around Rs 2 lakh crore. The Centre's stand is that unchecked state-level levies could raise the cost of key minerals, feeding into inflation and infrastructure costs.

Fiscal certainty for industry

According to Mines Ministry officials, the amendments seek to address what the Centre considers excessive cess and other levies imposed by some states following the Supreme Court's 2024 judgment.

The July 25, 2024 ruling overruled the 1989 ruling in *India Cement Ltd v. State of Tamil Nadu*, which had held that royalty was a tax and that states lacked the legislative competence to tax mineral rights, as the subject fell under the Union List.

B K Bhatia, mining industry expert and former Director General of the Federation of Indian Mineral Industries, told *The Indian Express* that the amendments would help prevent states from imposing multiple and excessive levies on mining companies.

"Apart from royalty, District Mineral Foundation and National Mineral Exploration and Development Trust contribu-

Implications for federalism

● The Bill has drawn sharp opposition from states, who have raised concerns over loss of prospective revenue.

● The Centre's stand is that unchecked state-level levies could raise the cost of key minerals, feeding into inflation.

tions, mining companies currently pay various other cesses, including environmental and pollution cesses. But the mineral-bearing land tax was the biggest additional burden on the industry," Bhatia said.

According to him, while the amendments will help the industry by providing greater certainty over the fiscal burden, they are unlikely to result in any material revenue loss for states, as most of these levies have been legally contested for decades, resulting in large amounts of pending dues.

A senior official at the Mines Ministry said there are around 14 levies in the mineral sector, which will stay. "All we are saying is all these levies together should not go beyond a certain percentage," the official said, adding that this percentage would be decided after consultation with all the states.

States' revenue loss

Last week, Jarkhand CM Soren, in a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, said mining revenue accounted for approximately 84.9% of the state's own tax revenue in 2024-25. Soren claimed the Mineral Bearing Land Cess, which the state

has been imposing on mining companies, was expected to generate approximately Rs 11,000 crore annually.

"These figures demonstrate that mineral-related revenues are not marginal receipts but a critical component of the state's fiscal capacity," the letter read.

Prabhat Ranjan, Senior Director at Nexdigm, a global consulting and advisory firm, said the amendments would, in effect, serve as a cost-containment and investment-certainty measure for mining companies, but concerns over potential revenue loss for states cannot be brushed aside. "The Centre should use the new framework to establish reasonable and transparent guardrails, while ensuring adequate consultation with mineral-producing states," he said.

The dispute

The Centre's stand is that unchecked state-level levies could raise the cost of key minerals, feeding into inflation and infrastructure costs.

States have raised concerns over loss of revenue as well as over the Bill's implications for India's federal structure.

CENTRE TO FORM HIGH-POWERED PANEL ON BANKING REFORMS FOR VIKSIT BHARAT SOON

FM-bankers meet: Mobilisation of deposits, banking for GenZ in focus

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, August 17

ADDRESSING THE banking needs of Gen Z and ways to boost deposit mobilisation took centre stage at a key two-day meeting of the public sector banks and the Ministry of Finance starting Monday, where heads of key financial institutions are expected to produce "workable ideas" for banking sector reforms.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said banks are in a better position to take up reforms as non-performing assets (NPAs) are at the lowest level ever, adding that the future of banking must reflect the aspirations of India's youth, with 29% of India's population between 15 and 29 years of age. The high-level committee for banking with a focus on "banking for Viksit Bharat", which was announced in this year's Budget, will be announced soon, she said.

"Intensive discussions today and tomorrow come at a time when we expect the announcement of the high-powered committee to look into banking for Viksit Bharat. The recommendations [after this discussion] would help us to clearly understand where the committee wants India to go towards Viksit

Bharat and in that the role of banks," Sitharaman said. The minister further said, "It is your output that I am keenly looking forward to because once the committee gives its input, it's for us to rapidly move in that direction, understanding that the Viksit Bharat 2047 is actually not too far away. We are in 2026, so less than or short of 20 years is what we have before us."

The meeting was structured around seven themes covering key areas of opportunity for PSBs and PFIs, including 'deposit mobilisation', 'banking for youth', 'supporting the investment cycle', 'global capability centres', 'agriculture & horticulture value chain infrastructure, priority sector lending and 're-imagining credit card business'.

A banking sector executive who participated in the meeting told The Indian Express that several ideas were discussed, particularly on how to mobilise deposits and "finance the aspirations of the youth." "There have been discussions on the new structured products which give more flexibility and better returns. For instance, when we talk about mobilisation of deposits, we are looking at what type of credit flows are required to achieve the kind of GDP needed



FM Nirmala Sitharaman said banks are in a better position to take up reforms as NPAs are at the lowest level ever. PRAVEEN KHANNA

group of 15-29 years.

The discussion comes as India's household debt has surged in recent years, and financial sector regulators are particularly concerned about the composition of that debt. Non-housing retail loans — largely used for consumption — now account for more than half of household borrowings, and have grown faster than housing, agriculture and business loans, a trend flagged in internal discussions among policymakers, as this newspaper had reported earlier.

Another banker said the meeting was very focused on addressing the needs of the youth at every level, starting from education to various levels, particularly in the age

FM asks states to address land, connectivity bottlenecks

New Delhi: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said industrial corridors are an important pillar to expand manufacturing and urged states to resolve bottlenecks relating to land, connectivity, utilities, and statutory clearances.

Chairing the three meeting of the apex monitoring authority of the National Industrial Corridor Development and Implementation Trust (NICIT) here, she stressed that the focus must now move beyond project approvals towards timely completion of infrastructure, land allotment, investment and commencement of production.

"She urged states to resolve bottlenecks relating to land, connectivity, utilities, statutory clearances and the powers of project Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs)," the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement. PTI

CERC lets RE developers retain grid connectivity despite project delays

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 17

IN A major relief for renewable energy developers, the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) has introduced a compensation-based mechanism allowing projects that miss key implementation deadlines to retain their grid connectivity and seek additional time to complete them, instead of facing automatic revocation of transmission access.

Renewable developers can lose their connectivity if they fail to meet three major project deadlines: submitting land ownership documents, achieving financial closure, or missing their commercial operationalisation deadline.

As per the data from Central Transmission Utility of India Ltd (CTUIL), at least 5.3 gigawatts (GW) of renewable energy capacity is expected to face connectivity revocation in the October 2026 period for failure to achieve commercial operationalisation date.

The latest order comes as some renewable energy developers have approached the CERC seeking additional time to achieve the milestones after receiving notices from CTUIL.

"The entities seeking such time are at various stages of implementation of the project, including some at an advanced stage of implementation. Several such cases have been disposed of by this commission, giving additional time on payment of compensation," the CERC order read.

It stressed the need for an immediate requirement to handle such cases uniformly, in which entities have made progress towards project implementation and are seeking additional time to meet the milestones under the General Network Access Regulations.

"It is noted that such entities have been holding on to the connectivity, a scarce resource; therefore, additional time should be allowed, with payment of compensation, irrespective of the reasons for such delay, in a graded manner to ensure the earliest compliance with the milestones," it added.

Eligibility to qualify for extension

In its order, CERC specifies that developers must meet strict eligibility criteria, such as securing a minimum percentage of required land, to qualify for these extensions. Compensation would be levied based on the specific milestone for which an extension is sought, with rates generally increasing over time to encourage early compliance. Clean energy developers will have to pay Rs 1,000 per megawatt (MW) per day to obtain extra time for land and financial closure, while Rs 3,000 per MW per day for delays in starting commercial operations.

To qualify for an extension, an entity must demonstrate progress by meeting minimum thresholds at least 15 working days prior to the original milestone deadline.

For land and financial closure, the developer must furnish land documents for at least 20% of the required land. For extensions in commercial operation date, entities would be required to furnish land documents of 50% to 75% of the required land depending on the project type.

Developers can get up to three additional months to complete land requirements, six months to achieve financial closure and as much as 12 months to commission projects, it read.

If these projects still fail to meet the deadlines, they risk losing their grid connectivity and associated bank guarantees. The order also clarified that 100% of the compensation collected for delays in commercial operations, and 50% of the compensation collected for allowing additional time to submit land documents and achieve financial closure, would be used to reduce the Monthly Transmission Charges for other users under the Sharing Regulations, 2020.

• **BRIEFLY**

Rupee falls as RBI shuts FCNR(B) window early

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) decision to prematurely close its concessional swap facility for FCNR(B) deposits, coupled with a rise in crude oil prices to nearly \$90 a barrel, sent the rupee lower on Monday, though intervention by the central bank prevented a sharper slide. Despite a softer dollar, the rupee was the worst performing currency in Asia, depreciating 0.2% to close at a July low of 95.61 against the dollar as importers rushed to take forward cover. Exporters are holding back dollar sales even as importers are stepping up purchases. FE

• **MARKETS**

SENSEX 77,728.16
NIFTY 24,287.65
GOLD \$1,54,167
SILVER \$23,562
OIL \$95.61
US DOLLAR \$95.61

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES ARE PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 100, SILVER PER 1 KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 14, 2026

Govt nod to 31 more applications for electronic components mfg sops

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, August 17

THE MINISTRY OF Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has approved 31 more applications under the Electronics Components Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS), entailing a proposed investment of Rs 787.7 crore, as the government looks to deepen domestic manufacturing beyond finished electronic products and into components and sub-assemblies.

The projects, spread across 10 states, are expected to lead to production worth Rs 82,243 crore and create close to 10,000 direct jobs, IT Secretary S Krishnan said Monday.

The latest approvals cover a wide range of products, including capital goods, camera and display modules, anode materials, enclosures, connectors, rare-earth permanent magnets, optical transceivers, speakers and microphones, antennas, capacitors, coils and

The government looks to deepen domestic manufacturing beyond finished electronic products and into components and sub-assemblies

filters, among others. An enhanced investment in copper-clad laminates by Wipro Global, which had received an earlier approval, is also part of the latest tranche.

With this, the government has approved 106 applications covering around 30 product categories across 15 states under the scheme. Cumulative proposed investment from the approved projects has reached Rs 69,548 crore, crossing the scheme's original investment target of Rs 59,350 crore. Expected production from these

projects stands at Rs 54.34 lakh crore, compared with an original target of Rs 4.56 lakh crore. The selected companies, so far, have committed to create close to 75,000 jobs, as opposed to the scheme's total target of 91,600.

Some of the projects approved earlier under the scheme have already started production. ATL's lithium-ion cell facilities at Rewari and Sohna, and Tata Electronics' enclosure plant in Hosur, are currently operational. IT Secretary S Krishnan said. Several others are nearing commissioning. Keynotes Circuits' PCB plant near Chennai is expected to start operations within about a month. Mother'son's enclosure facility in Kanchipuram and Wipro Global's copper-clad laminate plant in the next two-three months, while Dixon's display and camera module facility in Noida is expected to go live within four months.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CAS here to stay, reviewing concerns raised by mkt participants: SEBI chief

Kushan Shah
Mumbai, August 17

THE SECURITIES AND Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairman Tuhin Kant Pandey on Monday made it clear that the recently introduced clearing and settlement (CAS) is here to stay, even as the market regulator looks at ways to address concerns raised by market participants.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the SEBI Sym-

posium on Cyber Defence in Mumbai, Pandey added, "... We will see if there are certain constraints or issues that we can improve, and certainly we will improve."

The market regulator is currently analysing data on trading activity during CAS — a special trading window to determine the closing price for stocks with futures & options (F&O) contracts — as well as feedback on concerns raised by market participants and other market participants.

Pandey emphasised that SEBI cannot react to every suggestion or criticism of the mechanism, which he described as a major market reform. "We are looking at all the suggestions. I have myself seen a number of suggestions which have come from social media. Our teams have gone through them and they are discussing them with the regulators," he said.

Pandey said many of the concerns caused by as participation in CAS increases. FE

Lithium projects lost to POSCO

In December 2024, a consortium comprising KABIL, Coal India Ltd (CIL), Oil India Ltd (OIL), and ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL) submitted a non-binding offer (NBO) of \$184 million to acquire 10% equity stake each in the Mt Marion and Wodgina lithium mines in Australia. The proposed transaction involved acquiring a 20% stake in the holding company, Mineral Resources Ltd, which owned 50% stakes in both mines. After the process was reopened, the consortium submitted a revised NBO of \$233 million in September 2025, seeking to acquire a 20% stake in each of the two

mines. This would have entailed acquiring a 40% stake in Mineral Resources Ltd.

But the assets were ultimately acquired by South Korean steel and chemical

major POSCO, which paid \$765 million for 15% stake each in the Wodgina and Mt Marion mines, equivalent to a 30% stake in Mineral Resources Ltd.

When a parliamentary

Tata Sons AGM faces quorum uncertainty

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 17

WHILE EFFORTS are underway to ensure the smooth conduct of Tata Sons' annual general meeting (AGM) scheduled for August 18, the meeting is likely to be adjourned if there is a lack of quorum. The regulatory freeze imposed on the Sir Ratan Tata Trust has left the Tata holding company unable to secure the shareholder representation required to convene the meeting.

The issue stems from Tata Sons' Articles of Association, which stipulates that at least five members must be personally present to constitute a quorum. Crucially, the quorum must include an authorised representative jointly nominated by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust. "Efforts are on to conduct the AGM smoothly," said a source.

All the parties concerned — including Tata Trusts, the Shapoorji Pallonji Group, Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran and other shareholders — are keen to ensure that the upcoming AGM proceeds smoothly without any disruption. The meeting is particularly significant for shareholders, as the dividend payout will be formally approved at the AGM, paving the way for them to receive the declared dividend in their hands.

Additionally, the AGM will have to consider and approve the resolution for the reappointment of SRTT to voluntarily relinquish their status as lifetime trustees and, thereafter, renominates themselves as trustees for a fixed and clearly defined tenure. Such a restructuring could bring the trust's governance framework into conformity with the amended Maharashtra Public Trusts Act.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

dividend, shareholders get the money in their hands. Further, the resolution for the reappointment of Chandrasekaran as director will also have to be cleared by the AGM," said a Tata source.

The issue arises from the inability of the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), which holds a 25.56% stake in Tata Sons, to convene a board meeting following an order issued by the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner in May. The order has effectively prevented the trust from conducting its board proceedings while an inquiry into the composition of its board is pending.

This has created a procedural hurdle for Tata Sons. In the absence of a duly convened SRTT board meeting, the trust cannot jointly nominate a representative with the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT). "Efforts are on to conduct the AGM smoothly," said a source.

A possible way forward would be for the existing "lifetime trustees" of SRTT to voluntarily relinquish their status as lifetime trustees and, thereafter, renominates themselves as trustees for a fixed and clearly defined tenure. Such a restructuring could bring the trust's governance framework into conformity with the amended Maharashtra Public Trusts Act.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

panel, whose report was tabled in the Parliament on August 12, sought details from KABIL, an unsuccessful bid, the company outlined several key lessons from the failed attempt. These included the absence of a

domestic value chain for spodumene concentrate, the end product of the Mt Marion and Wodgina projects, high volatility in lithium prices, significant variations in long-term spodumene concentrate price forecasts published by different market intelligence agencies, and the high valuation of assets amid intense competition for lithium projects.

KABIL also failed to submit



At least 5.3 GW of renewable energy capacity is expected to face connectivity revocation up to October, Reuters

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involving Chile's state-owned mining company ENAMI, KABIL had signed an NDA to evaluate potential business opportunities across the lithium value chain, including exploration, extraction, processing, and commercialisation. However, KABIL decided to hand over the opportunity to CIL, citing its "limited financial capacity" and the investment requirements associated with developing the five lithium brine blocks it acquired in Argentina in January 2024.

Queries sent to KABIL, and the Ministry of Mines remained unanswered till press time.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

No breakthrough in Kushner's talks with Israel & Hamas on Trump's Gaza plan

Alexander Cornwell
Jerusalem, August 17

DONALD TRUMP'S envoy and son-in-law Jared Kushner on Monday wrapped up two days of meetings with Israeli and Hamas leaders to break a stalemate over the US president's Gaza plan, but there were no signs of an imminent breakthrough as both sides dug in. Kushner met Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in Israel a day after meeting Hamas' political leader in Egypt in a bid to revive the plan, which has stalled as Israel has carried out air strikes and seized more territory in Gaza despite an October ceasefire, while Hamas has refused to give up its weapons.

Trump last month announced that Hamas had agreed to lay down its arms in phases, under a 15-point roadmap put forward by his so-called Board of Peace to advance the president's plan, as Israel's military withdraws from Gaza. Hamas said it agreed to the roadmap but implementation depended on Israel first meeting its own commitments, including halting attacks and withdrawing.

Netanyahu, whose ruling coalition is trailing in Israeli



Khaled Qaddoumi, the Hamas representative in Iran, speaks during a press conference in Tehran on Monday. AP

opinion polls ahead of an October national election, earlier this month rejected the roadmap, insisting Israel would not withdraw until Hamas is completely disarmed.

An Israeli official indicated that there was no breakthrough in the meeting, saying Netanyahu had made it clear the military would not withdraw from a demarcation line set out in an October ceasefire and would continue to carry out operations in Gaza as it sees necessary.

The Israeli official said Netanyahu and Kushner agreed in the meeting that the reconstruction of Gaza would not begin until Hamas was fully disarmed, including of light weapons. REUTERS

TRUMP SAYS HE WILL BOMB OMAN IF IT 'GETS IN THE WAY'

Iran vows to go on offensive in Strait if talks with US fail

Tehran has been negotiating a deal on Hormuz with Oman separately

Parisa Hafezi
& Katharine Jackson
Dubai, Washington, August 17

IRAN HAS decided to shift its policy from defensive to "fully offensive" due to the deadlock in efforts to agree a permanent end to its war with the United States, a senior Iranian official told Reuters on Monday.

Progress towards peace talks and a resumption of oil tanker traffic through the strategic Strait of Hormuz has ground to a halt, with no sign that the warring parties are moving towards ending the conflict that the US and Israel launched on February 28.

"Iranian entities must be prepared to escalate tensions in the Strait of Hormuz and wider region, as Iran will be ready to make decisions and take action on difficult decisions," the Iranian official said, adding that Tehran would conduct a "timely and precise" military attack to break the US naval



Vessels near the Strait of Hormuz, seen from Oman on Monday. REUTERS

blockade if diplomacy failed.

There was no immediate response to those comments from Washington, but US President Donald Trump said in a phone interview with Fox News on Monday that Iran "should put up the white flag of surrender".

Monday marked the day by which Iran and the US were expected to reach a final deal under a memorandum of understanding agreed in June and aimed at ending the war.

Signed on June 17, the MoU set out a 60-day timeframe, extendable by mutual consent, by which Washington and Tehran should reach a broader agree-

ment on issues including limiting Tehran's nuclear programme and lifting US sanctions.

That interim deal, which declared the "immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts", quickly unravelled, however, due to a dispute over control of the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow waterway through which a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas flowed before the war.

Tehran said point 5 of the MoU gave it the right to manage the strait, which it shares with Oman, while Washington rejected that interpretation. Hostilities resumed as Tehran began

Houthi say they attacked Saudi military vessels

YEMEN'S Houthi attacked what they described as a Saudi military ship and four escort vessels in the Red Sea with missiles, according to the group's military spokesperson Yahya Saree on Telegram on Monday. There was no immediate confirmation from Saudi authorities. Mocha is a Red Sea port near the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a strategic chokepoint connecting the Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden and an important international shipping route.

firing on vessels it said were trying to sail through the waterway on an unapproved route.

Tehran has separately been negotiating an agreement with Oman over management of the strait, seen as a key component of a wider deal, and says they are close to agreement, although progress has been slow.

"If Oman gets in the way, we'll bomb the shit out of them," Trump told Fox. There was no immediate comment from Oman. REUTERS

Ukraine energy plant suffers 13 Russian strikes in a week

Moscow is set to 'weaponize winter', say Kyiv officials

Associated Press
Kyiv, August 17

RUSSIA ATTACKED facilities of Ukraine's Naftogaz Group 13 times over the past week and has targeted its premises almost 300 times since the start of the year, the state energy company said on Monday.

Russia has repeatedly battered the Ukrainian power grid since its all-out invasion more than four years ago. Moscow hopes to sap Ukraine's will to fight by denying civilians light, heating and running water during the bitter winter



Bookseller Alexander Bahlai reacts as firefighters try to put out a fire at a market following a Russian missile attack in Kyiv on Sunday. AP

months. Ukrainian officials, who say Russia is "weaponizing winter", fear Moscow will pursue its campaign through the coming winter, too.

Russian drones and missiles struck facilities, with one asset hit multiple times during the

week, Naftogaz said, reporting serious damage to equipment and production capacity.

No employees were hurt in the attacks, the company said. DTEK Group also said a Russian attack struck a fire at one of its mines, killing a 52-year-old man.

Thousands in Indonesia await aid after quake toll rises to 68

Associated Press
Reo, August 17

THOUSANDS OF people were still waiting for aid on the Indonesian island of Flores as the country marked its 81st Independence Day on Monday, days after a powerful earthquake killed at least 68 people, injured more than 200 others and damaged hundreds of homes and other buildings.

Many residents on Flores is-

land in East Nusa Tenggara province spent the day mourning victims and waiting for aid to arrive to communities still cut off by the deadly quake.

During Indonesia's Independence Day ceremony in Jakarta, President Prabowo Subianto asked participants to pray for people affected by disasters in East Nusa Tenggara and other parts of the country, while leading a nationwide moment of silence honouring the na-

tion's independence heroes.

More than 1,300 homes were damaged when the quake struck East Nusa Tenggara province on Saturday, with nearly 250 destroyed on Flores alone. Some 5,000 people were forced into temporary shelters and 213 people were injured, according to the National Disaster Management Agency or BNPB.

Authorities have recorded 1,576 aftershocks into Monday.

Las Vegas gang leader planned Tupac Shakur's murder: Lawyer

Reuters
New York, August 17

A FORMER street gang leader orchestrated the 1996 drive-by shooting of hip-hop star Tupac Shakur in Las Vegas in retribution for the beating of his nephew, a prosecutor told jurors during opening statements in a murder trial tied to a long-unresolved crime that became a seminal moment in rap history.

Duane "Keffe D" Davis, 63, is charged in Clark County, Nevada, with a single count of murder in the first degree. He has pleaded not guilty. Davis is accused of leading a group of men to kill Shakur, 25, one of rap's most commercially successful and influential artists, in a 1996 drive-by shooting near the Las Vegas Strip.

"You will learn that when the opportunity presented itself for retribution, Duane Davis made sure that the shooters were armed and ready to execute their plan. And remarkably, you will learn that from Duane Davis himself," said prosecutor Binu Palal of the Clark County District Attorney's Office.

Shakur's killing heightened the image of violence permeating hip-hop culture and its lyrics during "gangsta" rap's golden age, stoking the East Coast-West Coast rap feud of that era. Police said after Davis' 2023 arrest that he was a longtime suspect in the killing but that investigators lacked sufficient evidence to charge him.



US Army vehicles gather at a training field in Yeoncheon, South Korea, near the border with North Korea on Monday. AP

South Korea baffled as Trump scales back military drills

Hyung-Jin Kim
Seoul, August 17

SOUTH KOREA on Monday expressed hopes for resumption of diplomacy between the US and North Korea to ease animosities on the Korean Peninsula, hours after US President Donald Trump said he ordered annual US military exercises with South Korea to be scaled back.

Trump cited his good relationship with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un for the decision. The announcement baffled many in South Korea, a key US ally in Asia where national security is a top priority due to threats from nuclear-armed North Korea.

The 11-day, summertime Uchi Freedom Shield exercises began Monday morning as scheduled and it wasn't known which parts of the training were being downsized. North Korea did not immediately respond to the announcement. North

Korea previously threatened strong responses to the US-South Korean exercises.

Experts say Trump's step signals his willingness to renege on his willingness to renege with Kim, but the North Korean leader, now emboldened by his advancing nuclear arsenal and expanding military cooperation with Russia, won't likely return to talks unless he is assured of serious US concessions.

Trump said in a social media post that the exercises are not only costly but "send a signal that is totally inappropriate and hostile" to North Korea, which he said "has been unthreatening and respectful" during his time in the White House.

Trump instructed Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth to "substantially reduce" the exercises, he said, adding that he recently asked South Korean President Lee Jae Myung if they would join the US in the "denuclearization" of Iran, "and they said: No thanks!" AP

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

PM exchanged messages with impostor posing as Susie Wiles



British Prime Minister Andy Burnham. FILE

of messages that elected officials, business executives and other prominent figures in the country received messages from someone posing as Wiles. Soon after those incidents, the State Department warned US diplomats of attempts to impersonate Secretary of State Marco Rubio and possibly other officials using AI. AP

BRITISH PM Andy Burnham exchanged messages with an impostor posing as US President Donald Trump's chief of staff, according to reports published Monday. A spokesperson for Burnham declined to comment, saying it was policy not to discuss "national security matters." Politico cited four unnamed officials in first reporting that Burnham thought he was messaging with Susie Wiles before he became suspicious and cut off communications. Last year, the US government investigated a series

ITALY

US tourist dies after being struck by lightning

AN AMERICAN tourist was killed by a lightning strike on Sicily's Mount Etna while hiking in an area that was closed to visitors due to recent volcanic activity, Italian firefighters said Monday. The 29-year-old man from Kansas was rescued by helicopter after being struck Sunday evening in an exposed area above the tree line. He was later declared dead by medical personnel. His name was not released. AP

IRAQ

Drones strike the office of Kurdistan PM

TWO DRONES targeted the office of the Kurdistan Regional Government's prime minister in northern Iraq on Monday but there were no reports of any casualties, the KRG security agency said. The attack was launched from Iranian territory, it said in a statement, without clarifying whether the drones had hit their target. There was no claim of responsibility from any group for the attack. REUTERS

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

SRI LANKA

Managers of 4 banks held in \$1-bn fraud case

MANAGERS OF four private banks were arrested in Sri Lanka in connection with a case involving the transfer of USD1 billion overseas under the pretext of imports, police said on Monday. The arrests are linked to the recent arrest of a foreign exchange dealer for transferring money overseas without any supporting documentation, according to the Financial Crimes Investigation Division of the police. PTI

PAKISTAN

Nine hurt in three separate landmine blasts

NINE PEOPLE were injured in three separate landmine explosions in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KPK), police said on Monday. According to the police, the three explosions occurred in the remote Dandars Sahara area of Kurram on Sunday. In the first incident, a labourer, Hamid Hussain, lost both his legs in the blast. Two more were injured in separate blasts in the area later in the evening. In the third incident, six people were injured. PTI

Hayden Panettiere, who openly shared her mental health journey, dies at 36

Matt Stevens
August 17

HAYDEN PANETTIERE, the actress who as a child starred in films like "Remember the Titans" before winning acclaim as a cheerleader with special powers on the TV series "Heroes" and a troubled country diva on "Nashville," and who spoke openly about her struggles with mental health issues and substance abuse, has died in South Carolina, She was 36.

Panettiere's death was confirmed by her father, Skip Panettiere, in a statement that was provided to The New York Times by his daughter's publicist. No further details were provided.

"It is with profound sadness that we share the tragic passing of our beloved Hayden," the statement said. "She was an incredible light and a force of nature who brought immeasurable love and joy to all who knew her and to the millions who watched her onscreen. We ask for privacy as our family takes time to process this unimaginable loss."

A two-time Golden Globe nominee, Panettiere had lived her life in front of the cameras since she appeared in a commercial for a soft drink when she was 10. Ten years later, already experienced onscreen, she made a mark as a sharp-tongued coach's daughter in "Remember the Titans" (2000), starring Denzel Washington. She played the supernatu-



Acclaimed actress starred in 'Nashville' and 'Heroes'

rally gifted cheerleader Claire Bennet on "Heroes" (2006-10), and the rising music star Juliette Barnes on "Nashville," for which she was nominated for a supporting-actress Golden Globe in 2013 and 2014. She was Kirby Reed, a quirky, sassy best friend, in the film "Scream 4" (2011), and reprised the role in "Scream VI" (2023). "Hayden is a real powerhouse," Wes Craven, the director of "Scream 4," said while promoting the film. "Tremendous technical ability. Able to bring enormous emotionalities to something very quickly. Smart. Just so full of life and laughter and fun."

Panettiere's life in the public eye took a toll, as she recounted in a memoir published this spring, "This Is Me: A Reckoning." She said she suffered from body dysmorphia as a result of invasive tabloid press coverage when she was a teenager. NYT

• BEIJING WANTS TO BECOME A LEADING SUPPLIER OF DATA — THE TROVES OF TEXT, IMAGES AND VIDEOS — THAT TRAIN AI SYSTEMS AROUND THE WORLD

China's grand plan: To shape what AI learns and remembers

David Pierson
& Berry Wang
August 17

WHEN CHATGPT was still a new technology, researchers in Beijing tested how well it handled Chinese-language questions. Their response to its results was telling.

The chatbot described former NBA star Yao Ming as the first Chinese woman to play professional basketball in the United States. It confused two classic works of Chinese literature, "Journey to the West" and "Dream of the Red Chamber," which were written two centuries apart.

The researchers at the Beijing Institute of Technology, who published their findings in 2023, also wrote that ChatGPT generated a large amount of "biased commentary about

China" and "would not evade or refuse to answer political questions about China."

ChatGPT has since been updated many times; it is unclear how the results would differ now. But the examples pointed to a central concern in China's quest to become an artificial intelligence power: The systems shaping the future are being trained on datasets that are overwhelmingly in English, and reflect what China sees as a Western way of thinking.

That imbalance is also a strategic vulnerability for the Chinese Communist Party because it means Western views are likely to prevail when it comes to issues such as human rights and the status of Taiwan, the self-governed island claimed by Beijing, analysts say.

To fix this gap, and to build more powerful AI tools, Beijing



Beijing has prioritized AI as a critical strategic technology needed to keep pace with the United States

wants to become a leading supplier of data — the troves of text, images and videos — that train AI systems around the world.

Earlier this year, the country's National Data Administration unveiled a blueprint to transform China into a data powerhouse by the end of

2028. The plan proposed creating "high quality" datasets in more than two dozen strategic fields, including scientific research, industrial manufacturing and autonomous vehicles.

The plan calls on China to share its datasets worldwide. That was reinforced last month

when China pledged to share data to help the dozens of developing countries that attended the World Artificial Intelligence Conference in Shanghai build their own AI systems. China has also already released huge troves of data curated by government labs and state-owned media, making them available for download around the world.

The goal, analysts say, is twofold: to draw more users into China's AI orbit and to narrow the gap with the US in access to high-quality training data, which Beijing believes is helping America maintain its lead.

Under China's top leader, Xi Jinping, Beijing has prioritized AI as a critical strategic technology needed to keep pace with the United States, and to reinvigorate the Chinese economy. To do that, Chinese labs will need

increasingly sophisticated data.

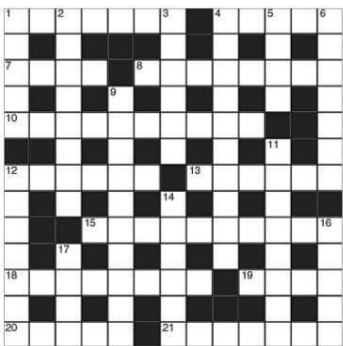
On the surface, that should not be a problem. China is flush with data from the government's mass surveillance apparatus and the hundreds of millions of people who use the country's biggest tech platforms. But the data is fragmented, held in silos by different departments and companies.

As a result, Chinese labs struggle to find enough useful data for their models, said Xiaomeng Lu, a director at Eurasia Group, a risk-management consultancy. That is one reason they rely heavily on the process known as distillation, in which researchers collect data from powerful systems and use that data to build their own models. (US companies such as Anthropic complain that their Chinese competitors are unfairly copying their technology.) NYT

Praksha Gadilkar, I.A.S)
Chief Executive Officer

CROSSWORD

6070



ACROSS

- 1 Get out of a tight situation (5,2)
- 4 Dreams about inspiring women (5)
- 7 Out-and-out row (4)
- 8 They will keep on watch in the ship (8)
- 10 One without a car needs a trip out (10)
- 12 Spot the dog is in free from danger (6)
- 13 Fashion design made one's name (6)
- 15 Conjurung appears a fashionable career (10)
- 18 Story of the underground (8)
- 19 Wager about a pound (4)
- 20 One out of bed seen going upstairs (5)
- 21 I sorted out the ones with views (7)

DOWN

- 1 A bit of a dust-up (5)
- 2 Monk who founded an order on Scottish mountain (8)
- 3 Depart agitatedly. It may explode (6)
- 4 Chalice man spilt unthinking (10)
- 5 Looks up and down (4)
- 6 We object during pay out to hold up (7)
- 9 Moon starter? Perhaps (10)
- 11 To her Ian may appear as a charmless character (4-4)
- 12 The usual object of retirement (7)
- 14 Cat goes under piano in spring (6)
- 16 Records some music (5)
- 17 Gives us directions for Customs? (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6069 ACROSS: 1 Crystal ball, 9 Inbred, 10 Range, 11 Tank, 12 Try again, 14 Napkin, 16 Anodes, 18 Tiresome, 19 Solo, 22 Orion, 23 Auditor, 24 Close season DOWN: 2 Robin, 3 Stem, 4 Adders, 5 Bargains, 6 Lanyard, 7 Distinction, 8 Tennis court, 13 Dissects, 15 Partial, 17 Smeared, 20 Outdo, 21 Idea

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

is not being emotional, but being able to express emotion - Kate Reid (6)

AGTAI

HOOSYC

EKONT

BEILOG

ANSWER: Katia Reid is not being emotional, but being able to express emotion - Kate Reid (6)

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL IS INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6414

9	7	4		8	5
	6	3			
3		5	2	7	1
	9	8		5	6
		9	3		
8	6	1	4	2	
5	9	6	4		8
			9	3	
4	2		7	9	6

SOLUTIONSUDOKU 6413

3	5	1	4	9	7	6	2	8
2	6	8	5	1	3	7	4	9
9	4	7	8	2	6	1	3	5
8	3	4	1	6	5	9	7	2
1	2	5	7	4	9	3	8	6
7	9	6	2	3	8	4	5	1
5	1	9	3	7	2	8	6	4
6	8	3	9	5	4	2	1	7
4	7	2	6	8	1	5	9	3

CORPORATE BRIEFS



EIL celebrated India's 80th Independence Day with patriotic fervour at Engineers' India Bhawan, New Delhi, and its Gurugram office. CMD Atul Gupta hoisted the National Flag in the presence of directors, senior officials, employees and their families. Addressing the gathering, Gupta highlighted EIL's commitment to indigenous technology, PM Gati Shakti, green economy and engineering excellence. He outlined the company's five-pillar strategy of business growth, operational excellence, technical innovation, digital transformation and human excellence, aligned with the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. He also stressed employee health, fitness and wellbeing.

GAIL CMD Deepak Gupta hoisted the National Flag at the company's Corporate Office in New Delhi on Independence Day, in the presence of directors, senior officials, employees and their families. The gathering joined in singing Vande Mataram, commemorating its 150th anniversary, followed by the National Anthem. Addressing employees, Gupta highlighted GAIL's role in nation-building and underscored energy as the foundation of economic growth. He said GAIL's diversified LNG portfolio is strengthening India's energy resilience amid changing global dynamics and geopolitical challenges, adding that wherever energy reaches, development follows.



PNB organised a Walkathon under the "Har Ghar Tiranga Yatra" campaign to celebrate the 80th Independence Day to commemorate 150th anniversary of "Vande Mataram". The initiative was inspired by the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign by GOI, which aims to bring the Indian National Flag closer to the hearts of India citizens while paying tribute to the national song that has inspired generations of freedom fighters. The walkathon was led by ED M Paramasivam, ED Amit Kumar Srivastava, Chief Vigilance Officer, Raghendra Kumar, and other senior officials. Speaking on the occasion, M Paramasivam, ED, PNB said: "As we mark 80 years of India's independence, this year holds special significance as we also commemorate 150 years of 'Vande Mataram', song that stirred the soul of a nation and gave voice to the sacrifices of countless freedom fighters. Through this PNB 'Har Ghar Tiranga Yatra', we pay homage to that enduring spirit of patriotism and unity.

NHPC celebrated India's 80th Independence Day at its Faridabad headquarters, with CMD Bhupendra Gupta hoisting the National Flag after a group rendition of the National Song, followed by the National Anthem. Addressing employees, Gupta highlighted NHPC's role in advancing energy security and self-reliance through clean power. He cited the commissioning of 1,000 MW of the 2,000 MW Subansiri Lower Hydroelectric Project and progress on the Dibang Multipurpose Project. He said hydropower will remain NHPC's core strength, while pumped storage, solar and wind will drive future growth. Gupta also stressed safety, quality, integrity and community welfare. Calling employees the company's greatest strength, he urged young recruits to contribute fresh ideas and promote greater use of Artificial Intelligence, digital technologies and innovation.



NBCC celebrated the 80th Independence Day at NBCC Bhawan, New Delhi, reaffirming its commitment to nation-building and Viksit Bharat 2047. CMD Dr. K. P. Mahadevaswamy highlighted landmark initiatives including the Amrapali projects, East Kidwai Nagar redevelopment, New Moti Bagh & World Trade Center, New Delhi. He urged employees to embrace innovation, technology and new-age solutions. The celebrations featured the National Flag hoisting, National Anthem and National Song. An employee-led cultural programme also unveiled the Official NBCC Anthem, alongside felicitation of competition winners and its writers and singers.



DM OFFICE, EAST DISTRICT On the occasion of 80th Independence Day, a grand Har Ghar Tiranga rally was organised at the District Magistrate (DM) Office, East District, with the joint collaboration of the District Magistrate Office, East District, and the Department of Women and Child Development (WCD), East District. The rally was led by Worthy District Magistrate, East District, Karanjit Vadodaria, along with the ADM, SDM & Tehsildar, Sadhana Singh, District Officer, WCD, East District. The event reflected the collective commitment of the District Administration and the Department of Women & Child Development towards promoting the values of national integration, unity and pride in the nation.

BSNL extends its warm greetings and best wishes to its customers, citizens, business partners, associates and employees on Independence Day. As India's trusted public sector telecom provider, BSNL remains committed to reliable, secure, affordable and inclusive digital connectivity, including in challenging geographical and climatic conditions. Guided by the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Digital India, the company is building a resilient, future-ready network powered by indigenous technologies and customer-focused innovations. As part of its Independence Day initiatives, BSNL is introducing new customer-centric offerings to enhance digital services and improve access to advanced connectivity and entertainment. The company has ordered over 26,300 additional 4G BTS sites nationwide, expanding coverage across towns, villages and remote areas. Its 4G network has also been comprehensively optimised for improved coverage, speeds, call quality and customer experience.

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a passionate, intense day. Although your impulse is to socialise, increased chaos and activity at home are challenging. But, fortunately, fair Venus opposite your sign promotes warmth in all your relations. Tonight: Check your finances.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today you might have to go more than halfway when dealing with others. Be cooperative and accommodating. Family discussions will be upbeat; however, someone might be stubborn. Tonight: Listen to someone.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): What you need today is for someone to listen to you. You like to share your ideas. Today, help someone if you can. However, steer clear of intense discussions. Tonight: Work to get better organised.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Home and family have your attention today. Or perhaps you want to keep a low profile. A discussion with a female family member is likely. Fortunately, with fair Venus in your House of Communications, things will flow smoothly. Tonight: Relax at home.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You have lots of energy today. Although you have a strong focus on money, earnings and cash flow, social outlets will appeal to you. Check out sports events, movies, fun get-togethers and playful activities with kids. Tonight: Enjoy socialising with someone.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today when talking to others, you want to have a real, meaningful conversation. Seek out someone who is willing to have a dialogue with you. Tonight: An interesting conversation.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today you have a tendency to identify with your possessions. You might consider buying wardrobe items. You probably will like what you see in the mirror. You might shop for a new look that you want to assume. Tonight: Check your belongings.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today the Moon is in your sign, which gives you a slight edge over all the other signs. This can make you more emotional than usual. Meanwhile, you create a great impression on everyone. Tonight: You're strong.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You're keen to find a change of scenery. You're happy to be low-key and work alone or behind the scenes. Disputes about taxes, debt, credit or shared property might arise. Relations with friends and groups are cozy. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today you're giving thought to your friendships, which is why your contact between yourself and a friend might be deeper than usual. You might feel supportive or protective of someone. Be patient with partners. Tonight: Time with friends.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today, which means people notice you more than usual. Be aware of this in case you have to do some damage control. Keep in mind that you need more sleep this week. Tonight: You're admired.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You're happy to work and accomplish things this week. You're also open to socialising. But today you want to do something different. Travel would be a nice option. If you can't travel, then be a tourist in your own city. Tonight: Explore.



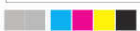
DFCCIL celebrated the 80th Independence Day at its Noida Corporate Office, with MD Praveen Kumar as Chief Guest. The programme paid tribute to freedom fighters and featured a rendition of Vande Mataram. DFCCIL launched a Track Recording Car, OHE Recording Car and Bridge Inspection Vehicle to strengthen infrastructure monitoring and support predictive maintenance, improving safety, reliability and efficiency across the freight corridor network. The occasion also saw the release of updated publications and unveiling of a commemorative postal stamp marking completion of the entire Dedicated Freight Corridor network. The initiatives reflect DFCCIL's continued commitment to modernising railway infrastructure through advanced technology and improved monitoring systems. The celebrations highlighted DFCCIL's contribution towards building a safer, more reliable and efficient freight transportation network. The event also reinforced the organisation's focus on innovation and excellence in freight rail infrastructure.



HUDCO organised a Har Ghar Tiranga celebration as part of the nationwide campaign from August 9 to 17, 2026. Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs and Power, Manohar Lal, inaugurated the campaign kiosk in the presence of HUDCO CMD Sanjay Kulshrestha, IHC Director Prof K G Suresh, TERI DGI Dr Vibha Dhawan, officials, representatives and schoolchildren. The Minister urged citizens to proudly hoist the National Flag and described the Tiranga as a symbol of India's freedom, unity, identity and collective aspirations. He emphasised that the campaign provides an opportunity for citizens, institutions and communities to come together in expressing their respect for the National Flag and the values it represents. The celebration also aimed to inspire young citizens and encourage greater awareness of India's national heritage and democratic values. HUDCO will distribute over 5,000 National Flags through its IHC kiosk and regional offices nationwide, encouraging wider public participation in the campaign. The initiative seeks to strengthen the spirit of patriotism and collective participation across communities. It also reflects the shared commitment of institutions and citizens towards celebrating the nation with pride and unity.



PNB celebrated India's 80th Independence Day at its Dwarka headquarters under the theme "Yuva Shakti for Viksit Bharat@2047", also commemorating 150 years of Vande Mataram. MD & CEO Ashok Chandra hoisted the National Flag and paid tribute to Lala Lajpat Rai, one of PNB's founders. Highlighting India's rapid economic transformation, Chandra said PNB, with over 10,000 branches, one lakh employees and 18 crore customers, is positioned to support the nation's development journey. He outlined priorities including technology-led banking, digital lending, AI, GenAI, quantum technology, financial inclusion and cyber resilience. PNB also disbursed 78.6 crore in scholarships to over 21,000 meritorious female students from SC/ST communities. The bank further supported education, child welfare and road safety through community initiatives across India.



GALLE TEST, DAY 3

India's day: Early breakthroughs, resistance in middle, handy lead

Visitors held up by Dinusha-Dickwella century stand before ensuring they hold all aces

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 17

DAY THREE, generally considered the moving day in a Test, didn't exactly move the way India wanted. After they ended with 462 in their first innings, the Galle weather was kind to them, ensuring no time was lost. And when a collective effort from their attack reduced Sri Lanka to 90/5 by the 27th over, the visitors smelled a big opening. Bow out the opposition quickly and enforce the follow-on, giving ample time to their bowlers to force a win.

Instead, all-rounder Sonal Dinusha's maiden Test century and Niroshan Dickwella's 80 restricted Sri Lanka out of the hole, taking the team to 484 before being dismissed, ensuring India would have to bat again. With scattered thunderstorms predicted for the next two days, and the pitch on the slower side, India would need to play exceptional cricket to take series lead.

Having taken stumps at 460/9 on Sunday, India's innings lasted only four more balls. So they didn't lose the advantage of letting their seamers make the most of the morning conditions. Thanks to the sweating under the covers, there was a bit of movement early on to go with the breeze. And immediately giving India the breakthrough was Mohammed Siraj, who made Nishan Fernando edge one to the cordon, where Devdutt Padikkal took a sharp catch.

But the seamers didn't cause much trouble thereafter, and it was Manav Suthar, who struck with his first delivery, removing Dinesh Chandimal. Then Lahiru Udara gifted the spinner his second wicket before Kuldeep Yadav



Ravindra Jadeja (second from left) celebrating one of his three wickets with teammates. CREMAS

and Ravindra Jadeja removed Kamindu Mendis and Dhana-jaya de Silva respectively. Mendis was undone by the digging with a drive, with Gill plucking a one-handed catch inches off the turf. De Silva was caught by KL Rahul, who ensured he stayed low at slip and got his fingers underneath the ball as it all began to unravel quickly for the home team.

Fightback

The challenge began only after half the side was sent back to the pavilion. As soon as Dickwella got in, he chose to go on the offence, with his sweep shots in particular upsetting the Indian spinners. Ahead of the Test, Dickwella's inclusion had become a big talking point, with questions raised over his career record (batting average 30.97, 21 50s and no centuries). Many asked why did the selectors go back to a 33-year-old who played his last Test in 2023. But more than the batting, Sri Lanka claimed it was Dickwella's glove work that brought him into the XI.

With Dinusha cutting out risk and playing deliveries on

merit, Dickwella cut loose as and when he intended. At most times, it was the sweep shot he fell back on as the safest and most effective option. Mostly sweeping deliveries in the 3m range, he would either play them square or in front of square depending on the line.

Dinusha, on the other hand, mostly preferred slog-sweeps and reverse-sweeps, but the bulk of his runs came in singles and twos as he had only four boundaries and two sixes to show in his knock of 100, before being trapped in front by Jadeja.

Despite having three tweakers, India would have wished to have an off-spinner in the XI. Kuldeep took the ball away from the left-hander, but being the slowest, and deliveries not getting enough venom off the pitch, both left-handers had no problem in making him toil. The liberal use of the sweep resulted in Kuldeep not hitting the right lengths. That he had no maidens to show and went at 464 runs an over was a telling statistic. He couldn't build much pressure. But it wasn't all doom for the wrist-spinner. When he attacked the line of the stumps, he posed questions.

Left is right

Jadeja and Suthar were relentless, but contrasted in their approach. Suthar was slower, while Jadeja who picked up his 350th Test wicket on Monday, did what he knows best - keeping it tight at all times. But Dickwella and Dinusha used his angle to their advantage.

The 146-run stand for the sixth wicket looked set to be a bigger one. Once the Kookaburra went soft, the Indian spinners struggled for purchase and even the Galle strip was unusually docile. Maybe the presence of dead grass meant it didn't break as much as one expected, but it is known to be notorious from Day 4. So India would hope the spinners have a bigger role to play as it would encourage their attack.

Once Prasidh Krishnamooredi Dickwella for 80, Sri Lanka's innings didn't move at a rapid pace. Although Dinusha did well to hold on to an end and coast to his maiden century, once the monopoly of the left-handers was broken, the spinners again came into play.

With a 178-run lead on board, India would like to

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA

GALLE

TOSS: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (O/N 460-9)

Kuldeep Yadav not out 13 (14b, 2x4)

Prasidh Krishna c Dickwella b AM

Fernando 2 (7b)

EXTRAS (b 4, lb 3, w 1, nb 4) 12

TOTAL (116.4 Overs) 462 all out

FOU: 47/1 (Yashasvi Jaiswal, 10.6 ov),

236-2 (Shubman Gill, 61.5 ov), 307-3

(Rishabh Pant, 80.4 ov), 319-4 (KL

Rahul, 31.1 ov), 357-5 (Devdutt

Padikkal, 91.3 ov), 377-6 (Ravindra

Jadeja, 98.1 ov), 432-7 (Dhruv Jurel,

109.1 ov), 447-8 (Mohammed Siraj, 112.6

ov), 447-9 (Manav Suthar, 113.1 ov), 462-10

(Prasidh Krishna, 116.4 ov)

BOWLING: Asitha Fernando 174-1-63-2; Lahiru Kumara 131-17-6; Keshara

Nuwantha 39-17-5-3; Prabhath Jayasuriya 39-10-9-4; Dhaniyaya de Silva 4-0-15-0; Sonal Dinusha 4-0-17-0

SRI LANKA

Nishan Fernando c Padikkal b Siraj 0

(2b)

Lahiru Udara c Jaiswal b Suthar 27

(44b, 6x4)

Dinesh Chandimal c Pant b Suthar 4

(16b)

Kamindu Mendis c Shubman Gill b

Kuldeep 14 (25b, 1x4, 1x6)

Sonal Dinusha lbw Jadeja 100 (168b,

4x4, 2x6)

Niroshan Dickwella c Pant b Prasidh 80

(115b, 7x4)

Keshara Nuwantha c Gill b Jadeja 2

(18b)

Prabhath Jayasuriya c Jurel b Suthar 10

(43b, 2x4)

Lahiru Kumara c Pant b Suthar 10 (5b,

1x4, 1x6)

Asitha Fernando not out 0 (5b)

EXTRAS (b 8, lb 2, w 2, nb 4) 16

TOTAL (79.4 Overs) 284 all out

FOU: 0-1 (Nishan Madushika, 0.2 ov), 27-2

(Dinesh Chandimal, 71 ov), 53-3

(Lahiru Udara, 12.5 ov), 59-4 (Kamindu

Mendis, 16.1 ov), 90-5 (Dhaniyaya de

Silva, 26.1 ov), 236-6 (Niroshan

Dickwella, 61.4 ov), 243-7 (Keshara

Nuwantha, 66.4 ov), 274-8 (Prabhath

Jayasuriya, 77.5 ov), 274-9 (Sonal

Dinusha, 78.1 ov), 284-10 (Lahiru

Kumara, 79.4 ov)

BOWLING: Mohammed Siraj 9-3-29;

1-Prasidh Krishna 14-0-47-1; Manav

Suthar 21-4-76-4; Kuldeep Yadav 14-0-

65-1; Ravindra Jadeja 21-5-57-3

swell to 350 in quick time,

thereby giving their attack

enough time to bowl the hosts

out, weather gods permitting.



Henry Croft (C) celebrates England's third goal against India in Amsterdam. HOCKEY INDIA

Fulton's India pay price for defensive approach, go down 2-4 to England

Mihir Vasudha
Mumbai, August 17

IT WAS a classic case of need versus choice.

At the Paris Olympics, India had little choice but to retreat deep into their own half against Great Britain. Devn to nine players for 43 minutes. It was survival. Against England at the World Cup, with 11 players on the field and a lead to protect, the same approach was a choice.

Craig Fulton's men stationed themselves deep in their own half, occupying only about 40 per cent of the field. They stayed compact, bent so low that their knuckles brushed the surface and sticks kissed the turf, and seemed happy to send England into wider areas.

It was the strategy that earned them a famous win two summers ago. On Monday at the World Cup, it might just have handed them a costly defeat. The immediate consequence of the 4-2 loss in Amsterdam is that India must now beat Pakistan on Wednesday to ensure themselves a place in the second round. They haven't lost to their neighbours in a decade. But pressure and Pakistan are capable of unpredictable things.

If India do get the result they need on Wednesday and advance, the impact of missing out on the three points they could have carried forward in the race for the semifinals could still be felt.

Initial high press

India did not start with the low block. Instead, they were the initiators in the opening exchanges and controlled proceedings. They were adventurous enough to commit numbers forward and press high even after England started to find their footing. That approach also left them vulnerable.

In the 13th minute, England turned defence into attack in the blink of an eye. India believed they had forced their opponents into a corner, but a left ball from the back travel, lying almost half the length of

Pool D

	P	W	D	L	GD	Pts
England	2	2	0	0	5	6
India	2	1	0	1	0	3
Wales	2	0	1	1	-2	1
Pakistan	2	0	1	1	-3	1

India must now beat Pakistan to ensure themselves a place in the second round

The goal injected a sense of urgency into India, who responded immediately after the quarter break. Harmanpreet led the comeback. Venturing forward from the left flank, he unleashed a powerful reverse hit that caught the foot of Ben Fox and earned India a penalty corner. The captain then finished the move he had started, sending a fierce drag-flick into the top-right corner and giving James Mazarello no chance.

India found their stride and, in the 24th minute, took the lead. The move started with what appeared to be an inconsequential pass from Abhishek Nain to Hardik Singh to restart play on the left. Hardik beat an England defender to enter the circle before finding Abhishek near the baseline. His drilled cross evaded both an outstretched Mazarello and a back-tracking defender before reaching Dilpreet Singh at the far post for a simple finish.

India had found the balance

between defensive discipline and attacking intent. They disappeared into the dressing room with the lead, a greater share of possession and more shots on goal.

When they returned for the second half, they appeared to abandon their attacking ethos altogether and retreat into an ultra-defensive shape.

England cash in

It gave England, who had looked uncomfortable whenever India drove forward, far more time on the ball. India maintained their compact shape impressively, forcing England to constantly search for new ways through. They alternated between aerial balls and sharp, low crosses from the wings while repeatedly switching flanks in search of openings.

But the trade-off was relentless pressure.

Eventually, England's persistence paid off, and India's lead disappeared in the space of four minutes.

Rushmore smartly deflected a low cross to beat Mothil in the 38th minute and level the scores. Four minutes later, he was involved again, controlling another high ball before pushing it into the circle for Henry Croft, whose fierce shot on the turn beat the stranded Indian goalkeeper.

India tried to change things in the fourth quarter, pressing high straight from the restart, but it was too little, too late. In their search for an equaliser, they left gaps at the back, and Bandurak punished them again in the 54th minute.

India looked their most dangerous when they attacked. They lost control the moment they stopped trying to.

RESULTS: England 4 bt India 2, Wales 3 drew with Pakistan 3

Suthar a throwback to Indian spinners of 1970s, 80s: Siva

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 17

LAXMAN SIVARAMAKRISHNAN understands the hype and excitement around left-arm spinner Manav Suthar, who had figures of 4 for 76 from 21.4 overs as Sri Lanka were bowled out for 284 in the first innings, on Day 3 at Galle.

"He is a throwback to old school, the Indian spinner one got to witness in the 1970s and 1980s," he tells *The Indian Express*. While much of the focus on Suthar has been on his re-lease position, where the seam is angled perfectly toward first slip, the ball dipping and drifting before it reaches the batsman, Sivaramakrishnan says there is plenty more in the spinner that makes him complete.

From the time Suthar burst onto the domestic circuit, he has been earmarked as the one to



Manav Suthar picked up four Sri Lankan wickets on Day 3. CREMAS

carry India's spin legacy forward. In his brief Test career so far, the 24-year-old has shown plenty of promise to live up to that. On Day 3 at Galle, he struck with his first delivery, removing the experienced Dinesh Chandimal with a ball that angled in, made the batsman play, then spun just enough to take his glove on the way to Rishabh

"You watch him just before he releases the ball. There is a rockback catapult, which you don't see in spinners these days"

LAXMAN SIVARAMAKRISHNAN, FORMER INDIA LEGSPINNER ON MANAV SUTHAR'S ACTION.

Pant. Through the day, he kept posing questions to the hosts.

While the seam position has remained the talking point, according to Sivaramakrishnan it's what happens before that which makes Suthar special. "You watch him just before he releases the ball. There is a rockback catapult, which you don't see in spinners these days. You

saw it with Bishan Singh Bedi, Erappali Prasanna and S Venkatraghavan, but these days spinners don't do it because they rush through with their stride," Sivaramakrishnan says.

Having taken to coaching in Chennai and Bengaluru, Sivaramakrishnan knows Suthar is a rarity. There are plenty of left-arm spinners on the domestic circuit, but few have caught the eye like Suthar. "The mostly bowlers with a pronounced seam, but when he slips in the scrambled seam, he creates doubts into batsmen's minds," the ex-India spinner says.

At Galle, across the last 10 Tests, the average turn on offer on Day 3 has been 4.23 degrees. Suthar, despite being a finger spinner, was getting 6. "This delivery stride is short, which means he has got the right balance, and the ideal hip drive that allows wonderful transfer of

weight from back leg to front leg," Sivaramakrishnan says. A year ago, when Suthar arrived at BCCI's Centre of Excellence, something was off in his bowling. With a long delivery stride, he was struggling with control and balance, which kept him out of the Duleep Trophy and three matches for India A. It took him only three sessions to get the delivery stride and release point right.

"Suthar's deliveries are arriving from above the eyeline of the batsman. It's classic old school," Sivaramakrishnan explains.

Once Suthar releases the ball, the rest of the story unravels. "Since his seam is pronounced, he will get turn, and because of the release point, there is extra bounce. He bowls on one leg, and the balance is perfect. When there is sync between back leg and front leg, you are in control of the line and length," he adds.



Navneet Kaur was India's standout player in their 2-2 draw with China in the Women's World Cup on Sunday. HOCKEY INDIA

dian hockey's greatest talent factories, producing over 80 internationals and eight Indian captains, including Rani Rampal.

Navneet grew up watching two other former captains, Ritu Rani and Surinder Kaur, train under him. Before she was one

of his students, she was an observer. "He was very strict about discipline and demanded complete focus during training. Otherwise, you'd have to run laps of the ground," Navneet said. "I saw the potential in a player, he would pay extra attention. But he was never biased. All he wanted was to create opportunities for girls through hockey."

Baldev had spotted the spark in her, and by 2013, Navneet was seen as one of India's brightest young prospects, even featuring in the bronze medal-winning team at the Junior World Cup. But in 2015, in senior hockey were far from straight-forward. Although she made her debut in 2014, Navneet had only 16 appearances till 2017, when she started consistently featuring in the squad. Since then, she

has played 196 times and scored 95 goals.

The uncertainty of being in and out of the squad forced Navneet to rethink her game. "I realised I had to play with more smartness and understand tactics. In India, players have skills, but today's hockey, you have to understand the game and know how to play," she said.

Fitness became equally important. "Without fitness, the tactics you're learning are not useful. So I think I've focused the most on the smartness of hockey." That intelligence is reflected in the way she plays. Unlike forwards who wait inside the circle for opportunities to arrive, Navneet prefers to create them herself. She likes receiving the ball while on the move, taking on defenders and accelerating into spaces before disappearing. China couldn't

contain that unpredictability.

Quiet performer

Navneet was among the team's best players at the Asia Cup, followed by an outstanding performance at the World Cup qualifiers in Hyderabad, where she was named Player of the Tournament, and during the triumphant FIH Nations Cup campaign in June.

Yet, despite crossing 200 international appearances and playing a key role in India's run to the Tokyo Olympics semifinals, she has rarely sought the spotlight. She has kept showing up. And on a day when India needed a gritty show to begin their World Cup campaign, it was fitting that Navneet — the girl who grew up in a cricket-loving household but couldn't escape the pull of hockey — was the one leading the way.

FORGED IN SHAHBAD'S HOCKEY NURSERY

Mihir Vasudha
Mumbai, August 17

IF NAVNEET Kaur had grown up anywhere other than Shahbad, she might never have become a hockey player.

Cricket dominated her home. Her father was an avid follower of the game, and one of her earliest sporting idols was India's captain, Harmanpreet Kaur. But growing up in Shahbad — the small Haryana town that has produced an assembly line of international hockey players — made a different future almost inevitable.

Baldev's influence

In Shahbad, hockey isn't a sport children discover. It's the sport that finds them. "My father wanted me to play cricket; he likes the sport a lot. But where I grew up in

Shahbad, everyone played hockey. I thought, Okay, this is no cricket here, but if you want to go into sports, then try hockey," Navneet told *The Indian Express* from Amsterdam.

She had another, more compelling reason: coach Baldev Singh, who was conferred the Padma Shri this year. "He has created many excellent international players. So that's why I started playing hockey," she said. On Sunday at the Women's Hockey World Cup, the 30-year-old reminded everyone why both Shahbad and Baldev continue to shape some of India's finest players.

With India holding Olympic silver medalists China to a 2-2 draw in their Pool D opener, ending a run of four straight defeats against the Asian heavyweights, the experienced forward produced a performance

that was as influential as it was energetic. She scored, created openings, led the press and constantly forced China onto the back foot. A few times, she even tracked all the way back into India's half to win possession and relieve the pressure on her defenders.

India needed all of that. And they will need more of it over the next four days, with matches against South Africa and England set to determine whether they progress.

When she first walked onto a hockey field, Navneet had little idea what a World Cup event was. "I went to the ground just looking for an opportunity to play. I had no idea I'd end up playing here... or even get selected," she said.

That journey began under Baldev, the man who transformed Shahbad into one of In-

BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

Ayush keeps the big hits coming

In beating the defending champ Shi Yuqi in the first round of Worlds, he has shown himself to be one for the bright lights

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 17

THE RUNNING joke in Bengaluru among his training group of sparrers and coaches was that Ayush Shetty would check into the Delhi hotel for the Badminton World Championships and scotch-tape a poster on the long mirror. 17th August will be a very bad day for Shi Yuqi', the scrawled graffiti was to say.

The 21-year-old badminton star from Mangaluru almost didn't see the manifestation play out when the Chinese defending champ and World No.1 dragged out his own end to a tantalising score of 21-14, 13-21, 21-19. But August 17 did end up as a wretched day for contemporary badminton's most complete shuttle, the sagacious Yuqi. Every step of his first-round exit was serendipitous and sweatied by an adoring crowd that watched the 6-ft-4 Indian soar at the Indira Gandhi arena, with a smash that took out the fabled Chinese.

Yuqi joined Lee Chong Wei in 2017 and Viktor Axelsen in 2021. In the ignominy of a first-round exit by a top name, though Ayush, ranked No.22, is way past being dubbed an upstart.

"I'm feeling great, it's a really special win and I'm super happy with the way I played today," Ayush said. "I knew it would be a really tough match and I really had to work very hard. I was mentally prepared, physically as well."

The signs were evident on Saturday when Yuqi refused to talk to the Indian media, choosing a \$5000 fine instead. He had refused to speak to the Chinese press pack too. In training, the Chinese coaches stood on wooden crates to mimic the steep Ayush smash that comes from eight feet high. But nothing could prepare the rhythmic shuttle for the cacophony of an aggressive Ayush and the throbbing Indian fortress. The reigning champion has had mental blocks against double Olympic champ Axelsen. There's no respite

pite in sight though, as the similarly towering Ayush - like a ghost from the past - starts whacking at him. The day had started with a hearty breakfast - Ayush's favourite meal. Then Indonesian coach Irawansyah ran him through the tactics - something that was sorely missing at the Asian Championships final.

Making the final was great. Yet, the towering shuttle needed a formal coronation

"I was telling myself to calm down because I got nervous. He got close and managed to get back every shuttle. Everything I did, he somehow managed to retrieve it. So I was just telling myself to calm down and be aggressive."

AYUSH SHETTY
ON SHI YUQI'S MINI-COMEBACK

that tips him to be a massive star of the future. It had to be Delhi. Having skipped lunch, Ayush chomped into Yuqi for his end meal.

Coach Sagar Chopra recalls the discussion before Ayush stepped onto the court. "Ayush asked Irawansyah what the court drift was like, because he was sitting for the Sindhu match before that," he said. Once that was clear, Ayush went about using the floaty lifts and clears that muddled Yuqi's ability to connect smashes as the winds did the trick. Delhi was pressgitting home advantage. "The tricky thing about drift is it messes with the timing of shots. That's what Sindhu and Ayush were told - to find the timing and feel on the shots," coach Vimal Kumar explained.

Yuqi looked visibly tentative when both receiving and send-

ing out the lobbed lifts.

Too close for comfort

The final game was Ayush's wicked gift to Delhi. He led 17-6 before he panicked, rushed and made a hash of the advantage.

"I was telling myself to calm down because I got nervous. He got close and managed to get back every shuttle," the Indian said. "Everything I did, he somehow managed to retrieve it. So I was just telling myself to calm down and be aggressive."

As five match points whittled down to 1, Delhi's partisan crowd shored up the nervy youngster. "I was super happy at how the crowd was standing up in the end in the stands cheering for me," he acknowledged.

Ayush was exhausted towards the end which explains the errors. Yuqi had read his cross-court pushes and was waiting for them.

That was when the Indian pulled out a stroke he reserves for clutch. A forehand cross-flick, brought out judiciously for the last point to push Yuqi away from the net. Not only was he aggressive in his attack as he took IG Stadium on a roller-coaster, he also took a leaf out of Lakshya Sen's defence and was ready for the opponent's push onto his body. He was told to be wary of the side drift and at the end-game, to stop looking for cheap points. "One good rally," his coaching bench kept repeating. A country that's been accustomed to Sindhu and Satwiksairaj's big smashes now has another glorious big booming hit to follow. Delhi will never forget the day Ayush made August 17 miserable for the Chinese stalwart. The No.1 it might be but it's still only Round 1 for Ayush. "I'm focusing on the next opponent at this point. Everyone is super tough and I have to be at my best on all days. I'm feeling great today. But I want to keep my head down. I'm happy with the win today. I did well. But I want to go much further," he added.



Ayush Shetty defeated Chinese World No. 1 Shi Yuqi 21-14, 13-21, 21-19 on Day 1 of the BWF Badminton World Championships in New Delhi on Monday.

How a tactical lift brought Chinese giant to his knees



Shi Yuqi struggled to read the shuttle trajectory from one side of the IG arena in the opening game of his 1st round loss.

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 17

THE FLICK-LIFT was the bait. World champion Shi Yuqi was best.

The game was badminton-chess. It ended with the Delhi World Championships finding a sensational premiere show, as unseeded Ayush Shetty took out Shi Yuqi. India has a new boombox to belt out bangers. The win though came from a lifting lift.

The Chinese World No.1, the defending World champion, arguably the most complete shuttle in men's singles currently, is known to problemsolve through all riddles. Ayush's big booming smash that originates from a height of eight feet wasn't even a cryptic puzzle. It was watermarked to this India-China Round 1 contest the moment the draw threw up an unseeded, dangerous opponent in the Chinese champ's path. The 6'4" Indian was expected to rain down steep scorchers from nose-bleeding altitude. What the Chinese might not have expected was for the Indian to flip the script. He had rich, deep, screaming smashes alright. It sent Mexican waves of goosebumps through the watching galleries at the Indira Gandhi stadium. But more than the smashes, Ayush had the tactical, tricky, tingling lifts.

Chinese tured

The bait of a shot that launches the shuttle into an inviting hitting orbit, beckoning Yuqi to slam it down, was so tantalisingly elusive that the Chinese was lured into belting it down, but the high lift denied him the sweet-spot to strike it deep. Or even cross the net striking it against the wind. The pressure was bound to build when Yuqi's smashes got stifled.

"Lifting really worked well," Ayush said. Coach Sagar Chopra explained how opponents tended to push Ayush to backhand back corner followed with a cross. The lifts and clears upturned the pressure on Yuqi instead. "It was just about popping the shuttle high. But he pulled it off," he said.

It was a riveting contest because Ayush had been decimated in the Asian Championship final when exhaustion and incoherent strategy ended matters in a whimper. The high lift was the first course-correction. It pushed the world-beating Chinese to the edge.

Forcing Yuqi to lift was the prologue to the plan. 3-0 up means little against a shuttler as formidable as Yuqi. But it was in going to 4-1 that the weak Yuqi lift was smothered into the

ground with the first of Ayush howitzers. Reading conditions of shuttle trajectory from one side at IG was something Yuqi struggled considerably with.

It also led to a spate of back at the net where Yuqi's backhand control tends to be impeccable. He logged at least half a dozen such mistakes in the opening game.

Mid-game change

The Chinese was forced into Plan B as early as 7-5 in the first. He increased the pace mid-rally trying to swamp Ayush. But the Indian was up to the task. Not only did he get onboard the flat, fast exchange, he ended with a regal cross-court smash kill that left Yuqi on one knee.

The Ayush floaters to the backline kept coming and teasing the Chinese and his judgment on the lines. Just to probe his defence ain't shabby at all, the Indian dove around plenty before inducing a Yuqi error at 9-4. The Indian reached 11-5, with yet another tactical lift, followed by a return that evaded an outstretched forehead. It was a recurring theme. He got to 16-9.

Yuqi was struggling to digest that both his control-play, the sort the Chinese rely on, with emphasis on rhythm, and his chaos in increasing the rally pace were really not troubling Ayush. If anything, the Indian replied in kind. When Yuqi's midcourt lift was punished giving Ayush the opening game, the crowd sensed the new Shetty on the block was onto something.

The 21-14 scoreline was impressive. Before the sides switched, Yuqi did most of the talking rather than the coach-failling his racquet-wielding hand. He pulled second back 21-13. But the decider promised to be a humdinger.

One knew Ayush had arrived when the passage from 17-7 up to 18-14 had Indian fans jumping and wincing at his errors and exhaling with cheers as he edged closer to the 21-point mark. Yuqi threw everything he had in his consistency repertoire at double clip in the closing stages. The nudged pace almost did Ayush in as the score reached 20-19. The man has a penchant for drama. A medical timeout, tangled toes, a sitter at the net, Ayush contrived to find a way to drag this to the edge of the cliff.

The final point was neither a steep smash nor a loopy clever lift. It was a tired push - helped in staying in bounds by his tired arm and the wind against him. Winning seemed destiny. A star was born. The Asian Championships final was avenged. The World No.1 was evicted in Round 1. The lift took off sensationally.

Sindhu headlines five wins for India on Worlds Day 1

Prithvi Raj
New Delhi, August 17

A BADMINTON World Championships in front of the home crowd is an opportunity not every shuttler gets, and double Olympic medalist PV Sindhu soaked it in with an easy win over Sophia Noble of Ireland. Buoyed by the home crowd, Sindhu won 21-7, 21-11 in a 30-minute match.

"I'll yesterday, I was very excited to get on the court. I had butterflies while entering the court today but the crowd cheering and the whole environment gave me goosebumps," Sindhu told the media after the win.

Asked if playing in front of the home crowd added pressure,

she said, "Pressure is everywhere and I think here it is a privilege to play in front of my people."

It was one-sided from the start. The five-time World Championships medalist even experimented with some shots during the match. After winning the first game with ease, Sindhu went to the tougher side and adjusted to the drift and conditions. "Yeah, the opponent pushed me in the second half but I was experimenting with my shots and adjusting to the conditions. So, I tried my drops and smashes," Sindhu said.

Sindhu comes into the tournament on the back of the Japan Open Super 750 title, confidence that will matter with a potential clash against world number



PV Sindhu made light work of Sophia Noble in a 21-7, 21-11 win.

three Wang Zhi Yi of China looming, India's most decorated shuttler at the World Championships, she is eyeing a sixth medal

in the event, and an end to a seven-year wait. Her last medal came at the 2019 edition, when she won the title and became the

first Indian shuttler to do so.

Treasa-Gayatri win

Returning from an injury layoff, the women's doubles pair of Treasa-Lolly and Gayatri Gopichand started on a winning note, beating Paula Lopez and Lucia Rodriguez of Spain in straight games, 21-9, 21-13.

The Indian duo are coming back from a long layoff, with Treasa out for more than three months. "It was tough to stay away for 2.5 months from the court, and when we entered the court, it was a thrilling moment for us," Gayatri said after the win.

The other two pairs in contention, Simran Singh and Kavipriya Selvam in women's doubles, and Harinaran Amasu-

karan and Arjun MR in men's doubles, also won their opening games, making it five wins from five for India. Hari and Arjun played early in the day and took time to adjust to the conditions before their opponents, Scott Guleida and Paul Reynolds of Ireland, retired due to a back injury to Guleida. "There was some side drift and that is why the Irish pair started getting their length right. They had to retire unfortunately, but it is a good start for us, and that too in front of the home crowd," Arjun said.

Lakshya Sen and Unnati Hooda will headline the Indian contingent on Day 2. Lakshya faces Collins Valentine Filmon of Austria, and Unnati faces Thar Thar Thuzar of Myanmar.

• NORWEGIAN EFFICIENCY

Mourinho documentary inspired Carlsen to clinical Esports World Cup crown

Mayank Chaudhary
Paris, August 17

DENIS LAZAVIK wasn't too upset with himself when he walked into the content hub for his post-game interactions following his loss in the Esports World Cup final to Magnus Carlsen. After all, there is no shame in losing to the world's best.

The Belarusian teenager was the breakout star of the Paris event, taking down Ian Nepomniachtchi, Nodirbek Abdusattorov, and Hikaru Nakamura on his way to the final. But there, he found a dead end. Carlsen swarmed him without dropping a single game, successfully defending his EWCC title in clinical fashion.

While Carlsen adding another championship to his long list of accolades should come as no surprise, what stood out most was the efficiency with which he oper-

ated. He steamrolled the field even while battling illness. Carlsen went unbeaten against a series of elite opponents, which had Andrey Esipenko, Hans Niemann, Nihal Sarin, Alireza Firouzja, and Lazavik, to cruise to his second straight Esports World Cup title. In many of those matches, he simply gave his opponents no room to breathe, let alone make progress.

Not the same player

Lazavik observed that Carlsen is not the same player he once was. He no longer enjoys fighting in complex positions; instead, he wants to shut the door and move on. "Like a couple of years ago, he was trying to play more fighting chess, he was enjoying it more. Now I feel he doesn't like to play so much. He just trades everything and he is just way better in the endgame. So he doesn't try to create any complexity for him,"

Lazavik told *The Indian Express*. Carlsen didn't disagree with Lazavik's observation; rather, he embraced it. The Norwegian explained that his approach in Paris was a deliberate choice, not a sign of fading ambition.

He said, "I started watching the Mourinho documentary on Netflix the other day. They were talking about the first season that they were just winning 1-0 every match. And I was thinking, well, that sounds pretty nice, doesn't it? It's certainly the case that in this tournament I stayed very, very true to not trying to do much."

"Obviously, I wanted to save energy when I could. There were some boring games because of that, but that's how it is. I don't know if it's a general change, but for this tournament it was a very conscious choice."

Being the face of the Esports World Cup as a global brand ambassador, Carlsen



Magnus Carlsen went unbeaten against elite opponents in his dominant run to win the Esports World Cup title.

had a tonne of commitments towards the event like fan meet-and-greets, press conferences, side events. But he chose to save energy and

didn't oblige to most of them, keeping his game the priority. Carlsen said, "My main thought leading into this tournament was that I was going to

"My main thought leading into this tournament was that I was going to be a lot more conservative with my choices. Especially considering the match format here."
MAGNUS CARLSEN
ON CONSERVING ENERGY.

be a lot more conservative with my choices. Especially considering the match format here. Obviously with feeling under the weather as well, following that path became a more obvious choice as well."

His recent performance at Norway Chess had raised questions about his form, his mental

space, and even his future. He lost an unprecedented four games, two of which came against the eventual champion, India's R Praggnanandhaa.

Motivation flux

Carlsen admitted that his motivation fluctuates, but he was firm in his belief that he was going to let a poor showing in Norway define his Paris campaign.

"Norway Chess was an unusual tournament in the sense that I lost the first round in a fair, fighting game against Alireza. It was a bit of trying to catch up after that. And I probably did some things there, played in ways that didn't necessarily optimise my chances. But I kind of wanted to create chances, and I ended up in a lot of positions which I'm not used to. And I got beaten a lot of times. And I made sure not to do the same things here, that's for sure. But

it's hard to compare completely because they're very different formats."

"However, I wasn't going to play poorly here because I played poorly in other tournaments. My motivation comes and goes a little bit at times. But for this one specifically, it's something that I've wanted to do for a long time. Enjoyed last year a lot, and I was always going to do everything in my power to win this one," he added.

Carlsen came to Paris sick, tired, and carrying the weight of expectation. He left with another trophy and the same quiet certainty that no one is catching him anytime soon. Or as he said, "This is certainly a very big title for me. It's something I've been thinking about for a long time, and I really, really wanted to get this one."

(The writer is in Paris at the invitation of the Esports Foundation)